



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

THE DRIVE FOR A THREE-PEAT

The Dodgers’ Miguel Rojas and Freddie Freeman hold the last two World Series trophies before the opener against Arizona, with actor Will Ferrell at the wheel. Scan this code for our coverage at latimes.com and in our eNewspaper, which contains an exclusive “Sports Extra.”



Trump weighs troops’ return to L.A.

He also discusses a federal presence in San Francisco. Actual plans aren’t known.

BY GAVIN J. QUINTON

WASHINGTON — When President Trump ordered immigration raids in Los Angeles in June, only a handful of those arrested were violent criminals. The sweeps split families, cost businesses millions of dollars and drove many undocumented residents into hiding.

Activists protested the Immigration and Customs Enforcement actions, prompting the president to deploy thousands of federal troops in what he called a security operation. A federal judge called it unlawful and said the deployment caused “greater harm” to the city.

Now, Trump wants a redo.

At a Cabinet meeting Thursday, he called on the mayors and governors of several blue cities and states to allow troops to “come in and stop the crime,” pointing to purported successes in Washington, New Orleans and Memphis, Tenn.

“Crime is down 75% in a short period of time,” Trump told his top advisors. “We could do that for L.A. and we could do that for, frankly, San Francisco.”

The president framed the deployments as both a crime-fighting and immigration enforcement tool, saying that federal authorities can remove people from cities in ways local officials cannot.

“We can do it much more effectively, because [local leaders] can’t do what we do,” Trump said. “All the time, people come up to me ... and they say ‘thank you so much.’ I know immediately what they’re talking about. They’re able to walk to work.”

Trump also said this week that he would consider deploying the National Guard at airports to assist with mounting security delays amid a 40-day partial

[See **Troops**, A6]

Culver City is a rising hot spot for business

Once seen as ‘a drive-through city,’ it has emerged as a magnet for firms and consumers

By Roger Vincent and Iris Kwok

Culver City, a once-quiet corner of L.A. County people would pass through on their way to somewhere else, has emerged as a destination of choice for some of the world’s best-known companies.

Apple, Amazon, TikTok, and Sony are just a few of the big names with a strong presence in the city of fewer than 40,000 residents, conveniently located between downtown L.A. and the beaches. Recently, they’ve been joined by Ikea, Pinterest and the company behind the Labubu dolls.

“We’re this little oasis in the midst of a megalopolis,” Mayor Freddy Puza said.

Pop Mart, the Chinese maker of the viral dolls, picked a location in Culver City for its headquarters in the U.S.

Michael Hackman, an independent studio owner who controls the building that Pop Mart is moving into, says he is inundated with calls from people excited that the company is coming to Culver City.

“We’re getting all these calls from people saying, ‘I have a daughter who is a huge fan,’ and ‘How can we get a Labubu doll?’” he said.

Swedish furniture giant Ikea said last month that it would open a store in the Helms Bakery complex that once produced bread. Although Ikea’s address will be in Los Angeles — most of the sprawling area now known as the Helms Design District is in L.A. — Ikea pointedly announced it

[See **Culver City**, A11]

Rethinking UFW history amid scandal

Allegations against César Chávez add to a reassessment that had already been brewing.

BY HANNAH FRY

For decades, Dolores Huerta told an inspiring story about the union she and César Chávez built and how it changed the lives of farmworkers.

The two activists famously formulated a plan for what would become the

United Farm Workers in a kitchen in Boyle Heights. They were partners in decades of labor battles, boycotts, protests and political alliances. Huerta said they didn’t always agree, but she and Chávez shared a mutual respect and obsessive sense of mission.

But over the last two weeks, portions of the UFW history have been rewritten, in large part through the words of Huerta herself.

She and others made sexual abuse allegations against Chávez that are adding to a reassessment of the

union that already had been underway — one that tries to deal with the failures and problems in ways the myths have not.

“What’s now being exposed is that the wheels had fallen off years before César Chávez died and for reasons that have to do with his megalomania, his bad decisions and the internal strife” inside union headquarters, said Matt Garcia, a professor of Latin American, Latino and Caribbean studies, history and social relations at Dartmouth.

It began with an inves-

tigative story in the New York Times that reported allegations that Chávez had sexually abused Huerta and two girls. In subsequent interviews, Huerta portrayed Chávez as an abusive, sexist bully who demeaned her and undermined her so much that at one point she left the UFW headquarters for several weeks.

“He had an evil side to him,” Huerta told ABC News.

The revelations have sparked a movement to remove Chávez’s name from

[See **UFW**, A8]

A call for force at anti-ICE protest

Attorney said agents in L.A. should have ‘just started hitting rioters,’ email shows.

BY ANDREA CASTILLO

WASHINGTON — A lead attorney for the Department of Homeland Security suggested that federal agents should have “just started hitting the rioters and arresting everyone that couldn’t get away” during an anti-ICE protest in Los Angeles last June, internal emails show.

The note was in an email chain obtained by the non-profit watchdog group American Oversight through the Freedom of Information Act and shared exclusively with The Times.

In it, attorneys for Homeland Security appear to be discussing the June 9 lawsuit filed by California Gov. Gavin Newsom over President Trump’s deployment of thousands of California National Guard troops to Los Angeles.

Under the subject line “California DOD Lawsuit,” officials coordinated legal filings defending the Trump administration and included a draft declaration by the Los Angeles field office director of Immigration and Customs Enforcement supporting the deployment of military forces.

The final email in the

[See **Force**, A6]

Iran ‘begging’ for deal, Trump says; war exit unclear

GOP lawmakers grow frustrated over a lack of strategy as Tehran rejects U.S. demands.

By Kevin Rector and Ana Ceballos

President Trump on Thursday continued projecting confidence in the U.S. war effort in Iran, suggesting online and during a high-level Cabinet meeting that Iran has been “obliterated,” that its leaders were “begging” for a deal, and that the U.S. is “roaming free” over Iran and “NEEDS NOTHING” from its European allies.

He also again delayed threatened U.S. attacks on Iranian power plants, based on talks that he said were going “very well.”

Trump’s description of the war as all but finished — he actually said “we’ve won” — stood in contrast to the facts on the ground, where Iran continued to launch attacks and threaten oil tanker traffic in the vital Strait of Hormuz, and the U.S. continued sending troops and warships to what is already the largest American military buildup in the Middle East in decades.

The president’s framing of the conflict also con-

trasted with that of Iranian officials, who have remained publicly defiant, downplayed negotiations and rejected several of his conditions for ending the war — as Trump has acknowledged, accusing them of saying one thing in private and another in public.

“They better get serious soon, before it is too late,” the president wrote on social media, “because once that happens, there is NO TURNING BACK, and it won’t be pretty.”

“They are begging to make a deal, not me,” Trump reiterated later Thursday, while hosting his first Cabinet meeting since the war began.

The president asserted that Iran’s military capabilities have been destroyed, and that the American mission is “ahead of schedule.” He said American forces were operating without opposition over Iran, and “there’s not a damn thing they can do about it” because they’ve been “beat to s—.”

He said that Iranian officials had requested he hold off on power plant attacks threatened for Friday as talks continued, and that he had agreed to wait 10 more days, until April 6.

Trump’s outward confidence, a defining feature of

[See **Iran**, A3]



CHIP SOMODEVILLA Getty Images

DESPITE President Trump’s confidence in the U.S. war effort, Iran has continued to launch attacks.

Man nearly sealed into city storm drain

By Fedor Zarkhin and Allen J. Schaben

City crews were on the verge of welding a manhole cover shut in South Los Angeles on Wednesday morning when a surprise discovery stopped them in their tracks.

“Hey, there’s someone down there,” said one of the workers in a reflective yellow vest. He pointed to the storm drain at West 88th Street and South Grand Avenue.

Seconds later, a man in his late 20s climbed out of the darkness, carrying with him a pink polka dot roller suitcase. He walked away



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

WORKERS in South L.A. were about to weld a manhole cover shut when a man emerged with a suitcase.

Oscars will move to a new venue

Starting in 2029, the ceremony will be held downtown at L.A. Live. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Deputy’s widow files legal claim

Detective slain by a grenade wasn’t formally trained on the device, she says. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Sony and Honda scrap car venture

Companies withdraw plans for a gadget-filled EV priced at \$100,000. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 80/59. **B6**

Markets

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THE WORLD



NICOLAS ECONOMOU NurPhoto

A RUBBER boat with migrants leaves the French coast for the English Channel.

EU lawmakers vote to make deporting migrants easier

By SAM McNEIL

BRUSSELS — European lawmakers voted Thursday to ease the setting up of new migrant detention centers outside the European Union, known as “return hubs.”

Members of the European Parliament voted 389 to 206 in favor, with 32 abstentions. Right-wing parties made an alliance with far-right groups that they had previously shunned to pass the measure, while parties of the left and center voted against.

Any EU nation can now negotiate on its own or in small coalitions to deport migrants not to their home countries but to facilities yet to be built outside the 27-nation bloc.

Already, Greece, Germany, the Netherlands, Austria and Denmark have entered into negotiations with governments mainly in Africa to host sites to hold mi-

grants denied asylum.

Far-right parties in Europe have praised the deportation policies of President Trump and have called for the EU to adopt a similar approach.

Belgium’s far-right Vlaams Belang party and Germany’s far-right AfD party both said in January that they want to form a police group focused on finding and deporting migrants akin to U.S. efforts.

Charlie Weimers, a lawmaker from the right-wing Sweden Democrats and strong proponent of harsher migration policies, said Thursday’s vote heralds a new era in the EU.

“There is a new consensus in Europe. The era of deportations has begun,” he said in a social media post.

However, human rights groups say migrants are being brutalized and pushed back illegally at EU borders, and legal protections are being hollowed out.

Marta Welander, EU ad-

vocacy director for the International Rescue Committee, said the vote was “a historic setback for refugee rights.”

She warned it would “pave the way towards a new punitive EU asylum and migration regime, designed to deter, detain and deport people seeking safety. The EU should stand for a system that protects lives, not one that criminalizes survival.”

French lawmaker Mélissa Camara, who voted against the measure, said it passed only by centrist groups allying with the far-right.

“History will remember that the so-called moderate right-wing group sounded the death knell of what remained of the cordon sanitaire,” said Camara, who said “return hubs” are places far from Europe “where fundamental rights cannot be effectively monitored.”

McNeil writes for the Associated Press.

Costa Rica will accept more U.S. deportees

Nation agrees to take 25 per week under the ‘third country’ policy pushed by Trump.

By JAVIER CÓRDOBA AND MEGAN JANETSKY

SAN JOSÉ, Costa Rica — Costa Rica said Thursday that it would accept 25 migrants deported from the United States per week as part of an agreement to help the Trump administration’s latest policy of deporting immigrants to “third countries.”

The Central American nation joins a growing number of countries across Africa and the Americas that have signed contentious, often secretive agreements with the U.S. to accept deportees from other countries as President Trump pressures governments to help him advance his agenda. In many cases, migrants who had hoped to seek asylum in the U.S. are left in a legal “black hole” in foreign countries where they don’t speak the language.

Countries that have agreed to receive third-party migrants include South Sudan, Honduras, Rwanda, Guyana, and several Caribbean islands such as Dominica and St. Kitts and Nevis.

“Costa Rica is prepared to see this flow of people,” said Costa Rican Public Security Minister Mario Zamora Cordero in a video statement on Thursday.

Costa Rica’s government signed the pact on Monday during a visit by U.S. special envoy for the so-called Shield of the Americas Kristi Noem to Costa Rica. Noem, who was fired earlier this month from her role as sec-

retary of Homeland Security, has been traveling through Latin America, with recent stops in Guyana and Ecuador.

“We are very proud to have partners like President [Rodrigo Chaves Robles] and Costa Rica, who are working to ensure that people who are in our country illegally have the opportunity to return to their countries of origin,” Noem said on Monday.

Costa Rica’s government called the pact a “non-binding migration agreement” and said that the deal allows the Trump administration to transfer foreign nationals — who are not Costa Rican citizens — and that the Central American nation can accept or reject proposed transfers.

The government said that the deportees will be processed under Costa Rica’s migration laws under a special migratory status and that the country will avoid returning people to countries where they might face risk of persecution.

Such transfers have been sharply criticized for putting vulnerable populations further at risk and in some cases sending them to dangerous nations or where they face risk. Costa Rica has already faced controversy for its treatment of 200 deportees from countries such as Russia, China, Uzbekistan and Afghanistan it received last year.

Deportees, half of whom were minors, had their passports seized and were locked up for months in a rural detention facility near the Panamanian border, an incident that fueled lawsuits and accusations of human rights abuses. The country’s supreme court ordered their release last June.

Many deportees who said they were too scared to return to their country were later given temporary permits to stay in Costa Rica. Panama, which locked up hundreds of deportees around the same time, came under similar criticism.

Zamora on Thursday made assurances that the new round of deportees would be held in better conditions, and that the government would work with the U.S. to return migrants to their countries and with the U.N. International Organization for Migration to house deportees in Costa Rica. He didn’t immediately detail where they would be held or for how long.

“This will ensure they remain in the best possible conditions while in Costa Rica and guarantee their safe return to their countries of origin,” Zamora said.

At least seven African nations have signed deals with the U.S. to facilitate deportations of third-country nationals, which legal experts said are effectively a way to circumvent laws that forbid countries from sending people to places where their lives would be threatened.

Many deportees received legal protection from U.S. judges shielding them against being returned to their home countries, their lawyers said.

The Trump administration has spent at least \$40 million to deport about 300 migrants to countries other than their own, according to a February report by the Democratic staff of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee.

Córdoba and Janetsky write for the Associated Press. Janetsky reported from Mexico City.

Russia seizes on Mideast conflict to launch spring offensive

By BARRY HATTON

The Iran war has deflected global attention from Russia’s all-out invasion of its neighbor Ukraine as Europe’s biggest conflict since World War II enters its fifth year and an emboldened Kremlin undertakes a spring offensive.

The last week showed that neither side is easing up. Russia on Tuesday fired almost 1,000 drones and 34

missiles at Ukraine in one of the war’s biggest bombardments. The following day Ukraine launched almost 400 drones in the largest reported overnight attack on Russian regions and Crimea.

Ukraine’s fate is still Europe’s top foreign policy issue, fueled by fears that Moscow has wider ambitions. Meanwhile, the Trump administration has wound down talks with Russian and Ukrainian delega-

tions as the Iran war grips its attention. The administration has warned it could turn its back on the conflict if peace efforts come to nothing.

Only weeks ago, the Russian economy was starting to feel the pinch of sanctions. But Russia is now raking in billions of dollars from a temporary U.S. waiver on oil sanctions against Moscow. The measure taken this month aims to free up Russian oil cargo stranded at sea and ease supply shortages caused by the Middle East conflict.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky said the U.S. move was “not the right decision” because it will further enable Russia’s military campaign.

American Patriot air-defense missiles have been moved from Europe toward the Middle East as Washington redirects resources to its war on Iran. Zelensky warned that Kyiv will “definitely” face shortages of Patriot systems because of the war against Iran.

The U.S. produces 60 to 65 missiles per month, or about 700 to 800 missiles per year, Zelensky said. “And on the first day in the Middle East war, 803 missiles were used,” he said.

Aiming to secure some geopolitical leverage, Ukraine offered its battle-tested technology to help Persian Gulf states fend off Iranian drones. In return, Ukraine wants more of the high-end air-defense missiles that gulf countries possess and which Kyiv needs to stop Russia’s missiles. Zelensky also made Ukrainian drone interceptors available to the U.S.

Ukraine desperately needs money as well. A promised \$104-billion loan from the European Union to fund Ukraine’s armed forces and its war-shattered economy for the next two years is being held up by Hungary. After a winter of relative



DANYIL NIKOLAENKO Suspiline Ukraine

A UKRAINIAN firefighter near a building in Dnipro that was hit on Thursday.

calm on the front line, Russia is gearing up for the summer fighting season as fields dry out.

Russian forces are in an early phase of a spring offensive, assaulting Ukraine’s eastern so-called Fortress Belt of cities, said Elina Becketova of the Center for European Policy Analysis, a Washington-based think tank.

“Over the past weeks, the Russians have intensified pressure on the battlefield and in the air,” she told the Associated Press. In the eastern region of Donbas, Ukraine’s industrial heartland long coveted by Russian President Vladimir Putin, the situation is “critical,” she said, though Ukrainian troops say they are holding firm.

“Russia is trying, on the tactical level, some new approaches” with mechanized infantry and armor in its offensive, according to Robert Murrett, a retired vice admiral in the U.S. Navy who is deputy director of Syracuse University’s Institute for Security Policy and Law.

Fierce fighting is taking place along the roughly 750-mile front line snaking along eastern and southern parts

of Ukraine, the commander in chief of Ukraine’s armed forces, Gen. Oleksandr Syrskyi, said this week.

Moscow’s forces have made only incremental gains across rural areas. Russia occupies about 20% of Ukraine. That includes the Crimean peninsula, which Russia seized in 2014.

Russian war bloggers expect a new Moscow effort to create more footholds in the southern Zaporizhzhia and Dnipropetrovsk regions. That would pave the way for a possible push toward those regions’ capital cities, which are key industrial hubs.

The Russian tactic is to surround and then choke cities while bombing them to rubble.

After crushing Ukraine’s power grid during one of the worst winters in recent memory, Russian drone and missile barrages of civilian areas have continued unabated.

More than 15,000 Ukrainian civilians have been killed in the war, according to the U.N. Human Rights Monitoring Mission in Ukraine.

For its part, Ukraine has developed long-range drones and missiles to hit

targets in rear areas that keep Moscow’s war machine going. The targets have included oil refineries, chemical plants, ammunition depots and military logistics hubs up to 900 miles from Ukraine.

Washington’s peace efforts are largely on hold while the White House is “totally distracted by Iran,” Murrett said.

Months of U.S.-mediated talks between delegations from Moscow and Kyiv have produced no breakthrough on the knottiest problems, such as who keeps Ukrainian territory and how to prevent future Russian invasions.

Russia has rejected Ukraine’s offer of a ceasefire. European leaders have accused Putin of stalling in peace efforts while his army tries to capture more Ukrainian land.

The Kremlin has “never come off [its] maximalist demands” for a settlement, and it would take “overwhelming” Western military and financial support for Ukraine for Putin to back down, Murrett said.

Hatton writes for the Associated Press.

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Beach town becomes Lebanon’s last refuge

The city has room for the newly displaced, but catastrophe could be a bombing away.

By NABIH BULOS

TYRE, Lebanon — Whatever choices Hassan Kareet had left were all bad.

Israeli bombardment, not to mention the threat of an invasion, meant Kareet couldn’t stay in the village of Bazourieh, some 11 miles from Lebanon’s border with Israel.

But finding a place to stay in a country where an estimated 1.3 million people are already displaced was impossibly difficult as the war between Israel and Hezbollah intensifies.

Shelters were full, and landlords were demanding — and getting — exorbitant rents and advance payments that Kareet, who owns a pet shop specializing in birds, simply couldn’t afford.

Desperate, he brought his family to Tyre. It too was under Israeli evacuation orders, but at least there were places to stay for his wife and four children. And when things felt too crowded, they could escape here to Tyre’s public park, where Kareet’s 5-year-old son, Ali, was playing on a slide.

“We’re scattered: some in one school, others in another shelter. I slept in the car,” Kareet said, keeping one eye on Ali and another on the sky for the Israeli warplane he could hear prowling above.

Another advantage to being here: Tyre was close enough to Bazourieh that he could go and feed the 60 birds he owns.

“I can’t release them. They wouldn’t survive, and besides, we just got new hatchlings,” he said. Yes, he was afraid of an Israeli attack, he added, but, “What should I do? I can’t just let them die.”

Tyre, the country’s fifth-largest city and a normally bustling beach town with postcard-perfect views of the Mediterranean, has become a sanctuary of last resort even as the specter of a long-term Israeli occupation



AFP/Getty Images

SMOKE billows from the site of an Israeli artillery attack in a village in southern Lebanon on Wednesday.

looms over south Lebanon.

In recent days, the Israeli military bombed bridges around Tyre, which lies 12 miles north of the Israeli border, almost cutting it off from the rest of the country.

But around 20,000 people — roughly 16,000 displaced from nearby towns and villages, along with 4,000 of the city’s residents — remain, according to government officials. Before the war, the city population was 60,000.

“Where else can I go? The first night we left, we ended up sleeping on the seafront corniche in Sidon. I won’t do that again,” said Atallah, 52, sitting in the shade of a tree with his son, brother and sister-in-law.

He referred to the city of Sidon, 22 miles up the coast from Tyre and out of the area Israel says it will occupy, which extends around 20 miles from the border and encompasses a tenth of Lebanon’s territory. Atallah and his family members did not give their full name for fear of harassment.

Although the Israeli military issued multiple bomb warnings that day for Tyre,

including a strike that was less than a mile from the park, Atallah couldn’t stay cooped up in the makeshift shelter in a nearby school, where his family was sharing a classroom with three other families.

“I would have stayed in my village, but I couldn’t leave them,” he said, gesturing toward his son, Mohammad, who has Down syndrome and was burying his face in Atallah’s stomach as the warplane roared above.

Moments later, a bass thump sounded in the distance. Atallah walked to get a clearer view of the telltale plume of smoke indicating where a bomb or missile had hit; the whole way, Mohammad clung to Atallah’s leg.

War returned to Lebanon on March 2 when the Iran-backed Lebanese Shiite militant group Hezbollah launched rockets on Israel to avenge the death of Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, killed when Israel and the U.S. attacked Iran on Feb. 28.

Hezbollah also was retaliating for near-daily Israeli attacks despite a ceasefire

agreement reached 15 months ago.

Israel responded with a blistering assault that has stunned Lebanon with the scope of its destruction. So far, almost 1,100 have been killed and a quarter of the country’s population displaced, authorities say.

This week, Israel said that its troops will invade a swath of south Lebanon to create a “defensive buffer zone,” and that no residents could return until northern Israel was secure. The Israeli defense minister also said the military would apply the “Gaza model” to parts of south Lebanon, meaning that entire villages and towns would be razed and residents permanently uprooted.

The announcement raised fears about the long-term effects of the Israeli offensive.

“This is not a short shock. ... The crisis is no longer only about where people sleep tonight, but how they will live, eat, and access health-care in the weeks ahead,” wrote Firass Abiad, who served as Lebanon’s health

minister until 2025, in a post on X on Tuesday.

“Resources that were already barely sufficient for the poorest will now have to stretch even further.”

Randa, Atallah’s sister-in-law, said Israel’s announcement that it would invade had only increased her determination to stay. Though she was not part of Hezbollah, she, like many others interviewed in Tyre, supported the group.

“I left to another part of Lebanon the last war and I regretted it. I won’t make the same mistake, and I trust the men who are fighting the Israelis,” she said.

It wouldn’t be the first time Alwan Charafeddine, Tyre’s deputy mayor, experienced Israeli incursions.

The earliest one Charafeddine remembers was when Israel invaded Lebanon in 1982; he was 9 years old, and the family escaped at 3 a.m. just as the bombs were falling near their home in Tyre. With a detached air, he counted off other bouts of displacement: in 1996, 2000, 2001 and 2006.

“Us and our kids, we’re generations of war,” he said, adding that even people who don’t support Hezbollah would fight if the Israeli military invaded Tyre.

The municipality’s main problem for the moment, Charafeddine said, was that only one crossing into Tyre survives, a narrow bridge on the old coastal road. Even now, aid organizations were reluctant to deliver into the city for fear of getting stuck, he said.

“If they take out the last bridge and nothing can come in, it’s going to be a catastrophe,” he said.

Most of the displaced are now sardined in the city’s quaint Old Quarter, which lies on a promontory jutting out of Tyre’s northernmost tip and is excluded from the evacuation order.

On an unseasonably warm afternoon, families flocked to the waterfront, sunning themselves before an azure-blue Mediterranean. Some tried to continue their routine, walking their dogs or jogging by the sea.

One person seemingly determined to ignore the war was Adnan Abdo, a Syrian Kurd who worked as a farmhand in Tyre. As the sea lapped around him, he balanced himself on a rock and cast a fishing line into the sea.

He was the victim of multiple conflicts, he said: Tensions against Kurds in Syria meant he didn’t feel safe going home, and with even Lebanese having a hard time, there was little hope of him finding a place for his wife and two kids to stay elsewhere in Lebanon.

Besides, Israel was striking in areas well beyond Hezbollah’s traditional areas of support, so nowhere was safe. His family was staying in one of Tyre’s churches.

For now, he was enjoying the chance to fish. He had already caught several, and a tug of resistance on the line hinted he would get another.

Around him, people looked upward, searching for the warplane. But he kept his eyes on the sea.

“What can I do about that plane anyway? Nothing,” Abdo said, before he drew in another fish.

Lawmakers demand clear picture of war exit

[Iran, from A1] the war consistently echoed by Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and other administration loyalists, continued despite growing concerns this week in Congress — and not only from Democrats.

Several Republicans emerged from a classified war briefing Wednesday clearly frustrated with the administration for not providing a clearer picture of the path out of the now monthlong war, or clear answers on whether it planned to deploy ground troops.

“We’re just not getting enough answers,” said Rep. Mike Rogers (R-Ala.), chairman of the House Armed Services Committee.

“I can see why he might have said that,” said Sen. Roger Wicker (R-Miss.), chairman of the Senate Armed Services Committee.

Democrats have hammered the president over the war’s massive budget and death toll.

“Thirteen American lives lost and tens of billions of taxpayer dollars spent in just three weeks since Donald Trump plunged us into war without congressional authorization. There is still no plan, no clear justification, and no end in sight,” Sen. Alex Padilla (D-Calif.) said.

For weeks, Trump, Hegseth and other war leaders have focused on U.S. wins in the conflict — tallying up Iran’s sunken ships and grounded planes, assassinated leaders and undermined missile capabilities.

In recent days, Trump has suggested that, because of those wins, Iran is buckling. He has said the U.S. is pushing a 15-point plan that will forever block Iran from developing a nuclear weapon or threatening the U.S. or its allies. And he and others in his administration have accused the media of ignoring battlefield wins to harp on losses instead.

Israel, America’s major partner in the conflict, has projected similar confidence while showing no signs of slowing its attacks on Iran. On Thursday it announced



ODD ANDERSEN AFP/Getty Images

IRAN continues to strike Israel. In Jerusalem, troops mourn a soldier Thursday.

that it had killed several senior Iranian naval commanders, including Commodore Alireza Tangsiri, the head of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps’ navy.

Israeli Defense Minister Israel Katz said the deaths should send a “clear message” that Israel will continue to hunt down top Iranian military officials. Iran did not immediately acknowledge Tangsiri’s death.

The head of U.S. Central Command, Adm. Brad Cooper, praised Tangsiri’s killing. He said U.S. strikes would continue, and called on Iranian fighters to “immediately abandon their post and return home to avoid further risk of unnecessary injury or death.”

Meanwhile, death, destruction and environmental and economic damage from the war spread far beyond Iran, where officials recently raised their estimated death toll to nearly 2,000.

Israel was fighting off a barrage of incoming missiles Thursday, with booms heard in Tel Aviv and Jerusalem and an impact reported in the central town of Kafr Qassem. Israel was also continuing its offensive against the militant group Hezbollah in Lebanon,

where the death toll had risen to 1,116, Lebanon’s Health Ministry said Thursday.

Iraqi Defense Ministry spokesman Maj. Gen. Tahsin al Khafaj on Thursday said 23 people had been wounded in a Wednesday strike on a military clinic in western Iraq’s Anbar province.

Thousands of additional U.S. troops are on their way to the region, even as many of the tens of thousands already stationed there have had to move into hotels and other temporary housing — diminishing their war-fighting capabilities — after being displaced by ongoing Iranian attacks that have left the 13 regional military bases they call home “all but uninhabitable,” the New York Times reported.

Jasem Mohamed al-Budaiwi, the secretary-general of the Gulf Cooperation Council, accused Iran of charging fees for ships to safely transit the Strait of Hormuz, continuing the economic toll on global oil supplies. Environmental experts warned of massive pollution from burning oil and gas fields.

France’s Defense Ministry said Thursday that nearly three dozen countries had joined military talks

about how to reopen the strait “once the intensity of hostilities has sufficiently decreased.”

Russia, emboldened by the Iran war, which has drawn resources away from Ukraine and led the U.S. to ease sanctions on Russian oil, has launched a renewed spring offensive against Ukraine.

Many allies have largely stayed out of the conflict despite Trump vacillating between demanding their help and insisting it isn’t necessary.

In one of his social media posts Thursday morning, Trump blasted allies in the North Atlantic Treaty Organization for having “DONE ABSOLUTELY NOTHING TO HELP” in the conflict, and said the U.S. would “never forget.”

Asked during his Cabinet meeting about his desire to end the war soon, Trump said he was “the opposite of desperate” — “I don’t care,” he said — and that there “are other targets that we want to hit before we leave.”

Trump said that when the “right deal” is made with Iran, the Strait of Hormuz will reopen — while insisting that Iran no longer has any “mine droppers” that would threaten merchant vessels

passing through the key oil route.

Steve Witkoff, one of Trump’s top advisors leading negotiations in the Middle East, said that the Iranians were looking for an “off-ramp,” that Pakistan is serving as a mediator between Washington and Tehran, and that the 15-point plan Trump had mentioned “forms the framework for a peace deal.”

“We will see where things lead and if we can convince Iran that this is the inflection point, with no good alternatives for them other than more death and destruction.”

Trump has declined to say whom Washington is negotiating with in Iran but described them as “very smart,” “not fools,” and “very lousy fighters, but great negotiators.”

He also said he knows they are “the right people” for the U.S. to be dealing with because they had given him a “present” — and proved they are in control — by allowing a total of 10 boats of oil to travel through the strait this week. He did not provide details.

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said he is confident that more merchant vessels will soon be able to safely pass through the Strait of Hormuz, and energy prices will drop when the war ends.

“Many people, especially the Democrats, underestimate the will of the American people for short-term volatility for 50 years of safety that we are going to have on the other side of this,” Bessent said.

Hegseth repeatedly slammed the media for framing the war effort as floundering or unfocused.

He said that Iranian officials in private are acknowledging “very heavy losses,” and that the U.S. and the world are benefiting from having Trump, whom he called the “ultimate deal-maker,” working toward a peace agreement.

In the meantime, Hegseth said, the U.S. military will “continue negotiating with bombs.”

2 are out on bail in arson in London

ASSOCIATED PRESS

LONDON — British police said Thursday that two men arrested in connection with an arson attack that destroyed four ambulances owned by a Jewish charity have been released on bail as they continue to investigate the suspected antisemitic hate crime.

The British nationals, ages 45 and 47, were detained Wednesday on suspicion of arson with intent to endanger life, London’s Metropolitan Police Service said in a statement. The men were released under strict bail conditions and will be closely monitored, police said.

Authorities on Wednesday described the arrests as an important breakthrough in the case but noted that three people were visible in the closed-circuit camera footage of the attack.

“We continue to work to try and identify all of those involved in this appalling attack and the investigation team is working around the clock to do this,” said Cmdr. Helen Flanagan, head of Counter Terrorism Policing London.

Police are investigating a claim of responsibility by a group with potential links to Iran but have not declared the matter to be a terrorist attack.

The blaze early on Monday morning in Golders Green, a London neighborhood with a large Jewish population, destroyed four ambulances belonging to the volunteer organization Hatzoa Northwest, which provides emergency care to residents of the area. Oxygen cylinders in the vehicles exploded, breaking windows in an adjacent apartment block.

THE NATION

Trump could invoke a TSA national emergency

The action would be politically fraught. Meanwhile, senators weigh ‘final’ offer.

By LISA MASCARO AND KEVIN FREKING

WASHINGTON — With pressure mounting, the White House floated the extraordinary move Thursday of invoking a national emergency to pay Transportation Security Administration workers while senators reviewed a “last and final” offer to end the funding impasse that has jammed airports and disrupted travel.

Democrats have been refusing to fund the Department of Homeland Security as they demand changes to rein in President Trump’s immigration enforcement operations. Trump during an event at the White House warned he would step in if Congress failed to act.

The Senate came to a standstill and senators, ready to leave town for their own spring break, prepared to stay all night to reach a deal.

“Enough is enough,” Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-S.D.) said as he announced he had given the final offer to the Democrats.

Thune did not disclose details of the new framework, but he said that it picked up on what had been the Republican offer over the weekend, before talks with the White House and Democrats had broken off.

“Hopefully ... there will be some finality in this real soon,” Thune said.

The shutdown of funding for the Department of Homeland Security, now in its 41st day, has resulted in travel disruptions, missed paychecks and even warnings of airport closures. TSA workers are coming up on their second missed paycheck Friday, with thousands refusing to show up for work.

Multiple airports are experiencing greater than 40% call-out rates of TSA workers, and nearly 500 of the nearly 50,000 transportation security officers have quit



MEGAN VARNER Getty Images

ICE AGENTS screen IDs at an airport checkpoint in Atlanta amid a staffing crisis as TSA workers go unpaid.

during the shutdown. Nationwide on Wednesday, more than 11% of the TSA employees on the schedule missed work, according to Homeland Security. That is more than 3,120 callouts.

Trump, who has largely left the issue to Congress to resolve, threatened to send the National Guard to airports, in addition to his deployment of ICE agents who are now checking travelers’ IDs — a development that is drawing concerns.

The White House is considering a menu of options, including declaring a national emergency to pay the TSA workers, a move that would be politically fraught and almost certain to face legal challenges.

“They need to end this shutdown immediately or we’ll have to take drastic measures,” Trump said Thursday during a Cabinet meeting at the White House.

At George Bush Intercontinental Airport in Houston, Melissa Gates said she

would not make her flight to Baton Rouge, La., after waiting 2½ hours and still not reaching the security checkpoint. She said no other flights were available until Friday.

“I should have just driven, right?” Gates said. “Five hours would have been hilarious next to this.”

A ‘last and final’ offer on the table

Senators retreated to privately discuss the latest offer as a core group of more than 10 senators, Democrats and Republicans, worked to hammer out the details.

“I think we all realize we’re not going anywhere until this is done,” said Sen. Mark Warner (D-Va.).

Democrats argue that the GOP proposals have not gone far enough at putting guardrails on officers from ICE, Customs and Border Protection and other federal agencies who are engaged in the immigration sweeps,

particularly after the deaths of two Americans protesting the actions in Minneapolis. They want federal agents to wear identification, remove their face masks and refrain from conducting raids around schools, churches and other sensitive places.

Republicans said after a private lunch meeting that there were other options than invoking the national emergency.

“The president may well decide that, but I don’t know,” said Sen. Susan Collins (R-Maine), the chair of the Appropriations Committee, who said there was funding elsewhere that can be legally used to pay TSA as well as the Coast Guard.

Over the weekend, talks with the White House, including with border advisor Tom Homan, appeared to be making progress toward a deal, including on several items Democrats had been demanding, such as the IDs and limits on raids at sensitive places.

Senate Democratic leader Chuck Schumer of New York said they needed to see real changes. “We’ve been talking about ICE reforms from Day 1,” he said.

Any deal will almost certainly need to involve a compromise as lawmakers on the left and right flanks revolt. Conservative Republicans have panned their own GOP proposals, demanding full funding for immigration operations and expressing skepticism of the promise from leaders that they would address Trump’s proof-of-citizenship voting bill in a subsequent legislative package.

Trump stays out of the fray

Trump did not directly address the status of negotiations late Wednesday evening during an annual fundraising dinner for the House Republicans’ campaign committee. On Thursday, the president revived his

campaign for senators to end the filibuster as a way to overpower opposition to GOP policies, something most Republican senators do not want to do.

The GOP’s big tax cuts bill that Trump signed into law last year funneled billions to Homeland Security, including \$75 billion for ICE operations, ensuring the money is flowing for his immigration and deportation agenda even with the funding shutdown. ICE and other immigration officers are still being paid.

Republicans say the Trump administration has already made strides to meet Democrats’ demands, particularly after swearing in Oklahoma Sen. Markwayne Mullin as the new Homeland Security secretary to replace Kristi Noem.

TSA workers endure hardships

“This is a dire situation,” the acting TSA administrator, Ha Nguyen McNeill, testified at a House hearing Wednesday.

She described the multiple hardships facing unpaid TSA workers — who are accruing bills and eviction notices, and even resorting to plasma donations to make ends meet — and warned of potential airport closures if more employees refuse to come to work.

“At this point, we have to look at all options on the table,” she said.

McNeill also said TSA officers working at the nation’s airports have experienced a more than 500% increase in the frequency of assaults since the shutdown began.

“This is unacceptable,” McNeill said.

Mascaro and Freking write for the Associated Press. AP writers Joey Cappelletti, Mary Clare Jalonick, Rebecca Santana and Ben Finley in Washington; Lekan Oyekanmi in Houston; Wyattte Grantham-Philips in New York; Rio Yamat in Las Vegas; Russ Bynum in Savannah, Ga., and Gabriela Aoun Angueira in San Diego contributed to this report.

Officers share how they survive without paychecks

By PHILIP MARCELO, OBED LAMY AND RIO YAMAT

A woman in Indiana who put off dental surgery because she doesn’t know if she can afford the copay. A Florida couple with young children who are depleting their savings. A grandmother in Idaho who plans to sell her car to pay the rent.

They are among about 50,000 Transportation Security Administration officers expecting to receive another \$0 paycheck this week. A dispute in Congress over funding the Department of Homeland Security has held up their salaries since mid-February. With monthly bills coming due, many of these federal employees, who screen passengers and luggage at airports across the U.S., are making difficult choices about how to make ends meet.

High absentee rates at some major airports have produced long lines and frustrated passengers at understaffed security checkpoints. Union leaders and federal officials say empty gas tanks, child-care expenses and the threat of eviction keep more screeners from showing up the longer the shutdown continues. At last count, more than 455 had quit instead of weathering the ongoing uncertainty, according to Homeland Security.

“Stop asking me about the long lines. Ask me if somebody’s gonna eat today,” Hydrick Thomas, president of the national American Federation of Government Employees union council that represents TSA employees, told reporters Tuesday.

Turning to food pantry in Indiana

Before starting her shift at Indianapolis International Airport on Monday, Taylor Desert stopped at a



MICHAEL CONROY Associated Press

TAYLOR Desert at Gleaners Food Bank in Indianapolis. She was last paid Feb. 14.

food bank for meat, eggs, vegetables and dairy products.

“I never thought I would be in a position where, working for the federal government, I would need to go to a food bank to supplement my groceries,” she said as she loaded bags into her car.

Desert, who has been a TSA officer for seven years, said her last full paycheck came on Feb. 14, the day the shutdown started.

She had some savings to draw on despite a record 43-day shutdown last fall but put some personal plans on pause.

For example, Desert needs to get her wisdom teeth removed but says the TSA isn’t approving time off during the shutdown. She also worries about costs from the surgery not covered by insurance.

Wednesday was the 39th day of the Homeland Security funding lapse. If it goes another 21 days, Desert said she would seek another job.

“I don’t want to have to spend my entire savings just to afford to keep living,” she said.

Florida couple worries for kids

Oksana Kelly, 38, and her husband, Deron, 37, both work as TSA agents at Orlando International Airport. They have two young children and don’t know how they will keep supporting their family without any income coming in.

Kelly said they’re dipping into savings for now, but it’s running dry. If the shutdown persists, they will ask relatives for help or take out a loan, which she worries would put them deeper in debt.

Her husband has worked as a DoorDash delivery driver in his spare time since the shutdown in October and November. He’s considered resigning from the TSA to put the couple on more stable financial footing.

“It’s very mentally exhausting,” said Kelly, who is an organizer for the labor union representing TSA workers across central and northern Florida. “How do we even decide between being able to feed our kids or come to work?”

Kelly said strangers might criticize the couple for “putting all eggs in one basket” since both have chosen to work for the TSA for the last decade.

“All we want is to pay our bills and get the pay we deserve,” she said.

Idaho grandmother fears losing home

Rebecca Wolf cries every day. She tries to hide it from her grandchildren, ages 11 and 6.

“They don’t understand why Grandma’s crying,” Wolf said. “I try not to cry in front of them, but sometimes it’s just too much.”

The 53-year-old TSA officer and union leader in Boise, Idaho, joined the agency soon after its creation in the wake of the Sept. 11 attacks. She was homeless at the time but turned her situation around with steady work and the benefits of federal employment.

Now, Wolf can’t help but dwell on where she was 24 years ago. “I don’t want to be in that position again,” she said.

Her Feb. 28 paycheck amounted to \$13.53, sending her “into a spiral right away.”

With no savings to fall back on, she is preparing to sell her car to cover her rent due in a week. She calls non-profits daily seeking rental assistance but hasn’t had any luck.

Supporting six family members — four children and two grandchildren — has always been challenging, but the repeated shutdowns have made it nearly unsustainable.

Wolf, who serves as president of AFGE TSA Local 1127, is hesitant to walk away from both the job that turned her life around and her role advocating for fellow officers.

“I worked hard to get to where I am now, and the thought I might lose it all scares me,” she said, her voice breaking as she tried to stifle the sound of weeping.

Dipping into savings in Massachusetts

Mike Gayzagian, a TSA officer at Boston’s Logan International Airport, says long stretches without pay have become enough of a “new normal” that he’s prepared for them.

The 56-year-old says he has a financial cushion of about six months to tap but that his situation is “an exception to the rule.”

“The majority live paycheck to paycheck and don’t have those kinds of reserves available,” said Gayzagian, who is president of his local TSA union chapter.

It shouldn’t be this way for federal workers, he said.

“The financial situation adds an additional burden to what is already a stressful job,” Gayzagian said. “I didn’t go into public service to make a lot of money. I went into public service because it has a certain stability and reliability and predictability that other jobs don’t have.”

A father in Utah leaves the agency

Robert Echeverria quit his job as a TSA agent at Utah’s Salt Lake City International Airport about two weeks into the current shutdown.

The 45-year-old, who has a wife and three children, counted five government shutdowns in the nine years he worked for the agency.

The toughest was last year’s record shutdown that ended in mid-November around the start of the holiday season. Echeverria said his family skipped Christmas and took months to recover financially.

He began looking for a new job in February when it became clear Congress was headed for another budget battle.

“Emotionally I was already distraught,” Echeverria said last week. “We were barely recovering from the last shutdown.”

He now works for the department that manages the airports in Utah’s capital. Leaving federal service “was a hard decision for me,” Echeverria said.

“I really believed in the mission of the TSA,” he said. “We took an oath, and it was a way for me to give back to the country that gave me so much.”

He’s still based at Salt Lake City International, where his 20-year-old daughter works as a TSA agent, and says that seeing his former colleagues struggling is difficult.

“They all feel betrayed by their government because they’re showing up to work,” Echeverria said. “They’re there, but they feel that the government doesn’t care for them,” he said.

Marcelo, Lamy and Yamat write for the Associated Press. Marcelo reported from New York, Lamy from Indianapolis and Yamat from Las Vegas.

Maduro, wife back in court in New York

Lawyer argues against U.S. blocking funds for the Venezuelan leader's legal costs.

By MICHAEL R. SISAK, JENNIFER PELTZ AND REGINA GARCIA CANO

NEW YORK — Former Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro and his wife were back in a New York courtroom Thursday as they seek to have their drug trafficking indictments thrown out over a geopolitical dispute over legal fees.

The hearing opened with the defense and prosecution arguing over whether Maduro should be allowed to use Venezuelan government funds to pay for his defense. The defense has insisted that the U.S. is violating the deposed leader's constitutional rights by blocking government money from being used for his legal costs.

Maduro lawyer Barry Pollack contended that if Maduro had public defenders, investigating and preparing his case would sap legal resources meant for people who can't afford their own attorneys, and that doesn't make sense in "a case where you have someone other than the U.S. taxpayer standing ready, willing and able to fund that defense."

Prosecutor Kyle Wirshba argued against letting Maduro use Venezuelan government funds.

"This is a unique case that has not come before the judiciary before," he said, casting it as an issue of the U.S. government's ability to use sanctions to advance national security and foreign policy interests.

Thursday's hearing is the first time Maduro and his wife, Cilia Flores, have been in court since a January arraignment at which he protested their capture by U.S. military forces and declared: "I am not guilty. I am a decent man, the constitutional president of my country." Flores has also pleaded not guilty.

Maduro and Flores sat at the defense table between their lawyers, wearing jail uniforms and headphones to listen to the translation.

They are also accused of ordering kidnappings, beatings and murders of those



JUAN BARRETO AFP/Getty Images

GRAFFITI this week in Caracas, the Venezuelan capital. Nicolás Maduro and his wife are in a Brooklyn jail.

who owed them drug money or undermined their trafficking operation. That included the killing of a drug boss in Caracas, the indictment said. If convicted, they face life in prison.

Both have remained jailed at a Brooklyn detention center, and neither has asked to be released on bail. Judge Alvin Hellerstein has yet to set a trial date, though that could happen at the hearing.

Groups of demonstrators gathered outside the courthouse to rally both in favor of and against Maduro. In a noisy scene, protesters and supporters chanted, blew horns and beat drums and cowbells. Among the anti-Maduro contingent, one person waved a sign reading "Maduro rot in prison." On the other side of a metal barrier, people held signs reading "Free President Maduro."

In Caracas on Thursday morning, a couple hundred people gathered at a public plaza, including ruling party supporters, state employees and civilian militia members. One of the attendees, retiree Eduardo Cubillan, said he was there to pray for Maduro and Flores and condemn the violation of Venezuela's sovereignty during the Jan. 3 operation.

"We hope that in the United States, if justice truly exists, a trial will be held that will lead to President Maduro's freedom, because this kidnapping violated international legal principles, and we want justice to be served," Cubillan, 80, said.

Maduro, 63, and Flores, 69, continue to enjoy some support in Venezuela, with murals and billboards across the capital, Caracas, demanding their return. Although Maduro's ruling party remains in power, he has slowly been erased from the government of Delcy Rodríguez, Venezuela's acting president.

Rodríguez has replaced senior officials including Maduro's faithful defense minister and attorney general, reorganized agencies, appointed ambassadors and eliminated tenets of the self-proclaimed socialist movement that has ruled Venezuela for more than two decades.

Venezuela has since re-established diplomatic relations with the U.S., which in 2019 cut ties with Maduro's government and recognized the then-head of the National Assembly, a member of the opposition, as the country's legitimate leader. The U.S. has eased economic sanctions on Venezuela's crucial oil industry and

also dispatched a chargé d'affaires to Caracas.

But that may not spare Maduro and Flores from having to foot their own legal bills.

In a court filing last month, Pollack said the U.S. Treasury Department's Office of Foreign Assets Control, which administers sanctions, flip-flopped on a decision to let Venezuela pay for his legal fees.

The office approved the arrangement Jan. 9, Pollack said, but then rescinded it without explanation less than three hours later.

In a written declaration filed with the court, Maduro argued that he is "entitled to have the government of Venezuela pay for my legal defense."

Prosecutors responded that the U.S. government had authorized Maduro and Flores to use personal funds to pay their legal fees but would not let them do so from a fund controlled by a sanctioned government.

Maduro said in his declaration that he is unable to afford his defense. To qualify for a lawyer at U.S. taxpayer expense, he must show he is too poor to pay for it.

During a Cabinet meeting Thursday, President Trump accused Maduro of being a "major purveyor of drugs coming into our coun-

try."

Trump said Maduro would be given "a fair trial. But I would imagine there are other trials coming." He didn't provide details but suggested the current charges Maduro is facing might be "a fraction of the kind of things that he's done."

Maduro and Flores were seized Jan. 3 in a middle-of-the-night raid on their Caracas home.

A 25-page indictment accused him and others of working with drug cartels and members of the military to facilitate the shipment of thousands of tons of cocaine into the U.S.

Post-Maduro, everyday life for most Venezuelans remains the same.

Many public-sector employees earn just about \$160 per month, and the average private-sector worker makes about \$237. Last year the annual inflation rate soared to 475%, according to Venezuela's central bank, putting the cost of food and other essentials beyond the reach of many.

Sisak, Peltz and Cano write for the Associated Press. Cano reported from Caracas, Venezuela. AP writer Dave Collins in Hartford, Conn., contributed to this report.

Guthrie describes fear for missing mother

Speaking on 'Today,' she recounts receiving a distressing phone call from her sister.

By RICHARD WINTON

Savannah Guthrie can recall the moment she and her family discovered their mother, Nancy, was missing.

Speaking on the "Today" show, Guthrie said her sister Ann called to describe the scene at Nancy's Tucson-area home. The back doors were propped open and the front-door security camera had been yanked out. Nancy's cellphone and other belongings were still in her home.

"It made no sense," Guthrie said.

"My sister called me. I said, 'Is everything OK?' And she said, 'No.' She said, 'Mom's missing,'" she said. "And I said, 'What? What are you talking about?' She said, 'She's gone.' And she was in a panic. I was in a panic."

"We thought that she must have had like some kind of medical episode in the night and somehow the paramedics had come because the back doors were propped open ... and that didn't make any sense," Guthrie said. "We thought maybe they came and there's a stretcher and they took her out the back, but her phone was there, her purse was there, all her things and it just didn't make any sense."

They called hospitals but could not find her.

Guthrie's interview comes nearly two months since Nancy's Guthrie's abduction.

Despite a massive search, she has not been found.

Guthrie was abducted on Feb. 1. The kidnapping drama has captivated the nation, but there have been relatively few leads.

Investigators received their first major break in the case days later with the release of footage showing an armed man wearing a balaclava, gloves and a backpack. The man was seen approaching the front door of Guthrie's home and tampering with a Nest camera at 1:47 a.m. the night she was abducted.

Several ransom notes have emerged, but there has been no proof of life and the investigation has slowed considerably.

Guthrie said in the interview that a motive for the abduction is unclear but she worries it's possible her fame might have been a factor.

"I don't know that it's because she's my mom and somebody thought, 'Oh, that girl — that lady has money. We can ... make a quick buck,'" she said. "I mean, that would make sense. But we don't know."

She said she believes two ransom notes demanding millions for Nancy's return were legitimate.

More than a dozen gloves have since been recovered in the surrounding community. But the one glove, authorities say, that matched the one worn by the person in the video turned out to be unrelated and from a restaurant worker nearby.

There have been no DNA matches with known criminals in the federal database.

In the interview, Guthrie said her family assumed her mother may have experienced a medical emergency because she was frail.

"My mom, she was in tremendous pain," she said.

But the scene they discovered that Sunday morning made clear something was off.

"This is not OK. Something is very wrong here."



JUSTIN SULLIVAN Getty Images

A MAKESHIFT memorial placed at the front of Nancy Guthrie's home.

Trump ally Flynn reportedly settles lawsuit with Justice Department for \$1.2 million

Deal resolves claims that a criminal case against him was a malicious prosecution.

By ERIC TUCKER AND ALANNA DURKIN RICHER

WASHINGTON — The Justice Department has settled for roughly \$1.2 million a lawsuit from Michael Flynn, the former national security advisor to President Trump who pleaded guilty during the Republican's first term to lying to the FBI about his conversations with a top Russian diplomat and was later pardoned.

Court papers filed Wednesday do not reveal the settlement amount, but a person familiar with the matter, who spoke to the Associated Press on condition of anonymity to disclose nonpublic information, confirmed the total as about \$1.2 million.

The settlement resolves a 2023 lawsuit in which Flynn sought at least \$50 million and asserted that the criminal case against him amounted to a malicious prosecution. It also represents a stark turnaround in position for a Justice Department that during the Biden administration had pressed a judge to dismiss Flynn's complaint.

Atty. Gen. Pam Bondi, a former personal lawyer for the president, has openly criticized the Russia investigation in which Flynn was charged, and the Justice Department in the last year has opened investigations into former officials who participated in that inquiry.

The Justice Department cast the settlement as an "important step in redressing" what it says was a "historic injustice" of the Russia



ANDREW HARNIK Getty Images

MICHAEL FLYNN had been accused of lying about talks with a Russian official.

investigation that shadowed Trump for much of his first term.

"This Department of Justice will continue to pursue accountability at all levels for this wrongdoing. Such weaponization of the federal government must never be allowed to happen again," a spokesperson said.

In a separate statement, Flynn said: "Nothing can fully compensate for the hell that my family and I have endured over these many years — the relentless attacks, the destruction of reputations, the financial ruin, and the profound personal toll inflicted upon us all. No amount of money or formal resolution can erase the pain caused by a prosecution that should never have been brought."

The settlement is the latest turn in the long-running

legal saga involving Flynn, one of six Trump associates charged as part of special counsel Robert S. Mueller III's investigation into potential ties between Russia and Trump's 2016 presidential campaign. That investigation found Russia interfered in the election on Trump's behalf and that the Trump campaign eagerly welcomed the help, but it ultimately found insufficient evidence of a criminal conspiracy.

Flynn, a retired Army lieutenant general who vigorously campaigned at Trump's side, served for weeks as his first national security advisor before being pushed out of his position. He remained a Trump ally even after agreeing to cooperate with Mueller's team. He was pardoned in the final weeks of the presi-

dent's first term.

Flynn pleaded guilty in December 2017 to lying to the FBI when he said he had not discussed with the Russian envoy, Sergei Kislyak, sanctions that the outgoing Obama administration had just imposed on Russia for election interference. During that conversation, Flynn advised that Russia be "even-keeled" in response to the punitive measures, and assured him "we can have a better conversation" about relations between the countries after Trump became president.

The conversation alarmed the FBI, which at the time was investigating whether the Trump campaign and Russia had coordinated to sway the election. In addition, White House officials were stating publicly that Flynn and Kislyak had

not discussed sanctions, which the FBI knew was untrue.

Flynn was ousted from his position in February 2017 after news broke that Obama administration officials had warned the White House that Flynn had indeed discussed sanctions with Kislyak and was vulnerable to blackmail. He pleaded guilty months later to a false statement charge.

But Flynn later sought to withdraw his guilty plea, saying federal prosecutors had acted in "bad faith" and broken their end of the bargain when they sought prison time for him.

The Justice Department in 2020 moved to dismiss the case, asserting that the FBI had no basis to interview Flynn about Kislyak and that any statements he made during the interview were not material to the FBI's broader counterintelligence probe.

Flynn was pardoned by Trump in November 2020, ending the court case and the legal wrangling.

In his lawsuit, Flynn maintained his innocence and said he was targeted by the "virulently anti-Trump leadership" of the FBI's Russia investigation. He contended that investigators pursued him despite knowing there was no evidence of a crime and coerced his guilty plea.

"He was falsely branded as a traitor to his country, lost at least tens of millions of dollars of business opportunities and future lifetime earning potential, was maliciously prosecuted and spent substantial monies in his own defense," says the lawsuit, adding that Flynn will continue to suffer "mental and emotional pain."

Tucker and Durkin Richer write for the Associated Press.

‘Arresting everyone that couldn’t get away’

[**Force**, from A1] thread was from Joseph Mazzara, then-acting Homeland Security general counsel, and he appears to be referring to an incident in which protesters tried to breach a protective line at a federal building.

On June 11, he wrote: “Every time I read about the battering ram incident I’m just floored at how wild that is.”

Referring to law enforcement as “they,” he continued: “They should have, when they brought the line in, just started hitting the rioters and arresting everyone that couldn’t get away from them. No one likes being hit by a stick, and people tend to run when that starts happening in earnest.”

The Department of Homeland Security didn’t respond to requests for comment.

Mazzara was later appointed deputy commissioner of U.S. Customs and Border Protection.

Politico reported that Mazzara is among 10 staffers who followed former Secretary Kristi Noem to the State Department after she was fired from Homeland Security and given a new role as special envoy for the “Shield of the Americas.”

The battering ram incident Mazzara referred to is detailed in court documents for the lawsuit.

A June 19 order from a panel of judges from the 9th Circuit Court of Appeals states that Trump administration attorneys presented evidence of protesters interfering with federal officers. The protesters threw objects at ICE vehicles, “pinned down” several Federal Protective Service officers and threw “concrete chunks, bottles of liquid, and other objects,” the order said.

Protesters also “used ‘large rolling commercial dumpsters as a battering ram’ in an attempt to breach



CARLIN STIEHL Los Angeles Times

L.A. COUNTY sheriff’s deputies walk past graffiti on the Edward R. Roybal Federal Building after an anti-ICE demonstration last June.

the parking garage of a federal building,” the order states.

Mazzara’s comment in the email thread with other Homeland Security attorneys was given to American Oversight with a watermark showing the agency had intended to withhold it. American Oversight also received a version of the documents with that statement redacted.

Chiomu Chukwu, executive director of American Oversight, said it’s no wonder the administration wanted to keep Mazzara’s

comments hidden.

“They reveal a level of hostility toward protesters that is deeply at odds with the government’s obligation to protect civil liberties — and there’s no FOIA exemption that justifies hiding them,” she said.

Kerry Doyle, the former top ICE attorney during the Biden administration, said Mazzara’s comments show a shocking carelessness about the potential for harm against both the public and the officers he was employed to protect.

The email, she said,

“seems to encourage, or, at the very least, support constitutional violations by the operators that are supposed to be getting legal counsel from him to avoid violating the law.” Plus, commenting on operational strategy is outside the scope of his responsibilities, she said.

“He’s doing a disservice to the people that are on the front line, that rely on him and his colleagues to give them the parameters of what they can and can’t do,” Doyle added. “If you give them bad legal advice, you are setting them up for

liability.”

Noem’s removal came amid backlash against an escalation of violence during Trump’s crackdown on immigration, including the shooting deaths of U.S. citizens by immigration agents.

Doyle said part of the secretary’s job is to set the tone for the agency so the rank and file know what is expected of them. Mazzara’s comments, she said, show how that tone has permeated all facets of the agency.

After the U.S. Supreme Court cast doubt on the Trump administration’s le-

gal theory for using troops in domestic law enforcement operations, the president in December began removing the National Guard from Los Angeles and other Democrat-led cities.

The protests last summer caused significant property damage in a small section of downtown Los Angeles. But grand juries refused to indict many demonstrators accused by federal prosecutors of attacking agents, and a Times review of alleged assaults found that most incidents resulted in no injuries.



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

A PROTESTER in June outside the Roybal Federal Building in downtown L.A.

Trump mulls troop reboot

[**Troops**, from A1] government shutdown.

The renewed call comes after a series of controversial federal interventions in cities across the country. In Washington, Trump has repeatedly touted a visible security presence near federal buildings, crediting it with improving public safety, though local officials and analysts have debated how much of any decline in crime can be attributed to his order.

In January, Trump threatened to invoke the Insurrection Act to deploy troops to Minneapolis during the civil unrest that followed the fatal shooting of Renee Good by a federal immigration agent. The Pentagon prepared active-duty troops for a possible deployment, but they were ordered to stand down after the shooting of a second Minneapolis civilian, Alex Pretti, the same month.

Immigration sweeps in Los Angeles targeted workplaces, neighborhoods and churches, stirring widespread panic and forcing many undocumented residents — including those with long-term residency and native-born children — into hiding. As a result, businesses reported sharp declines in revenue and customer traffic. A county analysis found that 82% of surveyed businesses experienced negative effects, with some losing more than half their income amid workforce shortages and reduced traffic.

During the fallout, Mayor Karen Bass condemned Trump’s deployment of some 4,000 California National Guardsmen and 700 U.S. Marines.

“Deploying federalized troops on the heels of these raids is a chaotic escalation,” she said. “The fear people are feeling in our city right now is very real — it’s felt in our communities and within our families, and it puts our neighborhoods at risk. This is the last thing that our city needs.”

The president called the occupation off after U.S. District Judge Charles Breyer ruled that control of the California National Guard should be returned to the governor, rejecting the federal government’s authority to maintain control indefinitely. A similar Supreme Court ruling in effect ended federalized deployments throughout the country.

“The judges are really hurting this country,” Trump said Thursday. “Frankly, the justices — the Supreme Court — has really hurt our country too.”

At the meeting, Trump also narrowed his comments on San Francisco and its mayor, Daniel Lurie.

“San Francisco was a great city, could quickly become a great city again,” Trump said. “But we can do it much more effectively.”

Last year, Trump considered carrying out similar federal law enforcement operations in the city. He backed off after a somewhat conciliatory phone call with

Lurie, in which Trump said the mayor asked him “very nicely” to call off the deployment. Afterward, he agreed to give the newly elected mayor “a chance” to address crime in the city.

“In San Francisco, crime is down 30%, encampments are at record lows, and our city is on the rise,” Lurie said in a statement Thursday. “Public safety is my number one priority, and we are going to stay laser focused on keeping our streets safe and clean.”

A spokesperson for Lurie’s office said the two have not spoken since that October conversation, indicating Trump’s latest remarks do not reflect any new request or ongoing negotiations.

Even so, the president struck a measured tone toward the San Francisco mayor on Thursday. He said Lurie is “trying very hard” but insisted federal intervention would get the job done faster.

Whether any Democrat-led city will take Trump up on that offer remains to be seen. City leaders have previously resisted federal deployments, arguing they undermine local control and risk inflaming already tense situations.

The White House did not respond to questions about whether any current plans exist to redeploy federalized troops to California cities.

Times staff writer Melissa Gomez in Los Angeles contributed to this report.

Minnesota dad, boy flown on Delta to ICE detention

Video shows how officials are using a more opaque way to move immigrants.

BY MARTHA BELLISLE AND MARK VANCELEAVE

MINNEAPOLIS — Airport security video shows another way federal agents are taking immigrants to detention centers — in some cases they’re using commercial flights, with escorts dressed like any other passenger.

Video obtained through a public records request shows a 5-year-old boy who became a face of the immigration crackdown in Minneapolis being flown with his father to Texas on a Delta Air Lines flight, just a day after they were taken into custody. He had been detained while wearing a bunny hat.

Adrian Conejo Arias and son Liam Conejo Ramos seemed calm in these recordings as they were being escorted through the Minneapolis-St. Paul International Airport by a man and two women dressed in plain clothes. Since the father and boy didn’t appear to be in custody, their trip to San Antonio probably went unnoticed by fellow passengers.

The Trump administration, like its predecessors, is mostly using ICE Air Operations charter flights as it detains hundreds of thousands of people for deportation. Human rights monitors are trying to keep track as detainees are loaded onto planes in shackles in parts of airports the public can’t eas-

ily see.

The video of Liam and his father, they say, exposes another route that’s harder for rights monitors to document, despite happening in plain view inside the same airport terminals where Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents wearing tactical, military-style gear are now being deployed to support security checkpoints.

What happened in this case

The father, who was seeking asylum from Ecuador, and son were detained by ICE officers in Minnesota on Jan. 20 and taken to Texas. They were released on a judge’s orders and returned to Minnesota, but then an immigration judge denied their asylum request. The family’s lawyer said they’re appealing.

The video that revealed their commercial airline travel was first obtained by Nick Benson, an aviation enthusiast and activist with MN 50501, a grassroots group involved in anti-ICE and “No Kings” protests. Benson said he’s never seen children while monitoring ICE charter flights, so he suspected the agency was flying them commercially. He identified the time and day the father and son were flown out of Minneapolis, filed a public records request for the security video — and there they were.

The Associated Press obtained the same video through a similar request to the MSP Airport Police Department. It shows the father carrying the boy’s Spi-

der-Man backpack as a woman shows an airline agent their boarding passes. A man and the other woman follow them onto the jet bridge.

Delta declined to comment on the video. But the airline said most government travel is booked through third-party agencies, with no advance notice about who is flying or why. The Department of Homeland Security did not immediately return messages seeking comment.

What is ICE Air Operations?

ICE Air Operations transfers and depots people mostly using flights chartered through airline broker CSI Aviation, which has subcontracted with small airlines such as GlobalX, Eastern Air Express, Bighorn Airways, Key Lime Air and Avelo Airlines.

ICE Air continues to rapidly expand both domestic transfer and deportation flights, according to Human Rights First, which documented 1,630 immigration enforcement flights in February alone. Of that, 183 were deportation flights and 1,170 were domestic transfers.

ICE also uses U.S. Coast Guard planes. Flight Monitor said it has tracked hundreds of flights since June in which Coast Guard planes were used to transport immigrants domestically.

“It seems that ICE sometimes uses commercial flights to destinations where they don’t carry out kind of larger-scale ICE Air deportation flights,” said Savi Arvey, director of research and analysis for refugee and immigrant rights at Human Rights First.

The monitors use flight-tracking websites to follow the charter planes, but these tools can’t track individual passengers on commercial flights, making them “less in the public eye,” Arvey said. “It adds another level of opacity.”

Bellisile and Vanceleave write for the Associated Press. Bellisile reported from Seattle. AP writers Rio Yamat in Las Vegas and Rebecca Santana in Washington contributed to this report.



MSP Airport Police Department

SURVEILLANCE video shows Adrian Conejo Arias and son Liam at the Minneapolis-St. Paul airport.



SETH WENIG Associated Press

ALLISON Posner, organizer of a “No Kings” march in Maplewood, N.J., says suburbanites are “radicalizing.”

MONTCLAIR, N.J. — A few years ago, Allison Posner was barely involved in politics.

Now the 42-year-old mother of two from Maplewood, N.J., hands out food and diapers to immigrant families outside a nearby detention facility. She waves signs on a highway overpass between school pickups and orthodontist appointments. And this weekend, she'll lead a “No Kings” protest march across this affluent town alongside her husband, her children and thousands of others who are convinced President Trump represents a direct threat to American democracy.

“The people in the suburbs are definitely radicalizing,” said Posner, a freelance actor.

A growing faction of concerned citizens living in suburban communities across the United States — places once known for political moderation or even conservatism — are increasingly positioned on the front lines of the anti-Trump resistance. More than a year into the Republican president's second term, the soccer moms are becoming bona fide activists taking to their well-manicured streets to fight Trump and his allies.

The leftward lurch could cost Republicans control of Congress for the president's final two years in office. It could also reshape the Democratic Party by elevating a fresh crop of fiery progressive candidates emboldened to push back against the Trump administration more aggressively than the establishment may prefer.

Indivisible, the activist organization spearheading the third round of No Kings protests this weekend, said roughly two-thirds of more than 3,000 planned demonstrations will be held outside urban areas. Overall, more than 9 million people are expected to turn out nationwide for what leaders predict will be the largest day of protesting in U.S. history.

“We're going to be everywhere,” Indivisible co-founder Ezra Levin said.

Organizers said sign-ups have been especially enthusiastic in suburban areas with high-profile congressional races such as Scottsdale, Ariz.; Langhorne, Pa.; East Cobb, Ga.; and here in northern New Jersey's 11th District, which holds a special election April 16.

Democratic voters last month chose Analilia Mejia, a former political director for Vermont independent Sen. Bernie Sanders, as their candidate to replace Mikie Sherrill, the more moderate Democrat who was recently elected as New Jersey's governor.

Posner said she's excited to have a fighter represent her district, someone who can channel the outrage she sees every day.

“I'm seeing people from the PTA or the neighborhood who would have never joined a protest in the past, who are now asking how they can get involved,” Posner said. “This is not some other people's fight. This is our fight.”

For decades, affluent suburbs like those in northern New Jersey helped elect Republicans who fit the districts they represented: business-oriented, culturally moderate and uninterested in ideological fights.

That began to change in the Trump era.

Across the country, college-educated suburban voters recoiled from Trump's brand of politics. They shifted sharply toward Democrats in the 2018 midterms and in the presidential elections that fol-

lowed. Districts like New Jersey's 11th, once a Republican stronghold, have since become part of a new liberal coalition rooted in places that were, until very recently, politically competitive.

Even in Summit, N.J., one of the nation's wealthiest suburbs, Jeff Naiman feels as if he's living in an “authoritarian nightmare” of Trump's making.

“It's like our hair is on fire,” says Naiman, a 59-year-old radiologist who leads his local chapter of Indivisible. “Our country's being torn apart.”

He's supporting Mejia, and he has no doubt she'll win next month's special election — and again in November's general election.

“In this environment,” Naiman said, “I think the chances of her losing the general election are basically zero.”

Mejia, an outspoken progressive activist endorsed by Sanders and Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-N.Y.), emerged from the crowded Democratic primary last month, beating more moderate candidates like former congressman Tom Malinowski.

She's critical of Israel's war in Gaza, calls for the abolition of the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement and backs Medicare for All. She's also eager to raise concerns about what she describes as Trump's dictatorial tendencies and will be one of the featured speakers at a No Kings pro-

test this weekend.

“A ZIP Code does not protect anyone from rising violent authoritarianism,” she said in an interview.

Mejia still describes herself as a soccer mom, even as her Republican critics accuse her of trying to soften her activist image ahead of election day.

“My youngest plays baseball and soccer, my oldest lacrosse and basketball,” she said. “And when I take my children to activities, to games, and I speak to other parents, I know that we're all experiencing this economy and this political moment very similarly.”

Mejia defended herself against accusations of antisemitism for her position on Israel, which she accused of committing genocide in the war in Gaza, a topic that emerged as a key issue in the race.

“When I say Palestinians have rights, like Jewish people and Israelis have rights, that is not antisemitism, that is humanism,” she said while acknowledging there is antisemitism within the Republican and Democratic parties. “I am an Afro Latina raising two Black sons in America. I know ‘othering’ kills. I know how dangerous it is when we dehumanize communities.”

New Jersey's 11th District was represented by a Republican until Sherrill was elected during the 2018 midterm elections that served as a harsh verdict at the halfway mark of Trump's first term.

Joe Hathaway, the Re-

publican nominee in next month's special election and a town councilman from Randolph Township, hopes to convince voters that Mejia is too radical for them. Republican strategists in Washington, too, believe a surge of far-left Democratic candidates nationwide like Mejia in otherwise moderate districts might help their party maintain its razor-thin House majority this fall.

Yet suburban Republicans are facing serious political headwinds from the leader of their own party in the White House. Hathaway, for example, initially declined to say whether he voted for Trump.

“I don't think it's important,” he said in an interview, before acknowledging that he cast his ballot for the president three times. “This job is representing the district. NJ-11 comes first, before a president, before your party.”

Hathaway backs the president's war in Iran and many of the economic policies in Trump's big tax and spending cuts bill. But he was also quick to highlight areas of disagreement.

The Republican said he supports most of the Democrats' demands in the Department of Homeland Security shutdown fight, including proposals to require federal immigration agents to wear body cameras, clearly identify themselves, take off face masks and receive better training.

He also wants Republicans who lead Congress to stand up to Trump, whose

use of executive authority Hathaway said is “pressure testing” the checks and balances outlined in the Constitution.

“Congress needs to reassert that it is the first branch of government and take more of a leadership role than it's been doing,” he said.

Suburban Americans have been slowly moving away from the Republicans over the last 15 years, according to Gallup polling that tracks party affiliation over time.

Trump was unable to stop the shift despite warnings that Democrats would “destroy” the suburbs with low-income housing.

In 2020, Democrat Joe Biden won 54% of voters who said they lived in the suburbs while Trump won only 44%, according to AP VoteCast. That was a substantial improvement on Democrat Hillary Clinton's performance in a smaller survey of validated 2016 voters conducted by the Pew Research Center, which found that Clinton and Trump split the group about evenly.

The suburbs have also grown more diverse and educated over the last few decades, demographic shifts that may make Democrats more confident. In both of the last two presidential elections, AP VoteCast found that college-educated and non-white suburban voters were much likelier to support the Democratic candidate.

Naiman, the Summit radiologist, said he has witnessed a transformation in his town, which was represented by Republicans at the state and federal level for decades until Trump took over.

“I don't think that Summit is going to be swinging toward Republicans any time soon — at least not as long as Trumpism is around,” he said.

Peoples writes for the Associated Press. AP polling editor Amelia Thomson DeVeaux in Washington contributed to this report.

Court OKs denying bond hearings

Federal appeals judges support Trump's position on detention of immigrants.

By Audrey McAvoy

The U.S. can continue to detain immigrants without bond, an appeals court ruled on Wednesday, handing a victory to the Trump administration's crack-down on immigration.

The opinion from a panel of the 8th Circuit Court of Appeals in St. Louis overturned a lower-court ruling that required that a native of Mexico arrested for lacking legal documents be given a bond hearing before an immigration judge.

It's the second appeals court to rule in favor of the administration on this issue. The 5th Circuit in New Orleans ruled last month that the Department of Homeland Security's decision to deny bond hearings to immigrants arrested across the country was consistent with the Constitution and federal immigration law.

Both appeals court opin-

ions counter recent lower-court decisions across the country that argued the practice is illegal.

In November, a district court decision in California granted detained immigrants with no criminal history the opportunity to request a bond hearing and had implications for noncitizens held in detention nationwide.

Under past administrations, most noncitizens with no criminal record who were arrested away from the border had an opportunity to request a bond hearing while their cases wound through immigration court. Historically, bond was often granted to those without criminal convictions who were not flight risks, and mandatory detention was limited to recent border crossers.

In the case before the 8th Circuit, Joaquin Herrera Avila of Mexico was apprehended in Minneapolis in August 2025 for lacking legal documents authorizing his admission into the United States. The Department of Homeland Security detained Avila without bond and began deportation proceedings.

He filed a petition seeking immediate release or a bond hearing. A federal judge in Minnesota granted the petition, saying the law authorized detention without bond when a person seeking admission is not clearly and beyond a doubt entitled to being admitted. The judge found this was not the case for Avila because he had lived in the country for years without seeking naturalization, asylum or refugee status and thus wasn't “seeking admission.”

Circuit Court Judge Bobby E. Shepherd wrote for the majority in a 2-1 opinion that the law was “clear that an ‘applicant for admission’ is also an alien who is ‘seeking admission,’” and so Avila couldn't petition on these grounds.

Circuit Court Judge Ralph R. Erickson dissented, saying that Avila would have been entitled to a bond hearing during his deportation hearings if he had been arrested during the last 29 years. Now, he wrote, the Circuit Court has ruled that Avila and millions of others would be subject to mandatory detention under a novel interpretation of

“alien seeking admission” that hasn't been used by the courts or five previous presidential administrations.

The American Civil Liberties Union, which is representing Avila, didn't immediately return an email message seeking comment.

Atty. Gen. Pam Bondi hailed the ruling, writing in a social media post: “MASSIVE COURT VICTORY against activist judges and for President Trump's law and order agenda!”

At question is the issue of whether the government is required to ask a neutral judge to determine whether it is legal to imprison someone.

It's based on the habeas corpus, which is a Latin legal term referring to the constitutional right for people to legally challenge their detention by the government.

Immigrants have filed more than 30,000 habeas corpus petitions in federal court alleging illegal detention since Trump took office, according to a tally by the Associated Press. Many have succeeded.

McAvoy writes for the Associated Press.

Trump signature to go on currency — a first for a sitting president

By Fatima Hussein

WASHINGTON — The U.S. Treasury Department is working on plans to put President Trump's signature on all new U.S. paper currency, the agency announced Thursday.

The move would be a first for a sitting president. The news was first reported by Vanity Fair.

It's the latest instance of Trump putting his name and likeness on American cultural institutions, following his renaming of the U.S. Institute of Peace, the Kennedy Center performing arts venue and a new class of battle-ships, among other tributes.

The plans come in tandem with an effort to get Trump's face on a coin.

This month, a federal arts commission approved the final design for a 24-karat gold commemorative coin bearing Trump's image to help celebrate America's 250th birthday on July 4.

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent's signature would



HEATHER DIEHL Getty Images

PRESIDENT Trump holds a signed order.

also appear on the currency, according to a Treasury news release.

Bessent said in a statement that “there is no more powerful way to recognize the historic achievements of our great country” than with U.S. dollar bills bearing Trump's name.

U.S. Treasurer Brandon Beach said in a statement that printing Trump's signature on the American currency “is not only appropriate, but also well deserved.”

The Mint, which is part of the Treasury Department, manufactures and distributes the currency.

Hussein writes for the Associated Press.

Unhoused residents find shelter in sewers

[Sewer, from A1]
it. But it did little to cool her consternation.

“I don’t understand,” Evans said. “Why did it take a year?”

Evans’ home is on the east side of the 110 Freeway just south of the Manchester Avenue exit facing a sound-wall, with a residential street and a strip of dirt separating the neighborhood from the highway. That strip of land is where unhoused people congregated until Evans said she and others complained and the city put up fencing and placed boulders to keep them out. But the people living there did not go away, she said, they just moved their tents elsewhere in the neighborhood — or went underground.

“It’s disturbing, because these people are human,” she said.

Mayor Karen Bass’ office said it had “mobilized a response” to two locations on Grand Avenue on Tuesday, including at West 88th Street, and that “both sites were cleaned and people were offered resources.”

“This is so tragic, and is emblematic of the tough challenges that Mayor Bass is taking on that were ignored for decades,” the mayor’s office said in a statement.

It’s unclear what precisely prompted the city to respond. But Juan Naula, who runs a nonprofit dedicated to cleaning up the city, said he believed that videos he posted on social media Monday about people living in the storm drains were the trigger.

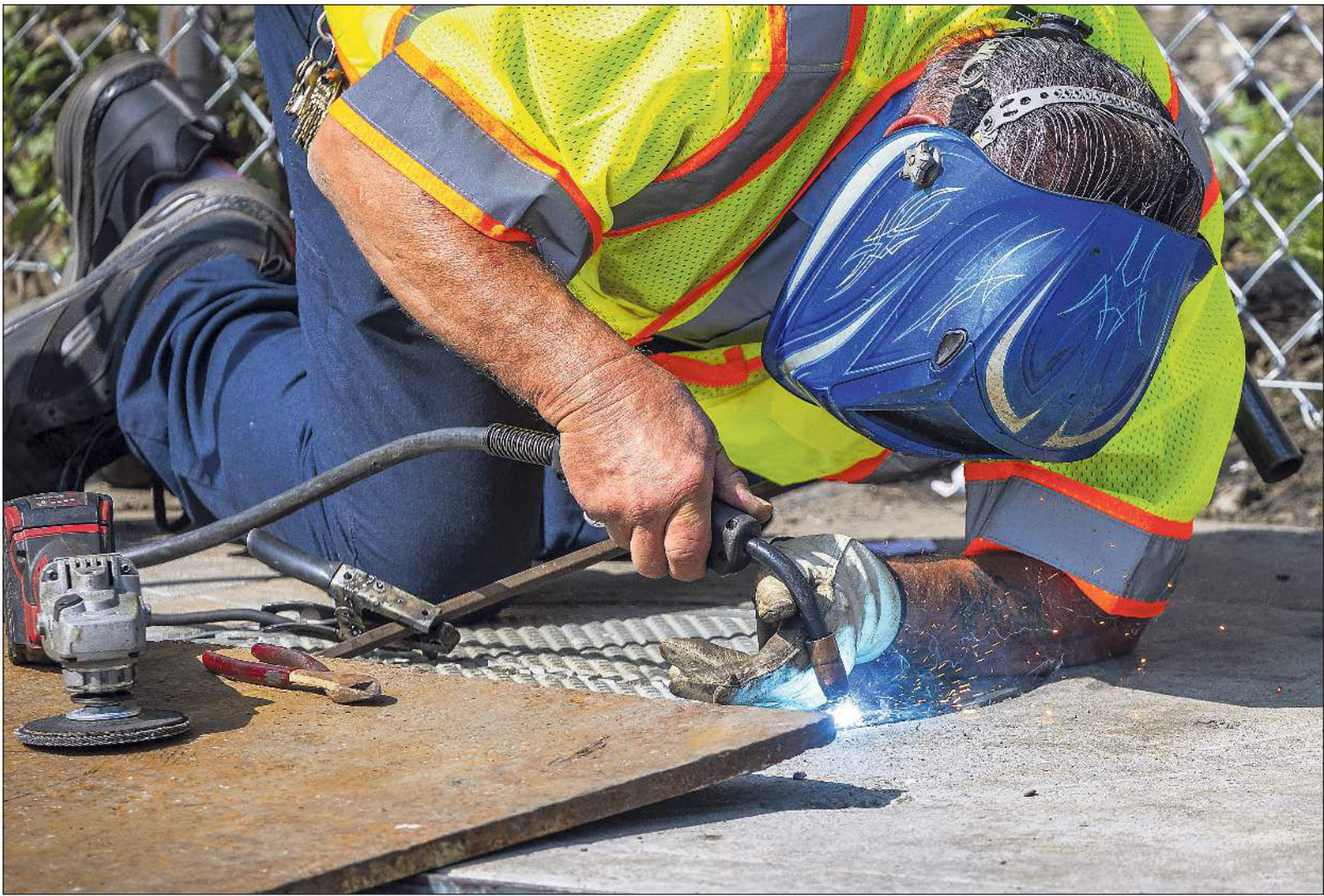
Naula said he was cleaning trash near the corner of 88th and Grand that day when he saw as many as 10 people go in and out of the storm drains. He posted a video online about people living in Los Angeles storm drains, then got a call from a Fox 11 reporter, Naula said. The station’s story ran online Tuesday morning — the same day city crews responded to the scene.

City crews placed a boulder over the manhole cover, said a spokesperson who was at the scene Wednesday. By the following morning, the boulder had been moved. The city then moved to weld the cover shut.

Around 9 a.m., sanitation workers were maneuvering what appeared to be a massive vacuum hose inside the drain, hovering up debris before the cover would be sealed.

About 10:20 a.m., workers were on the cusp of sealing the hole when one of them noticed a man inside, Luis Jimenez.

Jimenez told The Times



A MANHOLE cover, top, is welded in place near 88th Street and South Grand Avenue near the 110 Freeway, after several personal items, above left, were removed from inside the drain. Above right, an unhoused woman reads a Bible in a strip where people used to camp.



Photographs by ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

that he had been homeless for about 10 years and had stayed in the drain for one or two nights because he felt safer there.

Jimenez told a city employee that nobody else remained inside, Naula said. Asked what the city had done to ensure nobody else remained, Bass’ office said in an email that a crew member “went to the catch basin just south of 88th (at 91st) and walked through to ensure nobody was inside.”

Despite the city’s efforts,

Naula remained indignant.

“Why are we allowing people to live like this, like rats?” he said. “It makes me sad. It makes me mad.”

It wasn’t always like this, Evans said.

When she moved in about 11 years ago, the neighborhood was comfortable, but over the last eight years, it had gotten worse. Her grandchildren, ages 2, 6, 11 and 12, are “stuck in the house” because she believes it’s too dangerous to play outside, except in her back-

yard. She once had to fight a woman who came onto her property and stole some of her things, Evans said.

Evans is one of two residents who told The Times they had actively been trying to get the city to fix things.

Sitting in her office chair in her house, surrounded by dozens of framed family photos hanging on the walls, Evans scrolled through emails documenting her reports to 311, the city service that receives complaints and

homelessness. Her email showed dozens of contacts going back to at least 2020. Last year, she emailed her councilman, Marqueece Harris-Dawson, to ask for help with the “trash and feces” in a tunnel near her house, according to an email she provided.

“I trust that you can come see for yourself how dangerous it is for us as well as unsanitary,” Evans wrote.

Harris-Dawson’s office did not immediately respond to a request for com-

ment.

Cheryl Coleman, who also lives on 88th Street, said that she had been trying to get the city’s attention about problems in the area for at least two years, and that more than half a dozen times she had met with police officers and pointed out the drain where she saw homeless people go.

“This has been reported so many times, I got tired of calling,” Coleman said. “I thank God that they’re doing something finally now.”

‘Going to be complicated’: UFW history revisited

[UFW, from A1]
hundreds of schools, parks, streets and other institutions.

They also are likely to change the way history books and classrooms present the farmworkers union — one of the most consequential labor movements in U.S. history that has inspired decades of activism, particularly in the Latino community.

Chávez died in 1993, and Huerta, now 95, rose to take his mantle as the hero of the movement. She was credited with helping women advance in the union. But the UFW is a shadow of its former self, marginalized by decades of infighting, bad decisions and what critics say is gross mismanagement.

Newspaper reporting and books over the last 20 years had already tarnished the halo some affixed to Chávez after his death, Garcia said.

For example, a 2006 L.A. Times investigation uncovered the grim conditions faced by farmworkers despite the UFW, which had dramatically declined in size, and how the union had turned to political fundraising that did not benefit those working the fields.

But the latest allegations against Chávez are going to require more accountability and reassessment.

La Paz, the UFW headquarters in Kern County where Chávez moved the union operations in the 1970s, is a national monument. It’s also where he is alleged to have sexually assaulted underage girls, Garcia said.

“What do you do with



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

ARTWORK is on display at “Dolores,” a show at Plaza de la Raza in Los Angeles.

that? It’s going to be complicated,” he said.

Huerta says Chavez raped her in the 1960s, an incident she had kept a secret until allegations surfaced in the New York Times that he had also sexually abused two girls in the 1970s.

Huerta could not be reached by The Times for comment, but in recent interviews she’s described a culture that permeated the UFW in which women struggled to be heard and receive accolades for their work. Some women were berated. And criticism of Chávez or his ideas was not accepted.

In one instance, after spending four months in 1986 successfully lobbying lawmakers in Washington to

pass the Immigration Reform and Control Act that granted amnesty to undocumented immigrants, Huerta said, she wasn’t invited to a news conference to celebrate the win. Chávez instead requested that she head to Florida to handle a nonexistent crisis, what she calls a “straight male-chauvinist trick” to take credit for the work.

“Women are not seen as human beings. We’re just seen as sex objects,” Huerta told the New York Times.

She ultimately kept the alleged assault under wraps, she said, out of fear that it would upend their movement and efforts to better farmworkers’ lives.

Over the years, Huerta has mentioned working to

make the UFW more progressive toward women but did not speak about the level of abuse she and others faced.

The UFW’s membership has dwindled since its peak of about 80,000 unionized farmworkers down to roughly 5,000, according to recent estimates. The organization recently has tried to distance itself from its founder, canceling César Chávez Day celebrations this month after the allegations surfaced.

“As a women-led organization that exists to empower communities, the allegations about abusive behavior by Cesar Chavez go against everything that we stand for,” the organization said in a statement.

But the cracks in Chávez’s legacy had been visible for years for those willing to look, Garcia said.

In the 1970s, Garcia said, Chávez aggressively worked to “weed out people that he thought were betrayers of the movement and were not loyal to him. They called it ‘the game.’”

Others close to Chávez in the union “participated in some of the most heinous attacks on women,” Garcia said. “They attacked Dolores mercilessly and her daughters, calling them the worst names you could imagine for a woman in the ’70s.”

Huerta would get angry and quit, but would return and try to smooth things over with Chávez, a situation that Garcia called an “abusive relationship.”

More than a decade ago, Garcia said, one of the women at the center of the New York Times investigation accused Chávez of assaulting her when she was 12 years old, writing in a private Facebook group for UFW veterans: “Wake up, people. This man u march for every year molested me and many, many other young girls.”

She took down the post after union veterans accused her of tarnishing the movement, he said.

“So much of the success, so people thought, was wrapped up in César Chávez being a great leader and a virtuous man,” Garcia said. “So if César was exposed as being the problematic individual we now know him to be, then maybe the union and the movement was also problematic and so people stayed quiet.”

After Garcia’s book,

“From the Jaws of Victory: The Triumph and Tragedy of Cesar Chavez and the Farm Worker Movement,” was published in 2012, he said, he received intense scrutiny for his complicated portrayal of the union leader. But he also heard from people who spoke of Chávez’s alleged abuse of women.

The #MeToo reckoning came later, resulting in powerful men being held accountable for alleged sexual assaults and harassment across Hollywood, politics and corporate America. Women, many of whom had spent years living with painful secrets, found support when they came forward.

That shift in culture probably contributed to the willingness of the women Chávez is accused of assaulting to come forward as well, said Maria Quintana, associate professor of history at Sacramento State.

“There’s so much happening right now and so many conversations around gender and sexual violence and exploitation that it does make sense, in some ways, that it’s happening at this moment,” Quintana said.

Quintana said Huerta deserves her place in history.

A consumer boycott of grapes under Huerta’s leadership led to the California Agricultural Labor Relations Act of 1975, which paved the way for farmworkers to push for better working conditions and pay. She coined the rallying cry: “*Si, se puede*,” translated to “Yes, we can.”

“We forget that Dolores Huerta had this incredible role,” Quintana said.

CLIMATE

HONOLULU — Crews this week began evaluating damage from a surprise downpour that sent floodwaters raging through a neighborhood near downtown Honolulu — the latest bout in a series of storms and flooding that have pummeled the state over the last two weeks.

Residents along Oahu's North Shore, famous for its big-wave surfing, were cleaning up from the worst flooding to hit Hawaii in two decades when a storm Monday unleashed several inches of rain on the southern part of the island. Reddish-brown torrents gushed along roads in the Manoa Valley, a few miles east of downtown Honolulu, sweeping away parked cars and swamping much of the neighborhood.

Natalie Aczon had gone to the drugstore to pick up some medication for her mother on Monday. By the time she left the store some 15 minutes later, water was roaring down the street next to the shopping center.

"People came running out from Longs and one of the guys actually said, 'That's my white car.' And it had elevated," she said.

Michael McEwan and wife Heather Nakahara returned to their home in Waialua on Oahu's North Shore over the weekend to find their kitchen counters covered in red silt. Piled-up furniture blocked a hallway and a folding table they don't own was lodged under a heavy sleeper sofa. There were two other mystery tables in their backyard.

The rushing water trapped the couple in a bedroom closet for eight hours with their two small terriers and three parrots until daybreak, when McEwan was able to flag down firefighters driving down their road. The rescuers tied a rope to a tree next to their bedroom, which guided them through a narrow channel of flowing water.

They probably will have permanent reminders of the flooding in their house because of the red volcanic mud permeating everything.

"It's full of iron, so it stains everything brownish-yellow," McEwan said.

As the waters rose Friday, officials warned that the 120-year-old Wahiawa dam, north of Honolulu,



San Francisco Chronicle

RESIDENTS clear mud in Haleiwa, Hawaii, two days before a surprise downpour on Monday.

HAWAII'S MUDDY AFTERMATH

Torrential rains shocked meteorologists but could become a new normal thanks to global climate change

BY AUDREY MCAVOY AND GENE JOHNSON

was "at risk of imminent failure." The dam has long been vulnerable, but worries eased as the water subsided.

The earthen structure was built in 1906 to increase sugar production for the Waialua Agricultural Co., which eventually became a subsidiary of Dole Food Co. It was reconstructed after a collapse in 1921.

The state has said Wahiawa dam has "high hazard potential" and a failure "will result in probable loss of human life."

It has sent Dole four notices of deficiency about the dam since

2009, and five years ago it fined the company \$20,000 for failing to address safety deficiencies on time, according to records.

Afterward, Dole proposed to donate the dam, reservoir and ditch system to the state in exchange for an agreement to repair the spillway to meet and maintain dam safety standards.

"The dam continues to operate as designed with no indications of damage," Dole said in a statement.

The ferocity of the downpour even took National Weather Service meteorologists aback. They knew that lingering instability

from a powerful winter storm system called a "Kona low" could yield more rain, but their models aren't good at predicting how much moisture can remain in such systems, said forecaster Cole Evans.

"When you think it's over it's not quite over," he said Tuesday.

The downpour, which dumped 2 to 4 inches of rain per hour, was highly localized: One rain gauge in the upper part of the valley recorded 6 inches, while the airport a few miles away got just one-hundredth of an inch.

There were no immediate reports of deaths or serious injuries,

but authorities said hundreds of homes on Oahu's North Shore were damaged by the flooding, which came as heavy rain fell on soil already saturated by downpours from a winter storm a week earlier.

More than 230 people had to be rescued. The water pushed houses off their foundations, floated cars out of parking spots and left walls, floor and counters covered with thick, reddish volcanic mud.

Evacuation orders covered 5,500 people north of Honolulu, and some residents fled on surfboards as water reached waist or chest high.

Farms around the state reported more than \$9.4 million worth of damage as of Monday, according to a survey conducted by Agriculture Stewardship Hawaii, the Hawaii Farm Bureau and other organizations.

Gov. Josh Green said the storm toll could top \$1 billion, including damage to airports, schools, roads, homes and a Maui hospital in Kula. He called it the state's most serious flooding since 2004, when floods in Manoa inundated homes and a University of Hawaii library.

Green's office said Tuesday that he had submitted a major disaster declaration request to the Trump administration.

Molly Pierce, a spokesperson for the Oahu Emergency Management Agency, said that in addition to volunteers and public workers who have been cleaning up, a contract company had arrived to begin collecting, sorting and removing large piles of debris.

She called the storm system "extremely unusual."

"Most of us have not seen something that just keeps going like this," Pierce said. "We feel like we keep getting punched down. But we'll keep getting back up."

The intensity and frequency of heavy rains in Hawaii have increased amid human-caused global warming, experts say.

McAvoy and Johnson write for the Associated Press and reported from Honolulu and Seattle, respectively. AP writer Mark Thiessen in Anchorage and Gabriela Aoun Angueira in San Diego contributed to this report.



SEAN GALLUP Getty Images

SOLAR panels cover the roofs of homes this month in Frankenhofen, Germany.

European consumers look to solar, EVs as energy costs surge

BY JESS SHANKLEMAN AND EVA BRENDL

Consumers in Germany and the United Kingdom are growing more curious about rooftop solar and electric vehicles as they seek to shield themselves from surging energy prices resulting from the Iran war.

Early signs are starting to emerge that more people are at least considering the green technologies as alternatives. Octopus Energy, the U.K.'s biggest energy supplier, said inquiries about home solar were 27% higher than average the week the war started, and German companies also reported a rise in interest. Data on actual sales won't be available for a few months.

"We've consistently seen fuel price shocks and an unreliable grid accelerate small-scale solar adoption," said Lara Hayim, a solar analyst at BloombergNEF. "In the past we saw it in markets like Europe, Pakistan and Lebanon, and we're likely to see it again."

Demand for clean energy technologies rose in the wake of Russia's attack on Ukraine in 2022, as households and governments sought to reduce reliance on volatile fossil fuel supplies, driving increased uptake of

solar panels and heat pumps in particular. History appears to be repeating, with inquiries for EVs in the U.S. also rising, alongside growing interest in electric stoves in India.

Still, a sharp increase in semiconductor prices — driven in part by their energy-intensive production — could push up the cost of solar systems and slow the pace of adoption.

German renewable energy company Enpal said inquiries for solar panels and heat pumps have increased about 30% since the war started, and the company iKOMMA5 reported nearly a doubling of interest in solar and an increase in questions about heat pumps.

An Enpal spokesperson said that during the 2022 energy crisis, heat pump demand took longer to translate into actual sales, as installations require significant upfront investment. Heat pumps in Germany cost nearly twice as much as in the U.K., making it one of the most expensive markets for the technology in Europe, according to data from Heat Pumps Watch.

In response to the crisis, the U.K. government pledged to make it easier for consumers to install plug-in solar panels, which are widely available across other parts of Europe and can be

placed in gardens, on walls or balconies. Officials said they would introduce new standards and tweak regulations so that the panels can reach the market as soon as possible.

Ipsos polling released March 18 found that 84% of British people are worried about the effect of the war on the price of fuel and energy, in line with levels of concern at the start of the Ukraine conflict in 2022.

Some heat pump installers also are starting to see an increase in demand, the U.K. heat pump trade association said. Existing customers are seeking to boost the efficiency of their systems and other prebooked customers are asking for their installation dates to be moved up, according to a poll the association conducted for Bloomberg.

Meanwhile, German online searches related to EVs have risen to 60% of total car searches, compared with 55% before the war, according to the platform Carwow Deutschland.

"This suggests that consumers are highly sensitive to economic conditions, such as rising energy costs," said Philipp Saylor von Amende, chief executive of Carwow Deutschland.

Shankleman and Brendel write for Bloomberg.

U.S. pays firm \$1 billion to give up offshore wind leases

French company has agreed to invest in fossil fuel projects instead, feds say.

BY JENNIFER McDERMOTT

The Trump administration will pay \$1 billion to a French company to walk away from two U.S. offshore wind leases as the administration ramps up its campaign against offshore wind and other renewable energy.

TotalEnergies has agreed to what's essentially a refund of its leases for projects off the coasts of North Carolina and New York, and will invest the money in fossil fuel projects instead, the Department of the Interior announced Monday.

The Trump administration has tried to halt offshore wind construction, but federal judges overturned those orders. Environmental groups denounced the TotalEnergies deal as an alternative way to block wind projects. President Trump has gone all in on fossil fuels, which he says is the way to lower costs for families, increase reliability and help the U.S. maintain global leadership in artificial intelligence.

TotalEnergies had already paused its two projects after Trump was elected.

TotalEnergies pledged to not develop any new offshore wind projects in the United States. TotalEnergies Chief Executive Patrick Pouyanné said in a statement that the company renounced offshore wind development in the United States in exchange for the reimbursement of the lease fees, "considering that the development of offshore wind projects is not in the country's interest."

In fact, scientists and scholars say that development of the carbon-free electricity offshore wind turbines produce is essential to addressing climate change.



STEVE PFOST Newsday

A WIND TURBINE stands near two others being built off the coast of East Hampton, N.Y., in 2023.

Pouyanné said the re-funded lease fees will finance the construction of a liquefied natural gas plant in Texas and the development of its oil and gas activities, calling it a "more efficient use of capital" in the U.S.

After it makes those investments, TotalEnergies will be reimbursed, up to the amount paid in lease purchases for offshore wind, according to the Department of the Interior.

"We welcome TotalEnergies' commitment to developing projects that produce dependable, affordable power to lower Americans' monthly bills while providing secure U.S. baseload power today — and in the future," Interior Secretary Doug Burgum said in a statement.

The Biden administration sought to ramp up offshore wind as a climate change solution. Trump began reversing U.S. energy policies on his first day back in office, with executive orders aimed at boosting oil, gas and coal. Globally the offshore wind market is growing, with China leading the world in new installations.

The Trump administration halted construction on five major East Coast offshore wind projects days before Christmas, citing national security concerns. Developers and states sued, and federal judges allowed all five to resume construction, essentially concluding

that the government did not show the risk was so imminent that construction must halt.

On Monday, one of the wind farms targeted by the administration, Coastal Virginia Offshore Wind, started delivering power to the grid for Virginia. The developer, Dominion Energy, announced the milestone.

Environmental groups criticized the TotalEnergies settlement. The Natural Resources Defense Council said it's reckless to halt projects designed to bring energy costs down.

Ted Kelly, clean energy director at the Environmental Defense Fund, said the proposed deals "are an outrageous misuse of taxpayer dollars to prevent Americans from having clean, affordable power exactly when they need it most."

TotalEnergies bought a lease for its Carolina Long Bay project in 2022 for about \$133,000. It aimed to generate more than 1 gigawatt there, enough to power about 300,000 homes. It purchased the lease off New York and New Jersey, also in 2022, for \$795,000. This was planned as a larger project, with the potential to generate 3 gigawatts of clean energy to power nearly 1 million homes.

McDermott writes for the Associated Press. AP writer Matthew Daly in Washington contributed to this report.

BUSINESS

Sony, Honda pull plug on \$100,000 EV

Netflix prices climb, hitting \$27 a month

Afeela 1 is dropped after carmaker cancels plans for three other electric models.

By CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN

As major automakers pare back their EV offerings, Sony and Honda are scrapping their plans to launch a gadget-packed electric vehicle.

The move by Sony Honda Mobility comes weeks after Honda announced a \$15.7-billion write-down of its EV business and said it would cancel planned production for three of its own electric models.

Sony Honda Mobility is discontinuing the development and launch of the Afeela 1, a roughly \$100,000 electric sedan stuffed with screens, speakers and AI. The car was set to hit the roads exclusively in California later this year.

"This decision follows discussions between our parent companies, after taking into account the significant impact of Honda's EV strategy change," said Akiko Itoga, director of public relations for Sony Honda Mobility.

"The discontinuation of these [Honda] models significantly impacts Sony Honda Mobility of America in pursuing a viable business case," she said.

In a release on Wednesday, the company said it would not "be able to utilize certain technologies and assets that were originally planned," because of the sudden change in Honda's plans.

The company will issue refunds to customers who



RONALDO BOLANOS Los Angeles Times

THE AFEELA 1, stuffed with screens, speakers and AI, had been expected to launch in California this year.

paid \$200 to reserve a vehicle. It did not disclose the number of reservations.

Earlier this month, Honda reported its first annual loss in nearly 70 years as a listed company. It is not the only automaker to struggle with losses on EVs.

Ford took a \$19.5-billion write-down and discontinued its F-150 Lightning electric pickup last year. Stellantis, maker of Jeep, Ram and others, took a \$26.5-billion hit after shifting away from EVs in February.

"The way the market is looking right now, it makes sense they shut down," said Kristin Shaw, an auto industry analyst and writer. "It's a

matter of timing."

The companies could still work together in the future, she said.

Despite a predicted uptick in EV interest driven by sky-high gas prices, the market isn't welcoming for newcomers at the moment. The average price of gas in California was \$5.83, according to AAA.

"Afeela might be shelved or it might be trashed," Shaw said. "Right now, it's not going to work."

The creators of Afeela were trying to make a car, entertainment system and personal assistant in one. The discontinued vehicles were to have 28 speakers,

wraparound screens, an AI assistant and an entertainment system for karaoke or playing Sony PlayStation games.

The company was also trying to achieve full autonomy in its vehicles. The Afeela 1 was equipped with 18 cameras, nine radars, 12 ultrasonic sensors and lidar — allowing it to qualify for level two autonomy, which requires a driver to be in control.

President Trump has rolled back EV incentives and requirements for automakers to sell green vehicles, leading to fewer options and declining public interest.

Tesla, the most popular EV brand in the country, is pivoting toward AI and autonomous driving tech as its EV sales lose steam. It discontinued its Models S and X in January. The company also lost swaths of customers last year as Chief Executive Elon Musk's reputation suffered.

Sony Honda Mobility said it would continue discussions with Sony and Honda regarding future plans. Sony isn't the only tech company that tried to break into the electric vehicle market — Apple worked on an EV for more than 10 years before abandoning it in 2024.

Bell Gardens, Commerce seek to raise sales taxes

By ITZEL LUNA

Two southeast Los Angeles County cities proposed a sales tax increase to offset the financial impact of California's blackjack ban, which officials said would devastate their local economies.

Commerce and Bell Gardens will both place measures on the June ballot proposing a 0.25 percentage point increase in sales tax to recoup general funds the cities would lose due to the ban.

The officials declared fiscal emergencies for their cities and decried state Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta's decision to move forward with the ban at a news conference Thursday. The mayors for Commerce and Bell Gardens were joined by officials from both cities to announce the plan.

"The threat to our city is here," said Commerce City Manager Ernie Hernandez.

California's new regulations, to be enacted in April, are meant to end a legal interpretation that allowed card clubs to offer blackjack and other banked games where players play against the house. Those games are only meant to be offered in Indian casinos, but card clubs had long used designated outside dealers to get around the restriction.

Cardrooms have until the end of May to submit a plan showing how they intend to comply with the rules.

Officials said the tax measures are necessary to protect the city's budgets.

"If we don't act now, we risk the ability to protect the community," said Michael B. O'Kelly, the Bell Gardens city manager. "We are acting because we must, not be-

cause we want to."

Bell Gardens Mayor Miguel De La Rosa said cardrooms have been legal in the state for decades.

"They gave cities like ours the ability to responsibly build our budgets," De La Rosa said. "Now, that foundation is being pulled out from underneath us."

The ban will cause slowdowns and reductions of the city's basic daily services, including police and fire departments, as well as senior and recreation programs, Hernandez said.

The proposed measure could recoup at least \$4.5 million in Commerce, only a fraction of the expected \$8-million to \$18-million loss as a result of the ban, said Mayor Kevin Lainez.

Bell Garden risks losing about 40% of its general funds if the ban is enacted, O'Kelly said. About a third of

those funds would be recouped by the tax increase.

Officials said Bonta refused to meet with them or address their concerns, and urged the state to take action to stop the ban from taking place.

Bonta's office didn't immediately respond to a request for comment.

Card club operators said the ban is an existential threat for the industry. The state has over 70 cardrooms employing about 20,000 workers. The ban could cut those jobs by half, according to the California Gambling Assn.

In Los Angeles County, cardrooms bring in more than \$2 billion in economic activity and generate about 9,000 jobs, according to Los Angeles County Supervisor Hilda Solis.

The regulations are a turning point in a decades-

long fight between tribal casinos and the cardroom industry.

Indian tribes retained the right to conduct Nevada-style casinos on reservations in 2000, a form of gambling that is otherwise prohibited through the state's Constitution.

Cardrooms had since sidestepped the ban by giving players the option to take turns dealing the game and relying on third-party businesses to employ people who act as bankers.

Lainez and De La Rosa urged their constituents to pass the measure this summer.

"This is a terrible situation," Lainez said. "We are a vulnerable community. We are a community of color, and if you look at the cardroom cities all across the state, they are also communities of color."

Warner shareholders to vote on Paramount merger

By MEG JAMES

Warner Bros. Discovery shareholders will soon render a verdict on Hollywood's biggest merger in nearly a decade.

Warner has set an April 23 special meeting of stockholders to vote on the company's proposed sale, for \$31-a-share, to the Larry Ellison family's Paramount Skydance.

The \$11-billion deal is expected to reshape the entertainment industry by combining two historic film studios, dozens of prominent TV networks, including CBS, HBO, HGTV and Comedy Central, streaming services and two news organizations, CNN and CBS News. The tie-up would give Paramount such beloved characters as Batman, Wile E. Coyote, and Harry Potter, television shows including "Hacks," and "The Pitt," and a rich vault of movies that includes "Casablanca," and "One Battle After Another."

The \$31-a-share offer represents a 63% increase over

Paramount Chairman David Ellison's initial \$19-a-share proposal for the company in mid-September, and a 147% premium over Warner's stock's trading levels prior to news of Ellison's interest.

"This transaction is the culmination of the Board's robust process to unlock the full value of our world-class portfolio," Warner Bros. Discovery Chief Executive David Zaslav said Thursday in a statement. "We are working closely with Paramount to close the transaction and deliver its benefits to all stakeholders."

Paramount hopes to finalize the takeover by September. It has been working to secure the blessing of government regulators in the U.S. and abroad.

Should those regulatory deliberations stretch beyond September, Paramount will pay shareholders a so-called "ticking fee" — an extra 25 cents a share for every 90-day-period until the deal closes.

The transaction will leave the combined com-

pany with nearly \$80-billion in debt, a sum that experts say will lead to significant cost cuts.

For weeks it appeared that Netflix would scoop up Warner Bros.

Netflix initially won the bidding war in early December with a \$27.75 offer for the studios and streaming services, including HBO Max. But Ellison refused to throw in the towel. He and his team continued to lobby shareholders, politicians and Warner board members, insisting their deal for the entire company, including the cable channels, was superior and they had a more certain path to win regulatory approval.

The Ellison family is close to President Trump. This week, Trump named Larry Ellison to a proposed White House council on technology issues, including artificial intelligence.

Warner's board, under pressure, reopened the bidding in late February to allow Paramount to make its case. Warner board members ultimately concluded



KAYLA BARTROWSKI Los Angeles Times

WARNER stockholders will hold a vote April 23 on the proposed Paramount sale.

that Paramount's bid topped the one from Netflix and the streamer bowed out. Paramount paid a \$2.8-billion termination fee to Netflix and signed the merger agreement on Feb. 27.

Warner's board is advising its shareholders to approve the Paramount deal. Failure to cast a vote will be the same as a no-vote, according to the company's proxy.

Warner's largest share-

holders include the Vanguard Group, BlackRock, Inc. and State Street Corp.

Zaslav has significant stock and options holdings, worth about \$517 million at the deal's close, according to the proxy.

The regulatory filing also disclosed that a mysterious bidder had surfaced at the auction's 11th hour.

A firm called Nobelis Capital, Pte., reportedly based in Singapore, alerted Warner on Feb. 18 that it was

willing to pay \$32.50 a share in cash.

The firm said it had placed \$7.5 billion into an escrow account. However, Warner's bankers "could not find the purported deposit at J.P. Morgan," according to the proxy. And there was no evidence that Nobelis had any assets or any "equity or debt financing" lined up, Warner said, adding that it "took no further action with respect to the Nobelis proposal."

BUSINESS

From ‘drive-through’ to a destination city

[Culver City, from A1] was coming to Culver City.

Culver City residents “spend a significant amount of time commuting and are increasingly impacted by affordability challenges,” making it a good fit for a new Ikea store, company spokesperson Briana Lehman said in a statement.

The Helms Design District was a good fit for Ikea because it is a “historic Los Angeles destination” known for its restaurants and home furnishings businesses, the company said. The complex is also home to a Scandinavian Designs store, The Rug Warehouse, Room and Board, among other retail businesses.

The 11-acre Helms complex is the former home of the Helms bakery, famous for the butter yellow trucks that once zoomed across Southern California delivering fresh bread and for being an official supplier for the 1932 Olympics — a distinction still proudly displayed on a rooftop sign.

The bakery shut down in 1969 because the founder did not want his company to unionize, The Times once reported. The Marks family real estate firm bought the property in 1972 and turned it into a center for home furnishings and antiques.

The charm of Culver City is understandable because the former whistle-stop between downtown L.A. and the ocean has emerged as one of the region's top choices for creative businesses, including HBO, Amazon and Apple, which is building a splashy new office complex on the border of Culver City and Los Angeles.

Another newcomer is tech company Pinterest, which opened a new office in Culver City in January.

For years, city leaders have worked to cultivate a business-friendly image while managing some growing pains.

It eliminated parking requirements for new development, making it less expensive to build housing, new shops and restaurants. The city also has a small-business assistance program to reduce permit costs and provide advice to start-ups.

Improving housing affordability is another priority, the mayor said. The average home costs more than \$1.2 million, and longtime residents have expressed worries that the influx of well-paid tech employees will push up rents and exacerbate the area's housing shortage.

More units are on the way, Puza said, citing efforts to meet the Southern California Assn. of Governments' target of adding 3,341 units to Culver City by 2029.

“We have 4,400 units in the pipeline,” he said, and “600 of those are affordable.”

A maker city

“Culver City has always been a ‘maker city’ for people who make things,” said



Photographs by MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

CULVER CITY owes its rising appeal partly to the tech sector boom. Above, Metro's E Line near Ivy Station.



“GONE With the Wind” and 1937’s “A Star Is Born” were made on this studio lot.

Hackman, whose company Hackman Capital Partners owns Culver Studios, where the classics “Gone With the Wind” and 1937’s “A Star Is Born” were filmed. Amazon MGM Studios now makes movies and shows for its Prime channel there.

“Creatives have really latched on to the Culver City area,” Hackman said.

The low-key linear city evolved along railroad lines and roads connecting downtown Los Angeles with Abbot Kinney's resort city Venice, making it a self-contained outpost in the early 20th century. Its personality, however, lost luster after World War II, as it was engulfed by the sprawl of Los Angeles.

The presence of famed movie studios, including the former Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer headquarters, always provided some glamour, but when car dealerships started replacing former roadhouses and speakeasies in the 1950s, Culver City took



A VINTAGE clock adorns the city’s downtown area. Perceptions of Culver City have changed over time.

on a decidedly suburban vibe.

Over the years, Culver City Stadium was replaced

by a shopping center, and a Costco now stands on the

site of the Culver Dog Track, where greyhounds and, lat-

er, cars raced. The Culver City Airport, where city founder Harry Culver kept his own plane, closed to make way for a supermarket and an Earl Scheib auto-painting outlet.

With the cessation of train service in the 1950s and the 1965 opening of the Santa Monica Freeway, Culver City became a bit of an island, with its own police force and conservative sensibility.

“It was a drive-through city,” said Walter N. “Wally” Marks III, whose family bought the recently defunct Helms Bakery in 1971. “You didn’t stop here.”

Now, he said, “Culver City has been found.”

A tech boom

One of the reasons it has gained appeal is the economic boom the tech industry brought to the Westside two decades ago, grabbing up offices in what became known as Silicon Beach. In search of space, companies looked away from the ocean. More recently, the region also has become a growing hub for aerospace startups.

“It was obviously glitzier to be at the beach,” Marks said, but Culver City had the room, and its location east of the 405 Freeway turned out to be a plus as traffic to the west grew unbearable at some hours of the day.

Architect and Santa Monica escapee Lise Bornstein says a broader shift is lifting Culver City.

“I feel like the energy center in L.A. is being pulled east more and more, like the city itself is pulling,” she said.

Her firm, KFA, bailed out of Santa Monica in 2019.

“We were starting to lose out on employees because driving to Santa Monica was a deep, deep, dark thing,” Bornstein said, “and we were busting at our seams.”

KFA landed in a manufacturing building from the 1940s, last used by a china importer that was converted to an airy office by the architects.

It's one of several former industrial buildings in Culver City's Hayden Tract area that was developed by Sam Hayden after World War II. It's now a cluster of buildings with creative uses, some of which were designed by architect Eric Owen Moss in a plan to turn the district into a “laboratory” for experimental, avant-garde design.

Near KFA's office is Moss' undulating, steel-clad Waffle building, which is occupied by the two-Michelin-star restaurant Vespertine. . It's part of the mix in the Hayden Tract, which includes pottery studios and a whiskey distillery.

In November 2024, a new version of Helm's Bakery from restaurateur Sang Yoon opened in a 14,000-square-foot lot in the district, but it closed in December due to lagging sales. Two restaurants — a pizzeria and Japanese restaurant — plan to open in the district this spring, according to the district's Instagram account.

The new Pop Mart headquarters will occupy a Moss-designed building on Hayden Avenue known as Slash for its tilted windows and jagged design.

The company said it was drawn to Culver City because of its proximity to L.A.'s creative industries, which shape global pop culture.

“Pop Mart sits at the intersection of art, design, and entertainment, making Culver City, with its concentration of film studios and innovative technology companies, an ideal base,” Larry Lu, president of Pop Mart for the Americas, said in a statement to The Times.

The historic downtown near the 1920s landmark Culver Hotel, where movie stars used to stay while working at studios nearby, has the charm of a small city. Officials renovated its public spaces, such as sidewalks and medians, years ago in an effort to attract new businesses. In 2021, they launched one of the most ambitious street redesigns in the region that reconfigured pedestrian, traffic, bus, and bicycle lanes to reduce congestion and emissions.

Reviews on the program to improve walking, bicycling and use of public transit remain mixed, at least among drivers.

“Navigation there is a little hard,” said Bornstein, who won't drive on a stretch of Washington Boulevard. “It's insane. There are too many things to look out for.”

If Culver City can find the right path to interweaving pedestrians, bicycles, public transit and cars, the results could be an example for other cities in the region, she said. “I'm interested to see how it plays out and what changes they might make.”

MARKET ROUNDUP

Oil prices rise as Wall Street struggles with war in Iran

By STAN CHOE

Stocks fell sharply Thursday, and oil prices rose as doubt took over again from hope on Wall Street about a possible end to the war with Iran.

The Standard & Poor's 500 index slumped 1.7% for its worst day since January and is back on track for a fifth straight losing week. That stretches back to before the Iran war began, and it would be the longest such losing streak in nearly four years.

The Dow Jones industrial average dropped 469 points, or 1%, and the Nasdaq composite sank 2.4% to fall more than 10% below its all-time high set this year. That's a steep enough drop that professional investors have a name for it: a “correction.”

Stock markets likewise tumbled across much of Asia and Europe. They're the latest flip-flops for financial markets in a week that began with big hopes after President Trump said productive talks had taken place about ending the war. But Iran denied direct talks were underway and then

dismissed a U.S. proposal for a ceasefire that was delivered via Pakistan.

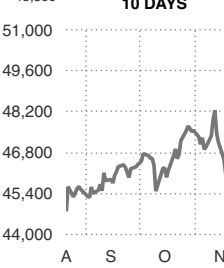
On Thursday, the fighting continued, and thousands more U.S. troops neared the region. Iran, meanwhile, tightened its grip on the crucial Strait of Hormuz. It may be creating something like a “toll booth” for tankers to get past the narrow waterway, which typically sees a fifth of the world's oil exit the Persian Gulf through it to customers worldwide.

The price for a barrel of Brent crude oil climbed 4.8% to settle at \$101.89 as hopes dimmed for a potential return to normal for the strait. That's up from roughly \$70 before the war began. Benchmark U.S. crude rose 4.6% to \$94.48 per barrel.

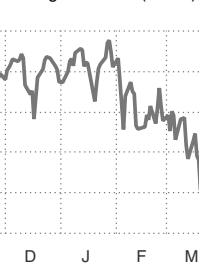
“They better get serious soon, before it is too late,” Trump said on his social media website about Iran's negotiators, “because once that happens, there is NO TURNING BACK, and it won't be pretty!”

The rise in oil prices worsened worries about high inflation and sent Treasury yields higher in the bond market.

Dow Jones industrials
Close: 45,960.11
Change: -469.38 (-1.0%)



Nasdaq composite
Close: 21,408.08
Change: -521.74 (-2.4%)



StocksRecap

	HIGH	LOW	CLOSE	CHG	%CHG	WK	MO	QTR	YTD
DOW	46,547.59	45,910.75	45,960.11	-469.38	-1.01%	▲	▼	▼	-4.38%
DOW Trans.	18,519.81	18,279.75	18,368.70	-72.36	-0.39%	▲	▼	▲	+5.83%
DOW Util.	1,148.29	1,135.69	1,147.86	+7.85	+0.69%	▲	▲	▲	+7.47%
NYSE Comp.	22,127.62	21,832.52	21,843.97	-283.65	-1.28%	▲	▼	▼	-0.73%
NASDAQ	21,823.58	21,395.77	21,408.08	-521.74	-2.38%	▲	▼	▼	-7.89%
S&P 500	6,573.22	6,473.79	6,477.16	-114.74	-1.74%	▲	▼	▼	-5.38%
S&P 400	3,417.23	3,362.37	3,365.63	-48.35	-1.42%	▲	▼	▲	+1.83%
Wilshire 5000	68,928.32	67,094.23	68,217.21	-711.12	-1.03%	—	▼	▲	+0.01%
Russell 2000	2,534.64	2,490.51	2,493.32	-43.06	-1.70%	▲	▼	▲	+0.46%

The yield on the 10-year Treasury jumped to 4.42% from 4.33% late Wednesday and from just 3.97% before the war started. That's a significant leap for the bond market, and it's already sent rates higher for mortgages and other kinds of loans for U.S. households and businesses, which slows the economy.

A report Thursday morning said slightly more U.S. workers filed for unemployment

benefits last week, though the number is still low compared with historical figures.

A slowing job market would typically encourage the Federal Reserve to cut interest rates to boost the economy. But hopes have cratered on Wall Street for a possible cut to interest rates this year, even though traders came into 2026 forecasting several. That's because lower interest rates

carry the risk of worsening inflation, and the jump in oil prices has heightened those worries.

On Wall Street, tech stocks were the heaviest weights on the market.

Meta Platforms fell 8%, and Alphabet sank 3.4% after each had held relatively steady the day before, when a jury found Instagram and YouTube liable in a landmark social-media addiction trial.

The financial penalties were small compared with the companies' vast profits, but it could herald a watershed moment that invites more lawsuits.

Other Big Tech stocks also fell, including drops of 4.2% for Nvidia and 2% for Amazon. Apple was an outlier and inched up 0.1%.

Commercial Metals fell 4.7% after the maker of steel rebar and other products reported a weaker profit for the latest quarter than analysts expected. Chief Executive Peter Matt said bad weather hurt its North American operations during the quarter.

All told, the S&P 500 fell 114.74 points to 6,477.16 and is 7.2% below its all-time high set two months ago. The Dow dropped 469.38 to 45,960.11. The Nasdaq composite sank 521.74 to 21,408.08.

In stock markets abroad, Germany's DAX lost 1.5%, Hong Kong's Hang Seng sank 1.9% and South Korea's Kospi dropped 3.2%. Japan's Nikkei 225 had one of the milder losses, at 0.3%.

Choe writes for the Associated Press.

BUSINESS

Limits on workers hit seasonal seafood

Louisiana's crawfish industry relies on foreign employees, and can't get any.

By Stephen Smith and Jack Brook

Spring is peak season in Louisiana for crawfish, the hard-shelled star of outdoor parties. But a shortage of foreign workers is dampening the mood.

Deep in Louisiana's bayous, where crawfish production is a \$300-million industry that is a key ingredient for backyard boils and buttery etouffees served in New Orleans' French Quarter, operators are fuming over labor struggles and pointing fingers at President Trump's administration over what they say has been a failure to authorize enough guest foreign workers.

The shortages add to a list of industries in the U.S. that rely on seasonal foreign labor, including landscaping and construction, whose struggle to fill jobs has been exacerbated during the Trump administration's wider clampdown on legal avenues for immigration. In Louisiana, the need for crawfish workers has strained an industry that is a symbol of state pride and frustrated Republican officeholders, many of whom broadly support Trump's hard-line immigration agenda but say their pleas for more legal laborers have gone unanswered.

"People have built businesses around these workers and this year we can't get them," said Alan Lawson, who runs a crawfish production facility in the rural town of Crowley. "This industry would not exist without it because the American people don't want to do the jobs we're offering."

Large-scale crawfish producers use guest workers, many from Mexico and Central America, to shell



GERALD HERBERT Associated Press

JUAN Antonio harvests a trap full of crawfish, which are in their peak season.

and freeze the freshwater catch that is often pulled from swampy rice fields. They are hired on H-2B visas for nonfarming jobs and are allowed to stay in the U.S. for less than a year after businesses first offer the jobs to Americans.

The Department of Homeland Security is required to release 66,000 H-2B visas each year and can release nearly double that amount. But that process happened later than usual this year — after Louisiana's crawfish season had already begun.

Homeland Security did not respond to multiple requests for comment. The Department of Labor said it respects the crawfish industry and importance to the U.S. economy, and that the agency "has been actively engaging with industry stakeholders to help address workforce needs and identify workable solutions."

But even if guest workers arrive before crawfish season ends around June, Lawson says, the damage is done. Restaurant owners and processors say crawfish

prices could spike for consumers already struggling with affordability.

High demand for seasonal workers

U.S. businesses' increasing reliance on seasonal foreign workers to do grueling jobs predates the Trump administration. The federal government has not kept pace with the expanding need, and Trump's immigration crackdown also has impacted the labor market. Businesses are seeking tens of thousands more guest workers than the federal government has made available, according to Labor Department data.

"The demand is there but the supply is not," Louisiana Farm Bureau Federation Public Policy Coordinator Andy Brown said. "These businesses want to follow the law. They want to go through the legal parameters to meet their labor needs."

Most seasons at Lawson's facility, the job of peeling and packaging thousands of pounds of the sweet-tasting, bright red

crustaceans is handled by more than 100 foreign workers. None have been allowed to come this season.

Homeland Security can begin offering supplemental visas in consultation with the Labor Department at the start of the federal fiscal year in October. However, the Trump administration did not release supplemental visas until February. Initially, it capped them at 35,000, or roughly half what the Biden administration authorized. The Trump administration eventually agreed to release nearly 65,000 supplemental visas — on par with recent years — following pressure from businesses.

15 of 20 plants have no guest workers

Louisiana officials say the federal government rejected many crawfish producers' applications because they listed start dates before January. Homeland Security told Lawson that his company was not eligible because he had applied months earlier, according to a February rejection notice

he showed to the Associated Press.

At least 15 of the state's 20 major crawfish processing plants have no guest workers this year, according to Louisiana Department of Agriculture and Forestry Commissioner Mike Strain. The Republican said the Trump administration's indifference to their plight has been "unacceptable."

Crawfish processors say that despite advertising locally for months for their peeling jobs, only a handful of Americans have turned up for seasonal gigs paying around \$13 an hour.

"I can't put the crawfish somewhere else. They have to be peeled at this time," said processor David Savoy. "The locals don't want to do it, I've tried — standing on concrete for seven, eight hours a day, peeling crawfish until your hands hurt."

Some immigration law experts said the crawfish industry's labor shortage reflects the administration's attitude toward legal immigration.

"There's much less of a push to facilitate legal immigration," said Julia Gelatt, associate director of the U.S. Immigration Policy Program at the Migration Policy Institute. "It's not a high priority to make sure that the immigration system is moving smoothly."

Crawfish farmers will have fewer options to sell their products and the price of frozen tail meat in grocery stores will rise, processors warn.

Chandra Chifci, who owns the New Orleans seafood restaurant Deanie's, is worried she won't be able to stockpile enough Louisiana crawfish to get through the monthslong off-season.

"Some companies might not be able to have some of their dishes on the menu," Chifci said. "When tourists come into town, that's what they're here for."

Smith and Brook write for the Associated Press.

Recurring jobless claims hit a 22-month low

By Julia Fanzeres

Recurring applications for unemployment benefits fell to the lowest level in almost two years, indicating ongoing stability in the labor market despite fresh economic headwinds.

Continuing claims, a proxy for the number of people receiving benefits, fell by 32,000 to 1.819 million in the week ended March 14, the lowest since May 2024, according to Labor Department data released Thursday. Initial claims increased by 5,000 last week, to 210,000.

Filings have remained subdued despite high-profile companies such as Paramount Skydance Corp.'s CBS News and Meta Platforms Inc. announcing job cuts. Many experts have downgraded their forecasts for the U.S. economy this year and boosted projections for unemployment after a surge in oil prices sparked by the Iran war.

But initial claims are settling near some of the lowest levels seen in the last year, signaling the labor market continues to be in a low-fir-

ing environment.

The four-week moving average of new applications, a metric that helps smooth out volatility, edged down to 210,500. Before adjusting for seasonal factors, initial claims fell. Kentucky and Ohio registered the largest declines.

Abiel Reinhart, an economist at JPMorgan Chase & Co., said the decline in continuing claims could be a good sign for upcoming jobs reports.

"The number of unemployed on permanent layoff had kept rising through February in the employment report, but continuing claims are one sign that you could soon see the unemployment rate level off or decline," Reinhart said in a note following the release. "That depends, of course, on the magnitude and duration of the recent energy shock."

Others, such as Oliver Allen at Pantheon Macroeconomics, said rising long-term unemployment and difficulties among first-time job seekers may weaken the signal about the extent of joblessness in the U.S. conveyed by the continuing



Associated Press

CONTINUING claims fell to 1.819 million in the week ended March 14, data show.

claims numbers. Neil Dutta, head of economics at Renaissance Macro Research, also suggested they are out of step with weak perceptions of the labor market in consumer surveys.

The number of Americans unemployed for at least 27 weeks has almost doubled

over the last three years, and stood at 1.9 million — or 25% of all unemployed persons — in February, according to monthly Bureau of Labor Statistics employment data. Workers in most states are eligible for up to 26 weeks of regular unemployment benefits, though some provide

fewer.

"Layoffs being low is the main story," Dutta said. But "continuing claims are somewhat at odds with consumer attitudes around job finding."

Fanzeres writes for Bloomberg.

Firms may raise prices quickly amid war

By David McHugh

The head of the European Central Bank says that businesses may be quicker to raise prices in response to the oil shock from the Iran war due to bitter memories of the inflation spike after Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

If oil and gas prices continue to rise, "the response of firms and workers may be faster than last time," ECB President Christine Lagarde said Wednesday in the text of a speech at a conference in Frankfurt, Germany. "We have a more recent memory of high inflation, which could affect how quickly costs are passed on and compensation is sought," Lagarde said.

Even though the ECB brought the 2022 inflation spike under control with higher interest rates, "that experience has left a mark," she said. "An entire generation has now lived through its first episode of high inflation — and it may not be as slow to react a second time." Inflation in the countries that use the euro currency peaked at 10.6% in October 2022 after the invasion led to the cutoff of most Russian natural gas supplies and sent oil prices temporarily higher. Inflation in February was 1.9%, according to EU statistics agency Eurostat.

Lagarde pointed out that monetary policy cannot lower oil prices, and that central banks typically look past transitory energy spikes without raising interest rates. Raising rates only makes sense if higher energy prices start being built into prices for other goods and into workers' wages, producing a price spiral.

"If the energy shock is seen to be limited in size and short-lived, the classical prescription of looking through should apply," she said, because by the time rate hikes take effect with a lag of months, the inflationary spike is already gone. Central banks typically raise rates to fight inflation. That cools price increases by raising borrowing costs for things like house mortgages or building new production facilities.

She said there were reasons to think the current jump in oil prices might be less inflationary than feared, because the energy price spike is, so far, smaller than the one Europe experienced in 2021-2022. But if inflation appears to be heading persistently above the ECB's 2% target, "the response must be appropriately forceful or persistent."

Lagarde said it was "too early to say where in this spectrum we will need to be. ... We will monitor developments closely and set monetary policy as appropriate." The ECB left its key interest rate unchanged at 2% at its last policy meeting March 19.

McHugh writes for the Associated Press.

War hits global economy; 1 group projects 4.2% inflation in U.S.

By William Horobin

The conflict in the Middle East is reviving the specter of inflation and hobbling the global economy just as it was showing signs of strengthening at the start of the year, the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development said.

In its updated outlook Thursday, the Paris-based organization sharply increased its inflation forecasts for major economies and now sees the average rate for the Group of 20 this year jumping to 4% — with an even higher pace in the U.S. — rather than the 2.8% it predicted in December.

Downward adjustments to growth were less dramatic

in the short term, but largely because the drag from the Iran war was offset by better-than-expected momentum at the start of the year.

The OECD is the first of the major international economic institutions to formally update forecasts. Other indicators, such as business surveys, have begun to point to a synchronized global shock of weaker activity and rising prices.

The organization also warned that there is a "significant downside risk" to its projections from further disturbance of exports from the Middle East that would fuel inflation, reduce growth and potentially trigger repricing on financial markets.

"The breadth and duration of the conflict are very

uncertain, but a prolonged period of higher energy prices will add markedly to business costs and raise consumer price inflation, with adverse consequences for growth," the OECD said.

Disruption from the Iran war arrived just as the global economy was picking up tailwinds from investment in artificial intelligence, an easing of U.S. tariff rates and supportive monetary and fiscal policies.

Without the conflict, the OECD said it could have revised up its global growth forecast by 0.3 of a percentage point for 2026. Instead, it left that prediction unchanged at 2.9% and trimmed its figure for 2027 by 0.1 point to 3%.

The sudden change of the

economic backdrop is forcing policymakers to change tack. Last week, the Federal Reserve signaled that any cuts in U.S. borrowing costs remain a long way off. European Central Bank officials are considering a possible hike as soon as April, while Norwegian officials Thursday revealed that they had even discussed a move as soon as this week.

For the U.S., the OECD expects inflation to jump to 4.2% this year from 2.6% in 2025. Its price outlook for this year is 1.2 percentage points higher than in December, also because the labor market remains tight with slowing net migration and tariffs are adding upward pressure.

"We do think there is a

combination of factors that are likely to have a bearing on the inflation outlook in the U.S.," OECD Secretary-General Mathias Cormann said in an interview with Bloomberg Television.

The organization now expects policy rates to remain unchanged throughout 2026 in both the U.S. and the United Kingdom, while it foresees that the European Central Bank will hike rates once in the second quarter to ensure inflation expectations remain under control.

"Our current expectation is energy price effect will be temporary, and as such central banks would be able to take that into account," Cormann said. "But in the end, what we are saying to central banks is that they need to

continue to focus very closely on the data as it evolves and be very prudent to ensure that inflation expectations are well anchored."

The 38-member organization also urged governments carrying large debts racked up through spending during previous crises to refrain from broad-based subsidies and transfers.

"Measures to cushion the impact of higher energy prices should be timely, well-targeted on households most in need and viable firms, preserve incentives to lower energy use and have clear expiry mechanisms," the OECD said.

Horobin writes for Bloomberg.

OPINION VOICES

Voices **LZ GRANDERSON** COLUMNIST

TSA agents are too important to be used as political pawns

Agents’ pay should be reinstated, and made significantly higher to reflect their role in keeping the nation safe

ROUGHLY 50,000 Transportation Security Administration officers are expected to go a second pay period without a check as the argument over funding for the Department of Homeland Security heads into its seventh week.

Many Americans were already troubled by the images of masked federal immigration officers without warrants breaking down doors and using excessive force on women and children. After the killing of two Americans in Minneapolis sparked weeks of outrage and congressional hearings, the White House made changes in leadership by removing the head of Homeland Security and reassigning the Border Patrol commander. Democrats demand changes in accountability and training.

Because of the nation’s divide over brutal immigration enforcement, Congress has been at this impasse since February. If that seems like a long time to you, perhaps as you wait in an hours-long airport line, do keep in mind: TSA agents haven’t been paid since Valentine’s Day ... and we’re approaching Easter.

Looking to bring the officers some relief is Rep. Debbie Dingell (D-Mich.), who is again touting a bill she introduced last fall when the government was shut down and airport security officers weren’t being paid. Dingell also referenced the 2018-2019 shutdown, when “hundreds of TSA officers

called out sick or resigned after going weeks without pay, resulting in long security lines, missed flights and temporary terminal closures at major airports.”

“This bill makes sure their hard work is respected and their paychecks continue by redirecting unnecessary spending from President Trump’s ‘One Big Ugly Bill,’” Dingell said in a statement. “Keeping TSA fully funded during a shutdown isn’t just about fairness, it’s about maintaining national security and public confidence in air travel.”

I’m not much for “whataboutism,” however it seems to me that when Democrats won the White House and took control of Congress back in 2020, there was an opportunity or two for the party to pass a law freeing TSA officers from Washington’s pollution, to “keep air travel safe,” as Dingell’s bill aims to do. Yet for whatever reason, here we are in 2026, approaching a decade since that 2018 shutdown, and TSA agents are still political pingpong balls, living check to check ... without knowing when their next check will come.

Congress has always known of this vulnerability, of course, because senators and representatives are the ones in charge of the nation’s purse. Shamefully, neither party will prioritize this element of national security so that it won’t be dragged repeatedly into political theater.

The 9/11 terrorist attack



MEGAN VARNER Getty Images

IMMIGRATION agents check IDs at the Atlanta airport, as unpaid TSA agents call out or resign.

prompted the creation of TSA in just over two months. Before then, most of the nation’s airport security was provided by private contractors with high turnover. We didn’t nationalize our security until we learned the hijackers had been able to walk on board without any real scrutiny.

The agency wasn’t created so lawmakers could have another lever to pull in negotiations. The nation had just been attacked, thousands died, and we were afraid. The TSA was meant to calm some of those fears.

Given that we are currently at war with Iran, a country that openly wishes for our death and that finances a lot of terrorist groups, it just doesn’t seem like the right time to have that agency under unnecessary stress.

But Dingell’s bill does not address the fundamental issue that this particular shutdown has exposed and that is the fact the people who are important to our national security, people like TSA agents, are being paid so little that

they can’t afford to miss a paycheck without life falling apart. The bill Dingell introduced simply allows them to go back to living a paycheck-to-paycheck life regardless of what happens in Washington. A more appropriate bill given the circumstances we all are now witnessing would guarantee a base salary raise so that people who are working for the TSA don’t have to worry about whether they can feed their children.

People are not quitting as a political statement. They just can’t afford to wait for Congress. A TSA agent base salary of \$35,000 isn’t considered poor when using the official rubric established in the 1960s. Back then, food was the most expensive item in a household — estimated to cost a third of weekly income. The other two-thirds was meant for housing and other necessities. That was a long time ago, and now the most expensive item is housing. In Dingell’s district in Michigan, the average rent for a one-bedroom apartment is roughly \$1,500 — more than half

the base rate’s take-home pay.

Since 2011, the country has incorporated a secondary metric for measuring poverty that considers rent, health insurance and utilities in addition to food costs. Using that formula, according to our own government, a base pay of \$35,000 is near poverty.

Why are we paying agents so little for something we clearly need so much? Absentmindedly treating airport security labor as a commodity left us vulnerable in a pre-9/11 world. However, intentionally treating it as an expendable pawn in 2026 is just foolishness.

As each party tries to win the PR war during this partial government shutdown, elected officials on both sides of the aisle are asking Americans to thank TSA agents for working without pay. Considering that when they are being paid, missing a single paycheck still could unravel their lives, even in normal times we should be thanking them for working at all.

YouTube: @LZGrandersonShow

LETTERS



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

CALIFORNIA has drawn scrutiny over the lag between election day and results.

Simple fixes for slow elections

Re “California can have easy voting, quicker results,” Politics Voices, March 22

CALIFORNIA can absolutely make voting both easier and faster — but with a less convoluted approach than columnist Mark Z. Barabak suggests.

First, set a clear, firm standard: All mail-in ballots must be received by election day. No gray areas, no extended uncertainty. Voters who wait until the last minute can still participate — by dropping off their ballots in person at designated polling sites on election day. That preserves access while restoring timely results.

Second, strengthen confidence and speed by encouraging in-person voting with voter ID. Verifying identity at the point of voting eliminates the slow, error-prone process of signature matching after the fact. The result: ballots validated instantly, counts finalized sooner and greater public trust in the outcome.

Efficiency and integrity aren’t competing goals. With straightforward rules like these, California can — and should — deliver both.

BRIAN SUCKOW
Palo Alto

An easy fix presents itself to alleviate the majority of our voting returns woes: Remove the restrictions on early release of voting results accompanied with sufficient notification that these are not official results. Yes, we must check every last signature, but we should not be forced to wait up to a month to know outcomes.

Save the long waits for

the tight races; the majority of outcomes are quickly apparent.

JOHN C. NELSON
Los Angeles

Re “Democrats are flustered over governor’s race,” March 21

James Rainey’s article about the mess in the gu-

bernatorial race recommends ranked-choice voting as a way out. The system described is actually instant-runoff voting, the worst of several ranked-choice alternatives. It throws votes away, raising grave constitutional concerns.

By the nature of its algorithm, it fails to find the majority winner and often leads to paradoxical results.

Moreover, by requiring centralized tallying, it greatly slows the vote-counting process. Partial (e.g. precinct) counts do nothing but mislead voters and candidates as to the likely outcome.

In contrast, Condorcet voting, aka instant round-robin, pairs candidates head to head and finds the candidate who defeats all others. It’s also much simpler and can be done by hand if necessary or preferred.

KAREN A. WYLE
Bloomington, Ind.

Outrage over ballot seizure

Re “SoCal sheriff seizes 650,000 ballots,” March 23

I am outraged that the Riverside County sheriff took custody of voter ballots to conduct his own recount. Would he have given an attorney custody of DNA evidence so they could conduct their own testing?

A far simpler and safer approach — without losing the chain of custody of the ballots — would be to select a random set of the ballots (still within the registrar’s custody) and see if the percentage shows any statistical discrepancy with announced results.

THOMAS MUNNECKE
San Marcos

Re “SoCal sheriff seizes 650,000 ballots,” March 23

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THOMAS MUNNECKE
San Marcos

Re “Sheriff’s seizure of

650,000 ballots: What we know,” March 25

The article promising to reveal “what we know” about Riverside County Sheriff Bianco left out some important details.

Yes, his possibly illegal seizure of Proposition 50 ballots is clearly a PR stunt designed to raise his profile in the governor’s race. But voters should know that Bianco previously said he supports the Constitutional Sheriffs and Peace Officers Assn., which the Southern Poverty Law Center calls an extremist group. The association believes that a local sheriff’s powers supersede those of any agency, even the FBI or the state Department of Justice.

How disturbing that a leading candidate for governor could support such a clearly unconstitutional ideology.

Bianco even joined the Oath Keepers for a year in 2014. While he denounced the fact that some of its members participated in the events of Jan. 6, 2021, he defended the group overall, saying, “they stand for protecting the Constitution.”

California voters of all political stripes should reject Bianco and his extremist politics.

PAUL GLICKMAN
Sherman Oaks

Pushing back against Big Tech

Re “Data centers face state scrutiny,” March 23

Across the country — and in Southern California — people are standing up to Big Tech and saying they don’t want data centers using our water and raising energy bills.

By 2028, AI data centers are expected to use as much water as 18.5 million households. This is especially concerning for those of us

who get our water from the Colorado River, which is 25 years into a megadrought. Meanwhile, electricity rates could spike from increased demand, and public health could suffer from polluting fossil fuel-generating stations.

Communities like the one in Imperial, Calif., are leading the charge and shining a light on the damages these facilities could impose on our environment and quality of life.

We can back up these powerful local actions by calling for a national moratorium to immediately halt the buildout of these behemoths. No one should have to sacrifice their health so Big Tech can line its pockets.

NOAH ROPP
Santa Clarita

Re “Data centers face state scrutiny,” March 23

Let me make sure I have this right: The people who design AI want to build more data centers that cause significant health problems and use massive amounts of energy and water.

Neither I nor millions of other retirees have any need for it. We are not doing genetic research or looking for a cure for cancer. Many of us spend our time playing video games or writing snarky letters to the editor for the Los Angeles Times, and we are more than capable of doing that on our own. But, even if I wanted to do the right thing, there is no easy way to opt out of using AI.

What a wasteful use of resources. Makes you wonder if the techies have thought this through.

STEVEN RICE
Thousand Oaks

HOW TO WRITE TO US

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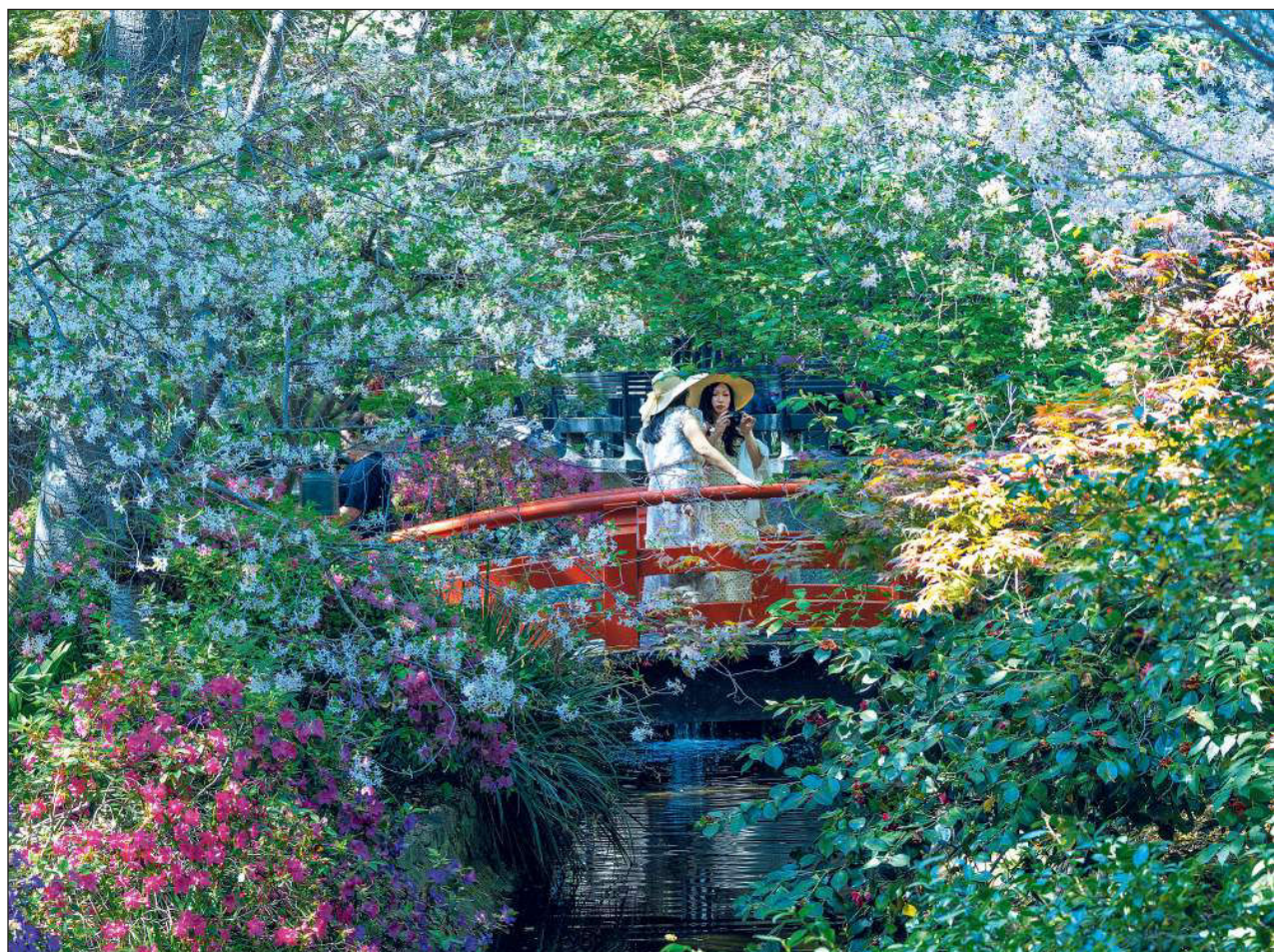
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CALIFORNIA

FRIDAY, MARCH 27, 2026 :: LATIMES.COM/CALIFORNIA



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

THE BRIDGE INTO SPRING

Dee Ngo and daughter Dee Ann Ngo visit Descanso Gardens' Japanese garden in La Cañada Flintridge.

Union says ICE presence is a workplace safety issue

Letter asserts hotel staff's right to leave if agents are on-site

By SUHAUNA HUSSAIN

The union representing thousands of local hospitality workers is demanding that Southern California hotels and stadiums refrain from hosting federal immigration agents as guests on their properties.

In a letter sent to scores of hotels, stadiums and airport vendors on Monday, Unite Here Local 11 said that after the chaos and violence in Minneapolis — where federal agents were

involved in the killings of two U.S. citizens — the presence of immigration personnel could pose a real danger to hospitality workers and guests alike.

The letter comes ahead of this summer's FIFA World Cup. U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement is expected to be part of the event's "overall security apparatus," according to comments by the agency's acting director, Todd Lyons, at a congressional hearing in February.

Ana Mendez, 43, who has worked

as a banquet server at J.W. Marriott for 15 years, said the events in Minneapolis had scared workers, many of whom are immigrants and have begun to worry about even commuting to work during the upcoming World Cup.

"We know ICE isn't just here to enforce the law, they are agitators, they are being violent, they are killing community members. ... Anything can happen," Mendez said. "The whole industry needs to understand [See [Unite Here](#), B4]

Deputy killed by grenade not properly taught, his widow says

Legal claim comes after July explosion at L.A. academy left three detectives dead.

By RICHARD WINTON AND SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

One of three L.A. County sheriff's deputies who died in a grenade blast last year was not formally trained to handle explosives and was exposed to danger by colleagues who disobeyed department bomb protocols and treated the live munition as if it were inert, according to a legal claim filed by the deputy's widow.

The July 18 explosion at the Biscailuz Center Training Academy killed Dets. Victor Lemus, Joshua Kelley-Eklund and William Osborn, and was the department's deadliest incident in more than 150 years. It has since sparked a series of investigations into what happened that day, including one by the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives into what caused the blast, as well as two criminal investigations into the deputies' deaths and the disappearance of a second grenade connected to the blast.

The legal claim filed recently by widow Nancy Lemus alleges new details in the run-up to the explosion.

The claim — a precursor to a lawsuit — not only accuses the department of failing to properly train Victor Lemus, but also alleges that Kelley-Eklund and Osborn failed to properly examine and handle the grenade. The claim argues that Lemus was relying on the expertise

of his fellow deputies and would not have expected them to bring a live grenade onto a training campus or use one for training purposes.

"Victor Lemus further would have understood that because he had not been trained, he would not be exposed to a live explosive device," the claim argues. "The Department is a paramilitary organization that ordered Victor Lemus to the Department's Bomb Squad but failed to provide him with minimum standards of training and exposed him to a deadly device that killed him."

A spokesperson for the Sheriff's Department confirmed that the department has been served with the claim, and that the investigation to determine exactly what happened is ongoing.

"We remain committed to thoroughly understanding the circumstances of this tragic incident and ensuring the safety of our personnel," a statement said. "The Department continues to mourn the loss of our three Arson Explosive Detail Detectives and remains committed to supporting their colleagues and families."

Lemus, a 40-year-old father of three, comes from a family of Sheriff's Department employees, including his wife, who is a detective, and his sisters, who are sergeants. He had worked two decades as a deputy but was new to the arson and explosive squad. So new in fact that his widow claims he had yet to undergo training for the handling of explosives.

"The Department failed to send Victor Lemus to the Federal Bureau of Investigation [See [Grenade](#), B5]

DE LOS Olvera Street's iconic burro stand loses eviction fight

By CARLOS DE LOERA

Jorge "El Burro," the frequently photographed stuffed donkey that has greeted visitors of Olvera Street for decades, won't be around for much longer.

On March 13, an L.A. judge ruled that the owner of the donkey stand, Richard Hernandez, was to be evicted.

"Good Bye Los Angeles it's been great!" reads a sign at the stand, called La Carreta. "Since 1968 the Hernandez family has brought you timeless memories. Generations have been photographed here. We lost our case with the City of Los Angeles, we want to stay.

But Mayor Bass won't negotiate."

The ruling handed down by Los Angeles County Superior Court is the culmination of a years-long saga involving the La Carreta owner and the city.

In 2024, Hernandez was given a 30-day eviction notice by the Board of Commissioners for the El Pueblo de Los Angeles Historical Monument Authority, which manages the historic and commercial resources of Olvera Street.

To try to resolve any problems the city may have had with the stand, Hernandez said, he has attempted to pay for any and all missed payments.

[See [Burro](#), B4]



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

A FAMILY takes a photo with Jorge the stuffed burro during Cinco de Mayo on Olvera Street in 2024.

Voices ANITA CHABRIA COLUMNIST

Bianco's ballot fraud crusade is a campaign stunt. It's also dangerous



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

SHERIFF Chad Bianco used a secret warrant to seize 650,000 ballots.

Voter fraud conspiracies are like methamphetamine running through MAGA veins, stirring up equal parts passion and

paranoia.

President Trump, of course, is the king pusher of this particular addiction, pathologically certain he won the 2020 presidential election (he did not). In his second term, and in advance of the November election, Trump has supercharged voter fraud lies; installed election deniers in key positions; and is attempting through the so-called SAVE America Act to disenfranchise poor and female voters.

Here in California, the seductive power of Trump's crusade can be seen in Riverside County, where gubernatorial candidate and Sheriff Chad Bianco is *definitely not* pursuing a vote fraud investigation for political

[See [Chabria](#), B5]

Voices STEVE LOPEZ COLUMNIST

A Republican could indeed be our next governor. A recall would begin soon after

Once upon a time in California, I went to the Orange County fairgrounds to watch Arnold Schwarzenegger give the signal for a wrecking ball to drop onto a vehicle.

The audience went wild, and Schwarzenegger went on to become governor and deliver on his promise to roll back a car tax increase, thereby

blowing a \$4-billion hole in the state budget.

I think it's fair to say that in the current gubernatorial campaign season, the excitement level is several decibels below what we experienced in 2003. But once again, it's fair to say we've not seen anything quite like this year's derby.

"There's no historical precedent in modern California history for a gover-

nor's race with such a large field or such an amorphous field of candidates," said longtime political observer Dan Schnur. "Unless you're paying very close attention, it feels like a big multi-headed political blob."

To break that down, eight Democrats and two Republicans are running in the primary, and here's the

[See [Lopez](#), B2]

A governor’s race without precedent in state’s history

[Lopez, from B1] craziest thing about that:

The Republicans could be the top two vote-getters because the Democrats have arranged themselves into a circular firing squad. While the Dems scramble for votes in the June 2 primary, the two Republicans lead in the polls because they’re splitting the GOP vote, and under the rules of the top-two primary, they could face off in the November election.

That means that California, which is one of the bluest states in the country and has nearly twice as many registered Democrats as Republicans, could end up with a Republican governor, which would be like having a Dodgers manager who wears a Yankees jersey in the dugout.

And by the way, if it happens, the Republican would be able to shuffle regulatory boards, attempt to squeeze budgets and create a bit of chaos, but still not get much accomplished because of Democratic supermajorities in the state Senate and Assembly.

And he would be targeted for recall even before he takes office. (More on that in a minute.)

There is a way for the Democrats to avoid this humiliation, but they can’t

seem to agree on anything at the moment. Party leaders have all but asked the candidates at the bottom of the polls to bow out, but understandably the response has been, “Why me? I’m no worse than the others.”

USC decided to host a debate night, a simple enough proposition, but then flubbed the deal by leaving four candidates off the invitation list — four candidates of color. A kerfuffle followed, and the debate was dumped, and an attempt to let everyone into the party fell apart.

So now what? It’s possible the Dems will huddle around one or two candidates who then move up in the polls and remove the threat of the unthinkable — two Republicans head-to-head. That would be Riverside County Sheriff Chad Bianco going against former Fox TV host Steve Hilton.

It’s also possible the Dems will play dirty and either spend money to promote one of the two Republican candidates or torpedo one of them. All they want, at the moment, is for a Democrat to make it past the primary, because that would all but ensure victory in November, given voter registration advan-

tages.

And then, if that doesn’t work, there’s the recall scenario.

“You could shut it down probably within five or six months,” said Mike Madrid, a longtime California GOP political consultant.

“It would surely happen,” said Rob Stutzman, a GOP strategist who helped Schwarzenegger knock Gov. Gray Davis out of office, and take his job, in the 2003 recall.

A wealthy Democratic donor could bankroll the recall campaign, Stutzman said. Or public employee unions might put up the money, given that a Republican winner is likely to create a state version of Elon Musk’s ham-handed attempt to fire nearly everyone on the federal payroll.

“The pitch,” Stutzman said of the recall strategy in an email, would be that “Trump still looms and CA must resist, and a GOP gov is a fluke of weird election law. Difficult to imagine it wouldn’t succeed.”

I thought of one more approach the Democrats could use to make sure at least one of them is on the ballot in November. Tom Steyer, a leader for many years on one of the most critical issues in California

and the world, climate change, has already spent tens of millions of dollars on TV ads that run about every two minutes, promoting him as the best candidate for governor.

They’re so repetitious, you can’t help but tune them out.

But everyone would pay close attention if Steyer instead ran ads offering incentives for either Bianco or Hilton to leave the state. Steyer could offer \$10 million cash for Bianco to move to Hawaii, and maybe throw in a beach house. He could buy a private jet for Hilton to take him back to his native Britain. Every day, there could be new ads upping the ante until one of them leaves the Golden State.

Wouldn’t that be a better use of Steyer’s money? It might even get him elected.

To be honest, having some honest pushback against Democratic authority in California wouldn’t be a terrible thing. It’s not as if Gov. Gavin Newsom and other Democrats are winning the battle against homelessness, housing shortages, affordability and other big challenges, and voters understandably want more — way more — for their tax dollars.

An experienced, nonsense, sensible, fiscally

conservative GOP candidate would do the state good.

The problem is that the two Republicans in the running, Bianco and Hilton, are Trump toadies.

In an embarrassingly amateurish political stunt, Bianco blew the president a kiss and all but begged for an endorsement by seizing 650,000 ballots from last November’s election to determine whether they were fraudulently counted.

Hilton recently said in an interview with ABC’s Eyewitness News 7 that he believes “everybody supports” Trump’s immigration policies.

Hilton might have missed the news that U.S.-born residents are carrying their passports in case they’re targeted by skin color. That Californians by the thousands have joined the resistance. That despite claims, most deportees don’t have criminal records. And that even some of the state’s GOP lawmakers have begged Trump to stop raiding industries that rely on immigrant help (and are often owned by Republicans).

And by the way, is this a smart time for a GOP candidate in California to be doing his best Trump impression?

The president’s popularity is down, consumer prices are up, he’s shamelessly pardoned drug lords and Jan. 6 barbarians, he thinks the presidency is a game of Battleship after promising to keep us out of wars, gas prices are sky high, he just said he was glad that Vietnam War hero and former FBI Director Robert Mueller had died, and he’s playing golf all day as if everything’s hunky-dory.

Like I said, there’s not a big-name character like Schwarzenegger in the race, but that doesn’t mean there aren’t good options. If you like Bianco or Hilton, so be it. Otherwise I suggest you read up on the other eight:

Steyer, state Supt. of Public Instruction Tony Thurmond, former L.A. mayor and legislative leader Antonio Villaraigosa, former Rep. Katie Porter, former state attorney general and U.S. Health and Human Services Secretary Xavier Becerra, former state Controller Betty Yee, San José Mayor Matt Mahan and U.S. Rep. Eric Swalwell.

And you’d better act fast. The primary is less than 10 weeks away.

steve.lopez@latimes.com

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SUMMONS (CITACION JUDICIAL)

Case Number (Numero del Caso): 25VEC03191

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(AVISO AL DEMANDADO):**
Tara Village HOA; and Does 1-25, inclusive

**(YOU ARE BEING SUED BY PLAINTIFF:
(LO ESTA DEMANDANDO EL DEMANDANTE):**
Frank Sarrafi

NOTICE! You have been sued. The court may decide against you without your being heard unless you respond within 30 days. Read the information below. You have 30 CALENDAR DAYS after this summons and legal papers are served on you to file a written response at this court and have a copy served on the plaintiff. A letter or phone call will not protect you. Your written response must be in proper legal form if you want the court to hear your case. There may be a court form that you can use for your response. You can find these court forms and more information at the California Courts Online Self-Help Center (www.courtinfo.ca.gov/selfhelp), your county law library, or the courthouse nearest you. If you cannot pay the filing fee, ask the court clerk for a fee waiver form. If you do not file your response on time, you may lose the case by default, and your wages, money, and property may be taken without further warning from the court.

There are other legal requirements. You may want to call an attorney right away. If you do not know an attorney, you may want to call an attorney referral service. If you cannot afford an attorney, you may be eligible for free legal services from a nonprofit legal services program. You can locate these nonprofit groups at the California Legal Services Web Site (www.lawhelpcalifornia.org), the California Courts Online Self-Help Center (www.courtinfo.ca.gov/selfhelp), or by contacting your local court or county bar association. **NOTE:** The court has a statutory lien for waived fees and costs on any settlement or arbitration award of \$10,000 or more in a civil case. The court's lien must be paid before the court will dismiss the case.

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The Superior Court of California County of Los Angeles
6230 Sylmar Ave.
Van Nuys, CA 91401

The name, address, and telephone number of plaintiff's attorney, or plaintiff without an attorney, is: (El nombre, la dirección y el número de teléfono del abogado del demandante, o del demandante que no tiene abogado, es):
Sanaz Imani, Esq.; Mesriani Law Group
510 Arizona Ave.
Santa Monica, CA 90401
(310) 826-6300

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SUMMONS - AMENDED (CITACION JUDICIAL)

CASE NUMBER (Número del Caso):
30-2024-01437254-CU-BC-CJC

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MALEX HOUSING, LLC, A California Limited Liability Company; MALEK HANNA, an individual.

YOU ARE BEING SUED BY PLAINTIFF (LO ESTÁ DEMANDANDO EL DEMANDANTE): SHENGMIN JIN, an individual; SKYE JIN, an individual.

NOTICE! You have been sued. The court may decide against you without your being heard unless you respond within 30 days. Read the information below. You have 30 CALENDAR DAYS after this summons and legal papers are served on you to file a written response at this court and have a copy served on the plaintiff. A letter or phone call will not protect you. Your written response must be in proper legal form if you want the court to hear your case. There may be a court form that you can use for your response. You can find these court forms and more information at the California Courts Online Self-Help Center (www.courtinfo.ca.gov/selfhelp), your county law library, or the courthouse nearest you. If you cannot pay the filing fee, ask the court clerk for a fee waiver form. If you do not file your response on time, you may lose the case by default, and your wages, s, or any settlement or arbitration award of \$10,000 or more in a civil case. The court's lien must be paid before the court will dismiss the case.

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Central Justice Center
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Elizabeth Opuni Afriye, Esq.
9465 Wilshire Blvd. Ste 300
Beverly Hills, CA 92701
213-794-7580

DATE (Fecha): 11/15/2024
/s/ by: DAVID H. YAMASAKI Clerk of the Court, Clerk (Secretario),
/s/ by: S. Berry, Deputy Clerk (Adjunto)
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2/27, 3/6, 3/13, 3/20/26

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Los Angeles Times

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LEGAL NOTICE

LOS ANGELES COUNTY SANITATION DISTRICTS
SIGNIFICANT NONCOMPLIANCE OF INDUSTRIAL WASTE PRETREATMENT REQUIREMENTS

For Calendar Year 2025
The United States Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) General Pretreatment Regulations for Existing and New Sources of Pollution, 40 CFR Part 403, require the Los Angeles County Sanitation Districts to publish on an annual basis a list of Industrial Users which, during the previous 12 months, were significantly violating applicable Pretreatment Standards or other Pretreatment Requirements. For the purpose of this provision, significant noncompliance is defined under 40 CFR 403.8 (f)(2)(vii) and 55 Federal Register 30882 as, (1) Chronic violations of wastewater discharge limits, defined here as those in which 66 percent or more of all of the measurements taken for the same pollutant parameter during a 6-month period exceed (by any magnitude) a numeric Pretreatment Standard or Requirement, including instantaneous limits, as defined by 40 CFR 403.30; (2) Technical Review Criteria (TRC) violations, defined here as those in which 33 percent or more of all of the measurements taken for the same pollutant parameter during a 6-month period exceed (by any magnitude) the numeric Pretreatment Standard or Requirement including instantaneous limits, as defined by 40 CFR 403.30; (3) Multiple violations of Pretreatment Standards, including but not limited to, (a) Interference or Pass Through (including endangering the health of POTW personnel or the general public); (4) Any discharge of a pollutant that has caused imminent endangerment to human health, welfare or to the environment or has resulted in the POTW's exercise of its emergency authority under paragraph (d)(1)(v)(K5) of this section to halt or prevent such a discharge; (5) Failure to meet, within 90 days after the schedule date, a compliance schedule milestone contained in a local control mechanism or enforcement order for starting construction, completing construction, or attaining final compliance; (6) Failure to comply with compliance schedules; (7) Failure to accurately report, monitor, or report, 90-day compliance reports, periodic self-monitoring reports, or compliance with compliance schedules; (8) Any other violation or group of violations, which may include a violation of Best Management Practices (BMPs) or other determinations will adversely affect the operation or implementation of the local Pretreatment program. For the purpose of this provision, "Pretreatment Standards" means any regulation concerning pollutant discharge limits promulgated by the EPA in accordance with section 307 (b) and (c) of the Clean Water Act, including but not limited to, (1) National Pollutant Discharge Limits established pursuant to Section 403.8 (f)(2)(vii) and 55 Federal Register 30882, (2) National Pollutant Discharge Limits established pursuant to Section 403.8 (f)(2)(viii) and 55 Federal Register 30882, (3) National Pollutant Discharge Limits established pursuant to Section 403.8 (f)(2)(ix) and 55 Federal Register 30882, (4) National Pollutant Discharge Limits established pursuant to Section 403.8 (f)(2)(x) and 55 Federal Register 30882, (5) National Pollutant Discharge Limits established pursuant to Section 403.8 (f)(2)(xi) and 55 Federal Register 30882, (6) National Pollutant Discharge Limits established pursuant to Section 403.8 (f)(2)(xii) and 55 Federal Register 30882, (7) National Pollutant Discharge 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CITY & STATE

Busted for gun possession, he’s now running for L.A. City Council

By Noah Goldberg

When Estuardo Mazariegos was 22, he was pulled over by Los Angeles police officers who found a gun and ammunition in the back seat of his Nissan Sentra.

The gun, he said, was not his. He was holding on to it for a friend, he said, but he got hit with a felony gun possession charge, later pleading it down to a misdemeanor.

Seventeen years later, Mazariegos is running for Los Angeles City Council — and he believes his gun conviction makes him a better candidate.

“I think it’s a strength. It’s not a liability,” said Mazariegos, who was born in Guatemala and grew up in Hollywood and South L.A. “I feel like it creates more of a connection with me and the community, because there’s so many people that are justice-impacted.”

But the gun charge could also be an issue for Mazariegos in his race against five other candidates to represent Council District 9, which covers part of South L.A. He was also convicted of shoplifting when he was 19.

The district is the poorest the city, and the council race is expected to be one of the most competitive city

contests this June, with the current council member, Curren Price, terming out.

Mazariegos is head of the Alliance of Californians for Community Empowerment Los Angeles, a grassroots advocacy organization. The 40-year-old is backed by the L.A. chapter of the Democratic Socialists of America and supports leftist policies such as reducing funding to the Los Angeles Police Department to spend more on other programs.

Jose Ugarte, a District 9 candidate who was a long-time Price staffer, believes his opponent’s criminal history is a red flag.

“Getting arrested and convicted for multiple crimes, including carrying a concealed loaded gun, should disqualify Estuardo in this race,” Ugarte said in a statement. “Instead, the Democratic Socialists of L.A. are propping up his candidacy and hiding his criminal past from voters who deserve to know the truth.”

DSA-LA co-chair Leslie Chang said her group is “proud” to stand with Mazariegos.

Georgia Flowers-Lee, a vice president with United Teachers Los Angeles, said Mazariegos discussed his gun conviction and the circumstances surrounding it during his interviews with

the union, which ended up endorsing him.

“He was up front, honest about the challenges and honest about the gun charge,” she said. “Walked us through what had happened and where it led and how and why he ended up pleading it out,” she said.

Wednesday night, Mazariegos released a campaign video featuring him discussing gun violence and his conviction with childhood friends. He said it was a turning point in his life.

“That was the moment where I was like, it’s either now or never,” he said. “Either I leave this s— behind, or it’s going to eat me up. I’m never going back to that lifestyle. I’m going to dedicate myself to the people.”

Mazariegos said he never carried a gun, except for that one day, but many of his friends did.

“Guns were a very common thing. It was almost like having a bike,” he said.

Mazariegos said that in 2009, he was driving home from the San Fernando Valley in the early morning, after dropping friends off, when he was pulled over by the LAPD. He said the officers gave no reason for stopping him, but they made him get out of his car and searched it without a warrant, finding the gun.



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

COUNCIL candidate Estuardo Mazariegos sees his long-ago gun conviction as a strength, not a liability.

He was a permanent resident at the time, after moving from Guatemala at a young age, and was advised by his attorney to plead guilty to a misdemeanor charge of carrying a concealed weapon in a vehicle, to avoid possible deportation, he said.

He was sentenced to 24 months of probation and one day in jail, records show.

The conviction helps him connect with residents of District 9, Mazariegos said, and he frequently discusses it while door-knocking.

Ugarte, meanwhile, is paying off \$25,000 in fines to the city Ethics Commission for failing to disclose years of outside income while he was working for Price.

Second fatal rattlesnake bite on a Southland hiking trail

By Clara Harter

A Ventura County woman has become the second to die recently from a rattlesnake bite on a Southern California hiking trail during an unusually active period of snake attacks and unseasonably warm weather.

The Ventura County Fire Department has received four reports of rattlesnake bites since March 14, according to department spokesperson Andrew Dowd. In comparison, the county recorded nine total bites in 2025.

The department responded to a call for a bite on a hiking trail at Wildwood Park just before noon on March 14. Paramedics took lifesaving measures and airlifted the patient to a hospital for treatment.

The woman who was bitten, later identified as 46-year-old Gabriela Bautista of Moorpark, died March 19 as a result of rattlesnake venom toxicity, according to the Ventura County medical examiner’s office.

The following day, the Fire Department rescued a teenage girl from the Wendy Trail in Newbury Park after she suffered a rattlesnake bite. Firefighters hiked up to access the victim and used a special wheeled stretcher to bring her down and transport her to a hospital in stable condition, Dowd said.

The two other recent rattlesnake bites in Ventura County were reported in Thousand Oaks and in Meiners Oaks, Dowd said.

On March 4, 25-year-old Julian Hernandez died in an Orange County hospital from a rattlesnake bite. Hernandez was wounded on Feb. 1 while hiking on Quail Hill in Irvine.

Rattlesnakes, which are typically most active in spring and summer, appear to have been drawn out earlier than usual this year as the Southland experiences the hottest March on record.

The U.S. Forest Service in San Bernardino issued a warning on Wednesday advising visitors of recent rattlesnake reports.

“As temperatures rise, rattlesnakes become more active in the forest,” the department stated. “Stay alert, watch where you step, and keep pets close.”

Greg Hardesty, a long-time trail runner who frequently runs in the foothills of Orange County, told The Times this month that he came across a big rattlesnake on March 4, noting that this was much earlier in the year than he typically sees serpents on the trails.

“When I run on trails, I’m always looking at the ground because the trails are rocky and you can fall easily,” Hardesty said. “That’s when I saw a large snake that looked like a baseball bat at first.”

Dowd said that as an avid hiker he understands the draw of the hundreds of miles of beautiful trails in Ventura County but noted that there are some very important safety tips the department wants everyone to be aware of.

“The first is to wear hik-

ing boots and long pants so that, should there be an encounter, that can hopefully provide some protection against a rattlesnake,” he said. “The second is to hike on clearly marked paths where you can see in front of you, so that you can avoid snakes.”

He strongly cautioned against wandering into areas of tall grass where rattlesnakes could be coiled up, and said that if hikers do encounter a snake the best thing to do is back away slowly and avoid contact.

Then there are the common safety tips hikers should abide by at all times of the year: Tell someone where you are going, carry plenty of water and ensure you have a charged phone or GPS device, he said.

In the event of a rattlesnake bite, Dowd reminds hikers to remain calm, call 911 and try to limit movement.

“The general recommendation is to avoid the use of tourniquets, to avoid trying to extract the venom, to communicate with anyone nearby and know that responders are on the way,” he said.

Despite the two recent fatalities, death by rattlesnake bite remains rare in the United States. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention estimates that about 8,000 people annually are bitten by venomous snakes, with fewer than 10 deaths.

Times staff writer Cierra Morgan contributed to this report.

Man arrested in rape, kidnappings

By Clara Harter

The UCLA Police Department has arrested a Santa Monica man on suspicion of kidnapping two female UCLA students and, in a separate incident, raping a woman unaffiliated with the university.

Officers arrested Alexander Schecter, 26, at his Santa Monica residence last Friday and booked him on one count of rape by force, one count of forcible oral copulation, one count of robbery, one count of extortion and one count of battery, police said.

He is not believed to be affiliated with the university, and his case will be presented to the L.A. County district attorney’s office for filing consideration.

Schecter was released on bond Saturday and is due back in court on April 15, according to the L.A. County Sheriff’s Department’s in-

mate information center. Detectives began investigating Schecter after two female students reported that a man prevented them from exiting his vehicle and threatened violence when they were being dropped off near campus around 3 a.m. March 8.

Detectives identified Schecter as the suspect in the incident and initially arrested him on March 12. He was booked on suspicion of kidnapping and false imprisonment and later posted bail and was released.

During their investigation, detectives uncovered evidence that they said linked Schecter to a previoed unreported sexual assault involving a separate female victim. That assault occurred on Oct. 12 between 2 and 5 a.m. in the area of Venice Boulevard and Clarington Avenue on the border of Palms and Culver City, police said.

The UCLA Police De-



UCLA Police Department

ALEXANDER Schecter, 26, was released on bond.

partment confirmed the details of the assault and developed probable cause to arrest Schecter for a second time on additional charges on Friday.

Detectives believe there may be additional victims and are asking anyone with information to contact the department’s investigations division at (310) 825-9371.

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Los Angeles Times

Legal Notices

Legal Notices

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LEGAL NOTICE

NOTICE TO DEFENDANT (AVISO AL DEMANDADO):

NOTICE! YOU HAVE BEEN SUED. THE COURT MAY DECIDE AGAINST YOU WITHOUT YOUR BEING HEARD UNLESS YOU RESPOND NOT LATER THAN APRIL 13, 2026, WHICH IS AT LEAST TEN (10) DAYS AFTER COMPLETION OF THE PUBLICATION OF THIS SUMMONS. READ THE INFORMATION BELOW.

¡AVISO! USTED HA SIDO DEMANDADO. EL TRIBUNAL PUEDE DECIDIR CONTRA USTED SIN AUDIENCIA A MENOS QUE USTED RESPONDA A MÁS TARDAR PARA EL 13 DE ABRIL 2026, QUE ES DIEZ (10) DÍAS DESPUÉS QUE TERMINE LA ÚLTIMA PUBLICACIÓN DE ESTE CITATORIO. LEA LA INFORMACIÓN SIGUIENTE.

TO: ALL PERSONS INTERESTED IN THE MATTER OF THE VALIDITY OF PROCEEDINGS RELATING TO THE AUTHORIZATION AND ISSUANCE OF NOTES AND BONDS TO BE ISSUED WITH RESPECT TO CERTAIN OBLIGATIONS OF THE LOS ANGELES UNIFIED SCHOOL DISTRICT ARISING FROM INVOLUNTARY TORT CLAIMS TO BE REDUCED TO JUDGMENT, A CREDIT AGREEMENT, AN INDENTURE AND ANY OTHER RELATED CONTRACTS AND AGREEMENTS AUTHORIZED OR CONTEMPLATED BY THE LOS ANGELES UNIFIED SCHOOL DISTRICT BOARD OF EDUCATION AND THE ADOPTING OF A RESOLUTION PERTAINING THERETO.

DETAILED SUMMARY OF MATTER TO BE VALIDATED:

The Board of Education (the “District Board”) of the Los Angeles Unified School District (the “District”) has authorized the issuance, from time to time, of judgment obligation notes (the “Promissory Notes”) and judgment obligation bonds (the “Bonds”), the proceeds of which will be used to satisfy the District’s obligations to pay judgments that have been or soon will be entered against the District in cases involving involuntary tort claims against the District either by application of California Assembly Bill Number 218, chaptered by the California Secretary of State on October 13, 2019 (“AB 218”), or as a result of similar childhood sexual assault, abuse, and/or molestation claims for tort liability (collectively, the “Judgment Refunding Program”).

Enacted by the Legislature in 2019, among other things, AB 218 extended the statute of limitations for tort claims based on allegations of childhood sexual assault to a plaintiff’s 40th birthday, and revived claims that were previously time-barred by the expiration of the statute of limitations for a period of three years, commencing on January 1, 2020 and ending on January 1, 2023 (the “Revival Window”). With the enactment of AB 218 and, in particular, the Revival Window provisions thereof, the District is defending an unprecedented number of involuntary tort claims from plaintiffs (the “Tort Plaintiffs”) who allegedly spent time in the District’s charge as children while suffering sexual assault, abuse, and/or molestation at the hands of District employees. As of February 17, 2026, the District has had more than 200 of such cases (involving over 400 individual Tort Plaintiffs), and counting, filed against it asserting involuntary tort claims by application of AB 218 or otherwise alleging claims in tort based on childhood sexual assault, abuse, and/or molestation claims (the “Lawsuits”). A significant portion of the Lawsuits could potentially be resolved in the coming months and years through settlements and stipulated judgments or via judgments on the merits entered against the District (each, a “Judgment” and, together, the “Judgments”). In either case, the District faces a substantial increase in liability from Judgments entered in the Lawsuits in favor of Tort Plaintiffs which obtain such Judgments (each a “Judgment Obligor” and, collectively, the “Judgment Obligees”) in the coming months and years. Given the potential liability amounts to result from the Lawsuits, payment of each Judgment in full upon conclusion of the related Lawsuit would likely result in significant and material impacts to the District’s operating budget that would be immediately felt across the District’s operating funds for years to come. To mitigate and manage these impacts, the Judgment Refunding Program establishes interim and long-term financing mechanisms to refund the District’s obligations to the Judgment Obligees evidenced by the Judgments as and when the Judgments are entered against the District. First, the District will refund the Judgments on an interim basis pursuant to one or more credit facilities established under one or more credit agreements (each, a “Credit Agreement”) to be entered into by the District and one or more lender banks (each, a “Lender”). Each Credit Agreement will provide a short-term line of credit that will be drawn upon as funds are needed to satisfy a Judgment or Judgments. The District’s obligations under each Credit Agreement will be evidenced by Promissory Notes to be issued thereunder. Moreover, to confirm the agreement between each Lender and the District with respect to certain commitment fees and other fees payable to such Lender under a Credit Agreement, the District will enter into fee agreements (each, a “Fee Agreement” and, together with the related Credit Agreement, a “Lender Agreement”) with each Lender. To provide additional short-term borrowing options and flexibility, the District may also from time to time and pursuant to its authority under applicable law authorize other forms of temporary borrowing by the District in the form of temporary notes to be issued from time to time (each, a “Temporary Note” or, collectively, the “Temporary Notes” and, together with the Promissory Notes, the “Notes”), the proceeds of which are used to satisfy and refund one or more Judgments.

Second, the District will issue Bonds, from time to time, pursuant to an indenture (the “Indenture”) to be entered into by the District and a commercial bank as trustee (the “Trustee”), and, if applicable, one or more supplemental indentures (each, a “Supplemental Indenture”), to be entered into by the District and the Trustee as provided under the Indenture. That is, when the amount of outstanding Notes and the timing is periodically appropriate to issue long-term obligations, the District will issue Bonds to refund the District’s interim obligations under Notes, the proceeds of which will go to satisfying amounts payable to a Lender or other holders of Notes then outstanding and issued in satisfaction of any Judgment or Judgments, from time to time, and related costs. Bonds may also be issued to directly refund Judgments unfunded at the time of issuance of any Bonds, and if desirable in the future, any previously issued Bonds then outstanding which previously refunded any Notes or Judgments.

On February 17, 2026, after public notice in accordance with law, the District Board adopted a Resolution entitled, “Resolution of the Board of Education of the Los Angeles Unified School District Approving and Authorizing the Issuance of Additional Judgment Obligation Notes and Bonds, an Indenture and Related Documents, an Official Statement, a Related Validation Proceeding and Related Actions, All for the Purpose of Refunding Obligations Incurred by Application of Assembly Bill Number 218 and Similar Claims for Tort Liability” (the “Resolution”).

The Resolution authorized the District to (a) issue the Promissory Notes under the Judgment Refunding Program, on an interim basis, to refund obligations the District owes in connection with the Judgments; (b) enter one or more Lender Agreements pursuant to which the Promissory Notes are to be issued; (c) issue Bonds, on a long-term basis, to refund obligations the District owes in connection with the Judgments (i.e., any outstanding Notes or Judgments or previously issued Bonds at the time of issuance); (d) enter the Indenture and one or more Supplemental Indentures as provided under the Indenture, pursuant to which the Bonds are to be issued; and (e) undertake certain related proceedings, or execute certain documents, instruments and other matters, with respect to the Judgment Refunding Program. Under the Resolution, the aggregate dollar amount of Judgments to be refunded by Promissory Notes and/or Bonds must not exceed \$250,000,000 (excluding any interest due thereunder).

The District brought this validation action to confirm the validity of the Judgment Refunding Program and its various constituent parts, as described above and more specifically in the Complaint and exhibits thereto. The District seeks a judgment declaring, among other things, that the District’s incurrence of any and all indebtedness and/or liability in connection with the amounts due to Judgment Obligees as set forth in the Judgments, the Notes, the Bonds, the Lender Agreement(s), the Indenture and any Supplemental Indenture as provided under the Indenture, and any and all contracts and agreements executed and delivered in connection therewith, is exempt from and not subject to the debt limitation set forth in Article XVI, Section 18 of the California Constitution. Namely, that the Notes, the Lender Agreement(s), the Bonds, the Indenture, and any Supplemental Indenture as provided under the Indenture, and any related contracts and agreements authorized or contemplated by the District Board in the Resolution do not create a new or different liability for purposes of the debt limitation set forth in Article XVI, Section 18 of the California Constitution but, rather, merely evidence the change of the form of the existing involuntary liabilities of the District arising in tort, as reflected in the Judgments, which are obligations imposed by law.

The Plaintiff has filed a civil complaint against you. If you wish to contest the legality or validity of the matter that is the subject of this lawsuit, you must appear and file with the Court a written pleading in response to the Complaint not later than April 13, 2026. Your pleading must be in the form required by the California Rules of Court. Your original pleading must be filed in this Court with proper filing fees and proof that a copy thereof was served on Plaintiff’s attorneys.

Unless you so respond, your default will be entered upon Plaintiff’s application, and this Court may enter a judgment against you for the relief demanded in the complaint. Persons who contest the legality or validity of the matters which are the subject of this lawsuit will not be subject to punitive action, such as wage garnishment or seizure of their real or personal property.

YOU MAY SEEK THE ADVICE OF AN ATTORNEY IN ANY MATTER CONNECTED WITH THE COMPLAINT OR THIS SUMMONS. SUCH ATTORNEY SHOULD BE CONSULTED PROMPTLY SO THAT YOUR PLEADING MAY BE FILED OR ENTERED

WITHIN THE TIME REQUIRED BY THIS SUMMONS.

SI USTED DESEA SOLICITAR EL CONSEJO DE UN ABOGADO EN ESTE ASUNTO, DEBERÍA HACERLO INMEDIATAMENTE, PARA QUE, SU REPUESTA ESCRITA, SI HAY ALGUNA, PUEDA SER REGISTRADA A TIEMPO.

CASE NUMBER (Número del Caso): 26STCV05691

The name and address of the court is (El nombre y la dirección de la corte

es):

SUPERIOR COURT, COUNTY OF LOS ANGELES

Stanley Mosk Courthouse

Department 51

111 North Hill Street

Los Angeles, CA 90012

The name, address, and telephone number of plaintiff’s attorney is (El nombre, la dirección y el número de teléfono del abogado del demandante es):

Attn: William B. Tunick, Esq.

Meredith B. Johnson, Esq.

Aidan Wallace, Esq.

Luke L. Punnakanta, Esq.

Dannis Woliver Kelley

444 W. Ocean Blvd., Suite 1750

Long Beach, CA 90802

Telephone: (562) 366-8500

Facsimile: (562) 366-8505

Date: 03/10/2026

(Fecha) (Delegado)

David W. Slayton, Executive Officer/Clerk of Court

Clerk, by S. Bolden, Deputy (Actuario)

The
Christophe
Sherwood

Sheriff pulls a dangerous stunt with vote recount

[**Chabria**, from B1]
reasons.
“From the very, very beginning, Chad Bianco didn’t say this was political,” Bianco told me, referring to himself in the third person. “Chad Bianco said we have an allegation of fraud with numbers that don’t add up, and no one has an exact reason why. So we have to find out the exact reason why. It’s plain and simple. Plain and simple.”

If you’re clueless as to what Bianco is talking about, let me give you the short version. A citizens group of election “auditors” claimed that in the election over Proposition 50 in November, there were about 45,800 more ballots counted than cast.

The Riverside County registrar of voters, Art Tinoco, a highly respected election official, gave a long presentation explaining why that number was not accurate. He said that the actual difference in ballots cast and counted is only 103, within the acceptable margin of error for the 1.4 million voters in his area.

But unhappy with that answer, the group apparently took its concerns to Bianco, who decided to use his powers of criminal investigation to circumvent the many established avenues for vote audits through his own county and the California secretary of state (though he hasn’t revealed publicly exactly what led to the investigation).

Using a secret, sealed warrant — so none of us actually know what he’s alleging — he seized more than half a million ballots. The court has apparently appointed a special master to count those ballots, though Bianco at first said his deputies would do their own counting. But we don’t

know who that special master is, or even if he or she has yet been appointed.
Here’s what we do know, and why it counts as a danger not just to Riverside, but also to American democracy writ large, when a politically ambitious lawman decides to run elections himself.

The fraud fiasco
So where did the citizen-auditors get their 45,800 number? Like many California counties, Riverside tallies ballots as they come in. So for the 11 days voting was happening (and for the mail-in ballots that came later) someone was making a handwritten note for every ballot that the county received.
Yes, I said handwritten, for more than 600,000 ballots going through 2,500 workers and volunteers. It’s often inaccurate and not every ballot is going to end up being a good one — some lack signatures, for example.

Tinoco, the registrar, called these handwritten logs “raw data” that also are missing ballots from other sources that increases the final tally, such as people who register on the day they vote. So no one who understands elections expects this number to be accurate or final.

Once all these ballots are checked to make sure they should be counted, they are sent to an entirely separate system, which reads them electronically and provides the election results.
When the number of vetted ballots is compared with the number of ballots that are counted by the second system, the difference is 103, Tinoco said.

So no fraud, only human frailty with the difficult business of counting by



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

CHAD BIANCO, a gubernatorial hopeful, denied involvement in the vote inquiry.

hand.
Matt Barreto, a UCLA political science professor and director of its Voting Rights Project, said Bianco’s actions were similar to what happened in Fulton County, Ga., where the FBI seized ballots after Trump’s debunked claims of fraud — despite plain and simple explanations from election officials.

“In both cases, Georgia and Riverside, independent elections offices had already verified the accuracy of the ballot count, and in both cases the results had been certified by the secretary of state,” Barreto said. “It is worrisome that a very partisan law enforcement officer is questioning the integrity of an election, perhaps because he did not support the results.”

The investigation
Bianco has been investigating the 45,000 claim for months, but it came to a head in recent weeks, in no small part thanks to a news conference he held. Bianco’s office, as first reported by the Riverside Record, served a warrant on the election office one day before

Tinoco made his presentation to the Board of Supervisors in early February.

Since then, the California secretary of state, which handles elections, and the state Department of Justice have both tried to intervene to stop Bianco from taking ballots or doing his own recount, Pillow Guy-style. But they’ve had little luck.

Secretary of State Shirley Weber called the allegations “unsubstantiated” and questioned the legality — and common sense — of having deputies hand-count ballots. Now, her office is trying to make sure folks trained in elections are involved in whatever happens next.

“The sheriff’s assertion that his deputies know how to count is admirable,” Weber said. “The fact remains that he and his deputies are not elections officials.”

Separately, California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta has gone to the courts to try to keep Bianco from spiriting away the ballots. Bonta’s office went straight to the California Court of Appeal

to ask it to force the sheriff to comply with their requests to take no further action and supply the Justice Department with the probable cause evidence used to obtain the search warrant — basically tell them exactly what proof he’s using to claim a crime might have been committed.

The appeals court declined to intervene until Bonta went to the lower Riverside County Superior Court. But in the meantime, Bianco went back to his judge and asked for another secret, sealed warrant — which he got.

The bigger problem

And that brings us to why we should all be concerned about Riverside County.

First, why all the secrecy? Shouldn’t elections and everything about them be transparent, so we all can feel confident any investigation is on the up and up?

I asked Bianco why the warrants are sealed, and he told me I didn’t understand investigations.

“In an ongoing investiga-

tion, we never unseal the warrants,” Bianco said. “No, I can’t say never. I can’t say never. Why are you coming at me like I’m the bad person here, instead of like a rational person?”

When I asked him why a sheriff needed to be involved, rather than allowing the state officials who handle elections to investigate, he told me this was a crime investigation just like any other — domestic abuse or murder, for example.

“It’s called fraud,” he said. “Let me ask you this: Do we just let, do we let doctors investigate themselves for medical malpractice?”

The implication there is that election officials are in a conspiracy to commit an actual crime — fraud — and can’t be trusted. That jumps the shark from maybe election staff counting sloppy in their handwritten tallies of ballots received, to a — yes, folks, here it is — a conspiracy of Democrats, from those volunteers up to the highest state officials.

That is a political vendetta, straight from Trump, and has little to do with tracking down crime — which, by the way, Bianco’s office is not great at. It has some of the lowest clearance rates in the state.

“Oh, please,” Bianco said regarding my questions on whether this was, in fact, political. “I’m the sheriff of Riverside County, and my investigators are responsible for crime. I have nothing to do with this investigation.”

His news conference would beg to differ.

And now we have a precedent for a politics-driven sheriff seizing ballots, maybe to make headlines, maybe to please Trump, maybe both.

What happens if other Republican sheriffs across the country decide to do some ballot seizing of their own in swing states or contested races come November?

Is it all fair game now for whoever can physically take the ballots to be the arbitrator of results?

“The political corruption in California just gets bigger and bigger,” Bianco said on social media recently.

On that, we can agree.

Widow blames grenade blast on lack of training

[**Grenade**, from B1]
dition’s Hazardous Device School in Huntsville, Alabama, where bomb technicians working in law enforcement receive training in the proper handling of explosive devices,” the claim alleges.
Experts interviewed by The Times said that is the usual standard in such squads. Sheriff’s Department officials did not respond to questions about whether Lemus had formal training for the bomb squad.
On the day before the explosion, Kelley-Eklund, 41, and Osborn, 58, responded to a call from the Santa Monica Police Department after officers found two grenades in the garage of an apartment complex in the 800 block of Bay Street. The deputies responded to the scene in personal work trucks rather than the department’s bomb truck, the claim alleges.

“The personal trucks contained lower-quality equipment as compared to what would be contained on the Bomb Truck. After arriving on the scene, Osborn used an older X-ray machine to examine the explosive device. Osborn then falsely reported to the Santa Monica officers that the device was inert,” the legal claim alleges. “Osborn’s reliance on the X-ray meant he would not take the required steps to render the device safe.”

The claim alleges that Kelley-Eklund and Osborn were mandated to request that members of the nearest military unit respond to Santa Monica to take possession of the grenade or “render the device safe and transport it directly to a Department facility with an explosive range for disposal.”

Instead, one of the men took the ordnance home and either left it in their truck overnight, or brought it into their house, the claim alleges.

“During the transport, the device was not secured in a safe or a Bomb Truck, thus exposing the public to potential catastrophe,” attorney Greg Smith wrote. “Each of these discrete acts — failing to use proper equipment, failing to render the device safe at the scene, failing to transport the device in a proper container,

failing to take the device directly to an explosive range, and purposefully driving on public roadways with a live explosive improperly stored — violates department policy and fundamental public policies of the State of California and the United States.”

(A department spokesperson said it had no information to substantiate the claim that the grenades were taken to one of the detective’s home and kept there overnight.)

On the next day, the grenades were taken to the training center, where such “live explosive devices are prohibited,” the claim alleges.

The deputies “then used the live explosive device as a training demonstration — the most tragic violation,” the claim says.

The Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives is investigating the deadly blast and is expected to produce a lengthy report. Investigators have served warrants in Marina del Rey for a yacht and storage unit connected to a man who served in the U.S. military and worked in the movie business.

Investigators also are looking into the disappearance of the second grenade that was seized in Santa Monica. After the blast, sheriff’s officials said the second device was missing.

In the aftermath of the explosion, Sheriff Robert Luna has called for an independent review of the department’s standards when it comes to disposing of explosive devices and said he plans to consult the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives on future policy and practice decisions.

The department said it has also consulted the Los Angeles Police Department, the FBI and other agencies about updating training manuals and guidelines for similar calls.

“Some updates include further standardizing Department practices and processes to ensure organizational consistency, the introduction of new equipment and refining response protocols tailored to the nature of the call for service,” a statement read.

Obituaries

Place a paid notice latimes.com/placeobituary | Search obituary notice archives: legacy.com/obituaries/latimes



Rosalee Miladinovich Orr

Rosalee M. Orr passed away peacefully of natural causes in her home surrounded by her loving family on March 10, 2026. Rosalee Miladinovich was born on September 15, 1933 in Butte, Montana. At the age of 10 her family moved to Wilmington, California. She married Roy McCarrell in 1954.

Rosalee worked over twenty years for the RBUSD in an administrative role where she made many friends and enjoyed maintaining those friendships well into her retirement. She was also a lifetime member of her church where she served for decades as the Financial Secretary and Missions Chairman. She loved to bake, entertain, sew, quilt, knit and read.

She is survived by her children, Michael McCarrell, Jeffrey McCarrell (Marcy), Jeanette VanAmburgh (Matt), and Christopher McCarrell. Her grandchildren include Kyle VanAmburgh (Aleesha), Kristiana McCarrell-Sphan (Brian), Jessica Forte (Andrew), Samantha McCarrell and Hannah Suominen (David). She was thrilled to live long enough to enjoy her great-daughter Vesper Rose Forte.

She was preceded in death by her husband Roy McCarrell, her brother Robert Miladinovich and husband James Orr, Sr.

In lieu of flowers please consider donating to the Wycliffe Bible Translators. Their website is Wycliffe.org

A Memorial Service to honor Rosalee will be on Saturday, April 18, 2026 at 2:00 pm at Branch of Hope Church in Torrance.



Margaret Cole Padilla

January 11, 1939 - September 1, 2025

Margaret Cole Padilla, a proud union teacher, fittingly died on Labor Day after a four-year struggle with stage IV breast cancer.

Daughter of the former Katherine Halligan of Sonnagh, County Mayo, Ireland, and Raymond Cole of Whittier, California, by way of Claremont, New Hampshire (a descendant of James Cole of Cole’s Hill, which overlooks the (in)famous Plymouth Rock), she was born in Los Angeles, delivered by her family’s favorite, decades-long, can-do anything doctor, Joseph Vinetz, at St. Vincent’s Hospital, where her mom was a longtime nurse, but she would spend nine years during and after WWII growing up in Panama on the Colón (Atlantic) side of the US Canal Zone, where her mom worked as a bookkeeper and her dad as a butcher in the “silver” commissary, designated for “silver roll” workers—predominately Afro-Caribbean, Panamanian, and other Latin American workers in manual labor, service, and clerical jobs not classified as “gold roll.”

Upon returning to LA, where she was made fun of for speaking English with a Panamanian accent, she attended St. Helen (South Gate), Precious Blood, Our Lady of Loretto High School, and Mount St. Mary’s College, from which she graduated in 1961 with a major in Drama and minor in History.

Opting for teaching over acting, in part because of the industry’s mistreatment of women, she spent the next 49 years teaching high school English at Bishop Montgomery (1961-62), St. Paul (1962-74), and Bosco Tech (1974-78), and adult ed ESL in the Alhambra Unified School District (1977-2010), until AUSD made the fateful decision to close down its adult education program in the Great Recession.

She loved her students, and they loved her. She is survived by everyone whose life she touched, including all the neighborhood fauna who love all the flora she planted and nurtured; her last-surviving pooch, Boots; last-surviving cockatiel, Luna; and friends and family, including her husband of 50 years, Fred, and son, Paul.

She is accompanied in the fondness of living memories and living legacies left behind by her many dearly departed family members, friends, and fellow humans on the journey of life, including, perhaps most tragically for her, former students she lost in the Vietnam War; and, last but not least, the nonhuman animal companions she had over her lifetime.

In her memory, be kind, pursue peace and justice, act in solidarity with indigenous peoples, immigrants, nonhuman animals, and all who are vulnerable, marginalized, and in need, and get your cancer screenings, reduce your risk, and let’s clean up our polluted planet for ourselves and all life on earth.

A memorial Mass will take place at San Gabriel Mission Church on Saturday, March 28, at 11am, immediately followed by a Celebration of Life luncheon event at Almansor Court in Alhambra.

The year that was

1935

Although a primitive, two-color process was first used in 1922, audiences weren’t impressed by Technicolor until a three-color system appeared in “Becky Sharp.”

latimes.com/archives

Share a memory

To sign a guest book please go to latimes.com/guestbooks

Los Angeles Times

THE WEATHER

Today in Southern California

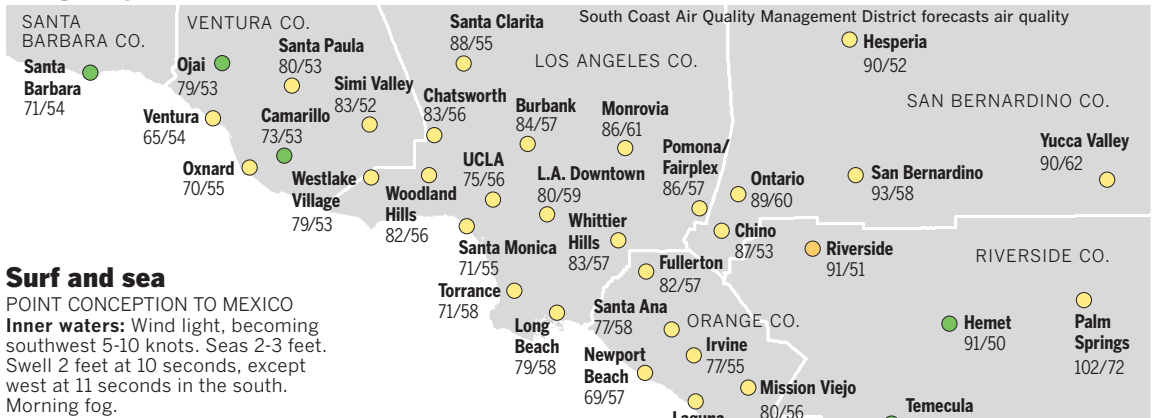
Continued warm inland: There will be low clouds and fog near the coast in the morning; otherwise, it'll be sunshine much of the day. A weak onshore flow will make it comfortable along the coast, but afternoon temperatures will challenge record highs across the interior. This weather pattern will continue over the weekend, with temperatures trending cooler next week as a stronger onshore flow takes over.

5-day forecasts

High/low temperatures are average forecasts for entire zone.

	L.A. Basin		Valleys		Beaches		Mountains		Deserts	
Today	80 59		83 57		71 55		73 42		102 72	
	Mostly sunny		Warm with sunshine		Partly sunny		Partly sunny		Very hot	
Saturday	Partly sunny	83/62	Partly sunny	86/61	Partly sunny	77/59	Clouds, sun	73/42	Very hot	102/72
Sunday	Mostly sunny	87/58	Very warm	87/58	Mostly sunny	76/58	Mostly sunny	70/39	Very hot	98/68
Monday	Not as warm	78/58	Not as warm	77/57	Clouding up	69/60	Mostly cloudy	64/43	Hot	93/67
Tuesday	Partly sunny	70/58	Cloudy	70/56	Cloudy	66/58	Cooler	52/37	Cloudy	87/60

Air quality



Surf and sea

POINT CONCEPTION TO MEXICO
Inner waters: Wind light, becoming southwest 5-10 knots. Seas 2-3 feet. Swell 2 feet at 10 seconds, except west at 11 seconds in the south. Morning fog.
Surf zone: The potential for strong rip currents is low at all area beaches, although rip currents are always possible.

County	Height	Period	Direction	Temp
Santa Barbara	1-2'	10 sec	W	62
Ventura	2-4'	10 sec	W	63
Los Angeles	1-3'	10 sec	W	65
Orange	1-3'	11 sec	W	65
San Diego	1-3'	11 sec	W	67

Tides

L.A. Outer Harbor, in feet.				
Today	5:27a	5.0 Hi	12:55p	-0.5 Lo
	7:45p	4.0 Hi	-----	Lo
Sat.	6:36a	5.2 Hi	12:45a	2.1 Lo
	8:12p	4.4 Hi	1:38p	-0.6 Lo

UV index

Minutes to burn for sensitive people
Las Vegas, 30
Phoenix, 30
Los Angeles, 30
San Francisco, 30

California cities*

City	Thu.*		Hi	Lo	Today		Hi	Lo
	Hi	Lo			Hi	Lo		
Anaheim	84	55	--	82	54	88	58	84
Avalon/Catalina	74	57	--	76	65	79	69	74
Bakersfield	83	57	--	87	59	90	59	83
Barstow	92	60	--	95	61	94	62	92
Big Bear Lake	72	39	--	73	42	73	42	72
Bishop	84	44	--	83	43	84	43	84
Burbank	84	57	--	84	57	87	60	84
Camarillo	72	53	--	73	53	77	51	72
Chatsworth	85	57	--	83	56	86	56	85
Chino	88	53	--	87	53	92	54	88
Compton	81	58	--	78	57	83	59	81
Dana Point	71	56	--	70	59	77	58	71
Death Valley	100	77	--	101	79	102	73	100
Del Mar	72	56	Tr	68	57	74	58	72
Escondido	86	46	Tr	83	51	88	50	86
Eureka	58	38	--	57	41	55	44	58
Fallbrook	83	48	Tr	82	53	89	53	83
Fresno	80	57	--	85	53	88	53	80
Fullerton	84	58	--	82	57	89	58	84
Hemet	90	49	--	91	50	96	54	90
Hesperia	86	53	--	87	56	88	55	86
Huntington Beach	71	58	--	68	57	75	59	71
Idyllwild	79	59	--	79	58	81	59	79
Irvine	78	56	--	77	55	85	58	78

Sun and moon

Today's rise/set
Sun 6:47a/7:10p
Moon 1:57p/3:47a
Los Angeles Co. 84/59
Orange Co. 82/58
Ventura Co. 72/56
6:46a/7:09p
1:56p/3:45a
6:51a/7:14p
2:01p/3:51a



Almanac

Temperature	Los Angeles	Fullerton	Ventura*
High/low	84/59	82/58	72/56
Normal high/low	71/53	72/52	67/47
High/low a year ago	61/54	63/55	61/53
Record high/date	98/1988	96/2015	94/1988
Record low/date	39/1907	44/2023	38/2023

Precipitation	Los Angeles	Fullerton	Ventura*
24-hour total (as of 2 p.m.)	0.00	0.00	0.00
Season total (since Oct. 1)	18.25	15.13	19.29
Last season (Oct. 1 to date)	7.57	3.68	6.00
Season norm (Oct. 1 to date)	12.75	10.50	14.32
Humidity (high/low)	93/56	93/37	93/70

City	Thu.*		Today	Today		S
	Hi	Lo		Hi	Lo	
L.A. D'town/USC	84	57	--	80	59	83
L.A. Int'l. Airport	71	58	--	72	58	75
Laguna Beach	70	57	--	68	59	77
Lancaster	88	48	--	87	52	89
Long Beach	78	58	--	79	58	84
Mammoth Lakes	70	33	--	70	37	69
Mission Viejo	82	54	--	80	56	86
Monrovia	86	59	--	86	61	90
Monterey	65	52	--	73	48	67
Mt. Wilson	72	56	--	63	52	64
Needles	99	69	--	101	69	100
Newport Beach	70	58	--	69	57	75
Northridge	86	56	Tr	83	56	87
Oakland	73	50	--	77	49	71
Oceanside	79	48	--	79	50	85
Ojai	81	55	--	79	53	81
Ontario	88	59	--	89	60	92
Palm Springs	102	72	--	102	72	102
Pasadena	84	58	Tr	83	60	89
Paso Robles	83	47	--	83	45	84
Redding	80	56	--	83	49	85
Riverside	89	49	--	91	51	92
Sacramento	78	53	--	81	49	82
San Bernardino	91	58	--	93	58	94

City	Thu.*		Today	Today		Sat.
	Hi	Lo		Hi	Lo	
San Diego	73	58	--	74	59	77 60
San Francisco	72	53	--	76	49	71 50
San Gabriel	84	58	--	84	60	87 61
San Jose	78	52	--	82	51	80 50
San Luis Obispo	77	56	--	79	50	74 49
Santa Ana	75	59	--	77	58	83 60
Santa Barbara	66	55	--	71	54	76 52
Santa Clarita	90	55	--	88	55	90 57
Santa Monica Pier	73	57	--	71	55	77 59
Santa Paula	77	53	--	80	53	83 55
Santa Rosa	80	44	--	82	42	79 46
Simi Valley	80	54	--	83	52	86 53
Tahoe Valley	63	31	--	67	34	67 30
Temecula	87	48	--	87	52	93 55
Thousand Oaks	77	54	--	79	52	80 55
Torrance	72	58	Tr	71	58	72 60
UCLA	75	56	Tr	75	56	81 58
Van Nuys	84	57	Tr	85	58	88 60
Ventura	65	54	--	65	54	67 56
Whittier Hills	83	58	--	83	57	86 60
Woodland Hills	88	56	--	82	56	85 59
Wrightwood	74	54	--	73	54	74 52
Yorba Linda	86	53	--	82	54	88 57
Yosemite Valley	74	52	--	79	46	77 42

USC REPORT

Devil in details at spring practice

By ANTHONY SOLORZANO

Three weeks into spring practice, USC football coaches are making one thing clear: 95% of their best will not be accepted or tolerated. Wednesday's practice started with some of the players doing up-downs after forgetting equipment.

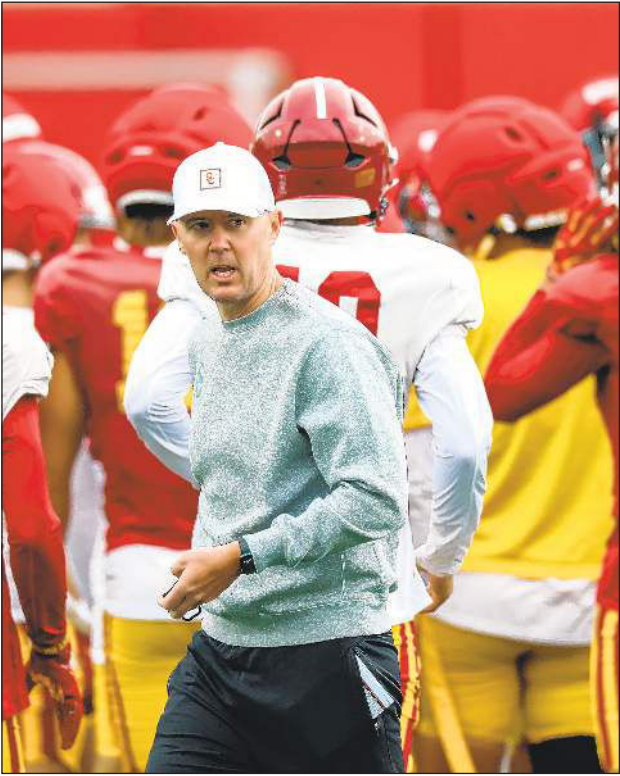
"It was a good message from some of our staff and leaders in terms of the approach that we need to have every day that we come out here," Trojans coach Lincoln Riley said.

A sentiment that was shared by junior defensive tackle Jide Abasiri: "We just have to be better prepared."

After the hiccup, Riley said the team responded well and it was back to business. After a spirited day on the field on Tuesday following a one-week spring break, Wednesday's practice was scripted with the intent to cause stress and create discomfort — stacking multiple two-minute drills after a 6 a.m. team meeting. The goal is to build a no-excuses program.

"It's invaluable time, invaluable reps," Riley said. "Coming out and working plays and the techniques, great. When you start putting those guys in real-life situations and you make it really difficult on them, you really start to see who rises up and they're great teaching moments for these guys and for the team in terms of what we want to be and what we want them to be."

Regardless of the mental challenges Riley applied, the Trojans' morale remains positive as players compete for spots in the lineup. The energy of the team comes from within, Riley said.



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

LINCOLN RILEY says USC coaches and upperclassmen are holding players accountable in the spring.

"It allows us as a staff to really hone in on pushing these guys, and coaching and critiquing and correcting," Riley said. "And they're taking it well."

Attention to detail has always been important at USC, but Abasiri said this year there is an extra emphasis being placed on playing specific details. The staff has implemented drills that focus on a player's specific movement or job during various plays.

Entering his third season with the Trojans, Abasiri said he felt like he needed to be a team leader. USC landed the No. 1 class in the nation for the first time since 2006. With so many new young players joining spring practice and a limited number of Trojans with three years of experience, Abasiri felt it was his job to lead.

"Just being an older guy, I feel like it's important for me to ... help them just come along," Abasiri said.

So far, his advice has been to "just have fun with it."

"I mean, obviously, stay on top of everything and all your stuff, but I feel like people get so stressed and so caught up in what they're doing that they forget that this is supposed to be enjoyable," Abasiri said.

The coaching staff, meanwhile, is balancing teaching schemes and the playbook.

"You have to be able to do both at this level," Riley said. "The new guys that came in did have a pretty good foundation. A lot of them came from really good programs. A lot of them had a pretty good working football knowledge to where when we got started with them, it wasn't like you felt like you were starting from literal square one."

Return game remains unsettled

USC is still working to identify its top kickoff and punt return options.

"We haven't done a lot of live returns yet," Riley said. "We're just trying to figure out who really fields the ball well, who understands it, who makes decisions and, honestly, the returners, they're showing us a lot of what they can do just in the offensive and defensive periods."

The coaching staff has a pretty good idea who some of the best players in that position are, but at the moment, it just wants to develop the skills, from a return standpoint.

THE DAY IN SPORTS

NBA to address the tanking

WIRE REPORTS

Tanking is going to be addressed. The 65-game rule might remain.

NBA commissioner Adam Silver insisted Wednesday that the league will change its draft process and address its tanking problem before the start of next season. And he pointed to the league's player participation policy — citing the effect it has had on load management — as proof of how the league can make effective fixes. The league's board of governors discussed tanking — the issue of teams trying not to win in order to enhance their odds of landing the best possible draft pick — at its two-day meeting that ended Wednesday. No votes were taken and no fingers were pointed at any specific teams, Silver said.

Silver responded to the National Basketball Players Assn.'s statement Tuesday calling for change to the 65-game rule for major individual awards.

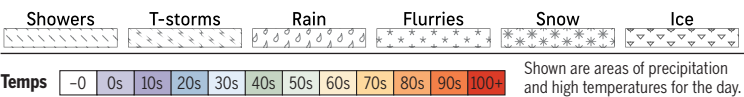
"We always knew when there's a line you draw that somebody's going to fall on the other side of that line and it may feel unfair in that particular instance," Silver said. "Let's see what happens at the end of this year. By the way, Cade Cunningham, he's an incredible player. I'm sorry that he's injured and can't wait to see him back on the floor."

"But having said that, we also have to remember that to the extent that one player is no longer eligible, some other player will then be All-NBA and will slot into that spot."

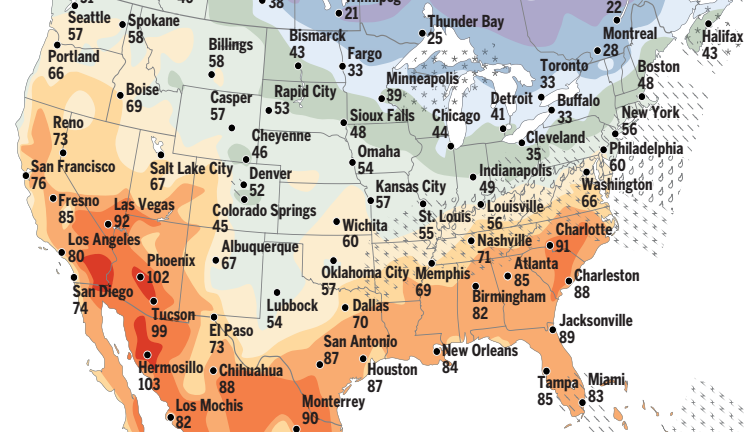
Paul George returned to the 76ers' lineup following a 25-game suspension for a failed drug test and scored 28 points on Wednesday night in Philadelphia's 157-137 win over Chicago. ... Guard Jaden Ivey and forward Jalen Smith will miss the remainder of the Chicago Bulls' season because of injuries, the team announced. ... Jamal Murray scored a season-high 53 points and Nikola Jokic had

Today in North America

Record warmth: Record-breaking heat is occurring across the southern tier of the U.S. A front will cause clouds, showers and thunderstorms from Arkansas to Virginia, while mainly dry but chilly weather will cover the upper Midwest, the Great Lakes and the Northeast.



Temps -0 0s 10s 20s 30s 40s 50s 60s 70s 80s 90s 100+ Shown are areas of precipitation and high temperatures for the day.



U.S. cities

THURSDAY'S EXTREMES AS OF 2 P.M. FOR THE 48 CONTIGUOUS STATES

High 102 in Hugoton, Kan. Low 9 in Rolla, N.D.

City	Thursday*			Today			City	Thursday*			Today		
	Hi	Lo	Prcp.	Hi	Lo	Sky		Hi	Lo	Prcp.	Hi	Lo	Sky
Albany	68	44	26	43	22	Pc	Seattle	53	35	--	57	40	Pc
Albuquerque	88	56	--	67	38	Hz	Tampa	84	67	.05	85	65	Pc
Anchorage	30	8	--	25	12	Su	Tucson	98	61	--	99	66	Pc
Aspen	72	44	Tr	67	39	Cy	Tulsa	90	67	--	98	38	R
Atlanta	79	54	--	85	48	Su	Washington, D.C.	80	49	Tr	66	36	R
Austin	89	69	--	86	56	Su	Wichita	97	64	--	60	35	W

NBA STANDINGS

Through Wednesday

Standings have been arranged to reflect how the teams will be determined for the playoffs. Teams are ranked 1-15 by record. Division standing no longer has any bearing on the rankings. The top six teams in each conference qualify for the playoffs. Teams seven through 10 will participate in a play-in tournament with the top-seeded team playing the lowest qualifying play-in team. The next-lowest qualifying team would play the second, etc. Head-to-head competition is the first of several tiebreakers, followed by conference record. (Western Conference divisions: S-Southwest; P-Pacific; N-Northwest; Eastern Conference divisions: A-Atlantic; C-Central; S-Southeast).

WESTERN CONFERENCE						
Team	W	L	PCT	GB	L10	Rk.
1. y-Okla. City	57	16	.781		9-1	N1
2. x-San Antonio	55	18	.753	2	9-1	S1
3. LAKERS	47	26	.644	10	9-1	P1
4. Denver	46	28	.622	11½	7-3	N2
5. Minnesota	45	28	.616	12	5-5	N3
6. Houston	43	29	.597	13½	4-6	S2
7. Phoenix	40	33	.548	17	4-6	P2
8. CLIPPERS	37	36	.507	20	6-4	P3
9. Portland	37	37	.500	20½	7-3	N4
10. Golden State	35	38	.479	22	3-7	P4

11. New Orleans	25	48	.342	32	6-4	S3
12. Memphis	24	48	.333	32½	1-9	S4
13. Dallas	23	50	.315	34	2-8	S5
14. Utah	21	52	.288	36	2-8	N5
15. Sacramento	19	54	.260	38	5-5	P5

EASTERN CONFERENCE						
Team	W	L	PCT	GB	L10	Rk.
1. x-Detroit	52	20	.722		7-3	C1
2. Boston	48	24	.667	4	7-3	A1
3. New York	48	25	.658	4½	8-2	A2
4. Cleveland	45	28	.616	7½	6-4	C2
5. Atlanta	41	32	.562	11½	9-1	S1
6. Toronto	40	32	.556	12	5-5	A3
7. Philadelphia	40	33	.548	12½	6-4	A4
8. Miami	39	34	.534	13½	5-5	S2
9. Charlotte	38	34	.528	14	7-3	S3
9. Orlando	38	34	.528	14	4-6	S4

11. Chicago	29	43	.403	23	4-6	C4
11. Milwaukee	29	43	.403	23	2-8	C3
13. Washington	17	55	.236	35	1-9	S5
14. Brooklyn	17	56	.233	35½	1-9	A5
15. Indiana	16	57	.219	36½	1-9	C5

x-clinched playoff spot
y-clinched division

WEDNESDAY'S LATE BOXES
LAKERS 137, PACERS 130

LAKERS										
	Min	FG-A	FTA	OR-T	A	P	T			
L.James.....	34	9-17	5-5	1-9	9	1	23			
LaRavia.....	28	3-3	0-0	1-5	1	1	3			
Hayes.....	36	9-11	3-6	2-10	1	1	21			
Donicic.....	37	15-30	9-10	1-6	7	5	43			
Reaves.....	37	7-16	9-9	0-1	8	3	25			
Kennard.....	28	2-4	2-2	1-2	2	3	8			
B.James.....	13	2-4	0-0	0-1	1	3	4			
Vanderbilt.....	12	2-2	0-0	0-1	0	1	5			
Kleber.....	11	1-2	0-2	1-4	1	2	2			
Totals	50-89	28-34	7-9	30	22	137				

Shooting: Field goals, 56.2%; free throws, 82.4%.
Three-point goals: 9-23 (Donicic 4-11, Kennard 2-2, Reaves 2-7, Vanderbilt 1-1, B.James 0-1, L.James 0-1).
Team Rebounds: 13. Team Turnovers: 1. Blocked Shots: 4 (Hayes 2, B.James, LaRavia). Turnovers: 13 (Donicic 5, LaRavia 3, Reaves 2, Kennard, Kleber, L.James). Steals: 15 (LaRavia 4, B.James 2, Hayes 2, Hayes 2, Kleber 2, Reaves 2, Donicic, L.James, Vanderbilt). Technical Fouls: Smart, 4:00 second.

INDIANA										
	Min	FG-A	FTA	OR-T	A	P	T			
Siakam.....	29	7-15	5-7	2-8	1	6	20			
Walker.....	29	5-9	1-2	0-6	4	3	15			
Huff.....	31	7-10	2-2	1-6	1	1	18			
Nembhard.....	33	3-9	6-6	0-2	19	4	14			
Nesmith.....	32	6-13	0-2	0-3	1	5	14			
Toppin.....	19	7-10	0-0	0-3	2	0	15			
Sheppard.....	17	4-6	1-1	2-2	2	3	13			
Potter.....	16	1-1	2-2	0-2	0	2	4			
McConnell.....	14	8-10	1-1	0-2	3	0	17			
Brown.....	8	0-2	0-0	0-0	1	1	0			
Jackson.....	7	0-1	0-0	0-0	1	0	0			
Totals	48-86	18-23	5-34	35	25	130				

Shooting: Field goals, 55.8%; free throws, 78.3%.
Three-point goals: 16-39 (Sheppard 4-5, Walker 4-8, Huff 2-5, Nembhard 2-6, Nesmith 2-8, Siakam 1-2, Toppin 1-3, Brown 0-2). Team Rebounds: 3. Team Turnovers: None. Blocked Shots: 2 (Huff, McConnell). Turnovers: 18 (Siakam 4, Nesmith 3, Toppin 3, Walker 3, Brown 2, Nembhard 2, Huff). Steals: 13 (Toppin 3, McConnell, Nesmith, Sheppard, Siakam). Technical Fouls: Siakam, 6:09 third.

LAKERS	45	30	30	22	137
Indiana	28	31	26	45	130

A-17,274. T-2,220.

CLIPPERS 119, RAPTORS 94

TORONTO										
	Min	FG-A	FTA	OR-T	A	P	T			
Barnes.....	30	4-11	0-1	3-8	12	2	9			
Ingram.....	35	6-18	0-0	1-6	4	1	18			
Poeltl.....	21	5-9	0-2	2-6	1	3	10			
Barrett.....	31	5-19	2-5	1-6	4	5	12			
Shead.....	31	3-9	0-0	0-0	4	1	8			
Murray-Boyles.....	23	5-7	0-0	2-5	0	3	10			
Mamukelashvili.....	15	5-7	0-1	3-7	0	0	13			
Walter.....	15	2-3	0-0	0-1	0	4	5			
Battle.....	10	1-4	0-0	2-5	0	0	3			
Fultz.....	8	0-1	0-0	0-0	2	0	0			
Dick.....	3	0-4	0-0	0-0	0	0	0			
Jackson-Davis.....	3	1-2	0-0	0-0	0	0	2			
Mogbo.....	3	1-1	2-2	1-1	1	1	4			
Temple.....	3	0-1	0-0	0-1	0	0	0			
Totals	40-96	4-11	15-46	28	20	94				

Shooting: Field goals, 41.7%; free throws, 36.4%.
Three-point goals: 10-29 (Mamukelashvili 3-5, Ingram 2-3, Shead 2-5, Barnes 1-2, Walter 1-2, Battle 1-3, Dick 0-1, Temple 0-1, Barrett 0-7). Team Rebounds: 9. Team Turnovers: None. Blocked Shots: 4 (Barnes, Ingram, Murray-Boyles, Shead). Turnovers: 11 (Ingram 3, Murray-Boyles 2, Shead 2, Barnes, Barrett, Mamukelashvili, Poeltl). Steals: 8 (Barnes 2, Shead 2, Barrett, Ingram, Murray-Boyles, Poeltl). Technical Fouls: None.

CLIPPERS										
	Min	FG-A	FTA	OR-T	A	P	T			
Collins.....	22	0-2	0-0	1-5	0	2	0			
Leonard.....	30	9-19	7-8	1-6	2	2	127			
Lopez.....	25	5-10	1-1	0-5	0	2	14			
Garland.....	30	9-16	1-2	1-4	6	2	24			
Jones Jr.....	28	1-4	0-0	1-7	0	0	2			
Mathurin.....	27	7-14	8-11	1-4	6	1	23			
Dunn.....	24	0-1	0-0	2-5	4	2	0			
Jackson.....	22	6-6	0-0	1-6	3	1	12			
Batum.....	14	3-4	0-0	1-2	1	1	9			
Sanders.....	7	2-4	0-0	0-0	0	1	6			
Christie.....	3	0-0	2-2	1-4	1	0	2			
Pedulla.....	3	0-2	0-0	0-1	1	0	0			
Totals	42-82	19-24	10-49	24	14	119				

Shooting: Field goals, 51.2%; free throws, 79.2%.
Three-point goals: 16-35 (Garland 5-9, Batum 3-4, Lopez 3-6, Sanders 2-3, Leonard 2-6, Mathurin 1-3, Collins 0-1, Dunn 0-1, Jones Jr. 0-1, Pedulla 0-1). Team Rebounds: 4. Team Turnovers: 1. Blocked Shots: 12 (Lopez 5, Jackson 2, Batum, Dunn, Garland, Leonard, Mathurin). Turnovers: 10 (Garland 3, Leonard 3, Collins, Dunn, Jones Jr., Lopez). Steals: 7 (Dunn 2, Lopez 2, Collins, Garland, Jackson). Technical Fouls: None.

Toronto	22	23	27	22	94
CLIPPERS	36	23	32	28	119

A-17,927. T-2,111.



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

DARIUS GARLAND goes up for two of his 24 points during the Clippers' victory.

Leonard, Garland carry the Clippers to victory

The duo combines for 51 points while Mathurin adds 23 off the bench for L.A.

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Kawhi Leonard had 27 points, Darius Garland added 24, and the Clippers beat the Toronto Raptors 119-94 on Wednesday night at Intuit Dome.

Benedict Mathurin had 23 off the bench and Brook Lopez scored 11 of his 14 points in the first quarter for the Clippers, who have won three in a row.

The Clippers stayed a half-game ahead of the Port-

land Trail Blazers for eighth in the Western Conference. Brandon Ingram had 18 points while Sandro Mamukelashvili chipped in with 13, but the Raptors have now lost three straight.

Toronto dropped into sixth in the Eastern Conference, one game behind the Atlanta Hawks, and is a half-game ahead of the Philadelphia 76ers in seventh.

With Lopez setting the tone, the Clippers outscored the Raptors 23-9 over the final 6:10 of the first quarter to open a 14-point lead.

The Raptors found themselves trailing by 22 in the second quarter before a late 11-1 run cut the gap. However, Toronto could have cut into the advantage even more

had it capitalized better on 10 offensive rebounds or from the free-throw line, where it shot 14.3% (one for seven) in the period.

Mamukelashvili made consecutive three-pointers as the Raptors tried to make one more push late in the third quarter, only for the Clippers to pull away again, with Garland making a 35-footer at the buzzer.

The Clippers were 19 for 24 from the free-throw line and outscored Toronto there by 15 points.

Raptors center Jakob Poeltl was briefly forced out of the game after sustaining a cut near his left eye going up for a rebound early in the second quarter and finished with 10 points.

Lakers finish strong 5-1 trip

[Lakers, from B10] five games all came down to the final minutes didn't faze Doncic. He nearly outscored the Pacers alone in the first quarter, putting up 21 while the Pacers trailed 45-28. He threw a lob to Maxi Kleber for a dunk in the third quarter, then pumped both of his fists. Doncic nailed a step-back three from the top of the key, held his follow-through and hopped backward on one leg.

The Lakers (47-26) toyed with the struggling Pacers (16-57) for much of the night. Indiana's Aaron Nesmith and Pascal Siakam fell over each other trying to contest a Euro-step layup by James, who then posed over them and pointed to the Pacers players. Nesmith and Siakam could only grimace at each other.

James finished with 23 points, nine rebounds and nine assists. Austin Reaves had 25 points and eight assists, Jaxson Hayes dunked seven times as the center had his first double-double of the season with 21 points and 10 rebounds, both season highs.

While players typically would drag through the end of such a long trip, Hayes found home-cooked fuel. Hayes stayed with his parents in his hometown of Cincinnati on Monday night after the Lakers' win in Detroit. He woke up to a full home-cooked breakfast from his mother, who stacked plates of pancakes, eggs and bacon in front of

her son. He scoped out properties he's hoping to buy in the summer and hung out with his dad all day. The family made the hour-and-a-half drive to Indianapolis and had dinner Tuesday night.

"Best way to end the trip for sure," Hayes said with a blissful smile.

Hayes brought the energy for the shorthanded Lakers, who were without Deandre Ayton (back soreness), Marcus Smart (right ankle contusion) and Rui Hachimura (right calf soreness). Smart and Hachimura remain day-to-day as they missed their second consecutive games, while Ayton was ruled out immediately before the game.

Even the reinforcements were shorthanded as rookie Adou Thiero missed the game because of left knee soreness.

Thiero, who has been back and forth between the NBA and the G League's South Bay Lakers, played 29 minutes in a G League game on Saturday and flew directly to Detroit for Monday's game.

He played two minutes against the Pistons, making his first appearance in a first half of a game since Dec. 7, but his knee didn't feel good the following morning. Lakers coach JJ Redick said. The team held the forward out for precautionary reasons, Redick said, as Thiero has struggled with injuries in both knees this season.

The Lakers relied on an-

other part-time G League contributor to carry them through a sloppy fourth quarter. Bronny James had four points, two steals and one block in 13:22 off the bench. Redick said the second-year guard's pull-up free-throw line jumper with 3:55 to go "was big to kind of settle us." It stopped a 6-0 run by the Pacers.

It was just the second game father and son have shared the court together this season. The elder James had the perfect shirt for the occasion. He walked out of the locker room wearing a gray T-shirt with a photo of him and his son on the front. Across James' shoulders on the back read "The Chosen 1." Across the bottom of the shirt, it read "The 1 who chose."

"Felt like this was a game we really needed him," Redick said of Bronny James. "It was a game that [we needed] his athleticism, his defense. ... I think the biggest thing with him is he's got a lot of confidence right now."

The Lakers have won 13 of their last 15 games to vault to third place in the competitive Western Conference. They have six of their last nine regular-season games at home and, after this grueling stretch, they can't get there soon enough.

"Do we have to do this?" Redick said quietly as he sat down for his postgame news conference.

He knew everyone in the room wanted to get home.

COLLEGE BASKETBALL REPORT

DraftKings refutes NCAA's complaint

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DraftKings has been using "March Madness" and other familiar terms to refer to the NCAA tournament for more than five years and has the legal right to do so, the sportsbook said in a court filing Wednesday in response to a complaint filed by the NCAA last week.

The NCAA seeks an emergency temporary restraining order to stop DraftKings from using registered trademarks associated with its men's and women's basketball tournaments. The complaint for trademark infringement, filed in the Southern District of Indiana, requests that DraftKings stop using "March Madness," "Final Four," "Elite Eight" and "Sweet Sixteen" and variations of those terms to promote its business.

In its response, DraftKings described those terms as "the universally recognized names for the tournaments and their rounds, used by millions of college basketball fans, journalists, and participants in the sports-betting ecosystem. They are the same words used by other online sportsbooks, who have not been singled out by the NCAA's fevered complaint."

The NCAA said it actively avoids any appearance of affiliation with gambling and said in the complaint that DraftKings' use of the terms confuses customers by making it appear the NCAA is on board. DraftKings said its use of the terms is protected under the 1st Amendment.

LSU fires coach to bring back Wade

Louisiana State fired fourth-year coach Matt McMahon and rehired former Tigers coach Will Wade from North Carolina State, where Wade was in only the first of

a six-year contract with the Wolfpack.

"This was not an easy decision," Wade wrote in a social media post Thursday in which he thanked N.C. State for the opportunity to coach the Wolfpack. "But the opportunity to return to Louisiana State University is deeply personal. It's a chance to go home — to a place that means a great deal to me and my family."

The move brings back to the bayou a coach whose popularity with many Louisiana college basketball fans — including Gov. Jeff Landry — endured throughout, and long after, an NCAA investigation that dogged both Wade and LSU four years ago, resulting in sanctions for the program.

Etc.

Duke men's coach Jon Scheyer said point guard Caleb Foster will try to play in Friday night's Sweet 16 matchup against St. John's. Foster broke his right foot in Duke's regular-season finale and missed the first two rounds of the NCAA tournament for the top-seeded Blue Devils. ... South Florida hired Chris Mack as its men's basketball coach. Mack leaves the College of Charleston, where he went 45-20 over the past two seasons. ... Northwestern hired former UConn star Carla Berube as its women's basketball coach. Berube replaces the retired Joe McKeeown and will be tasked with turning around a program that hasn't won more than nine games in a season since 2021-22. ... In Wednesday's NIT quarterfinals, Johnny Kinziger had 16 points in Illinois State's 61-55 win against host Dayton, and Filip Jovic had 18 points in host Auburn's 75-69 victory over Nevada. ... Memphis hired Hana Haden from Georgia Southern as the 14th women's basketball coach in program history.

NCAA MEN'S BASKETBALL TOURNAMENT

RESULTS, SCHEDULE

EAST REGION

Today's Sweet 16 games

- 1 Duke vs. 5 St. John's, 4 p.m., CBS
- 2 Connecticut vs. 3 Michigan State, 6:45 p.m., CBS

SOUTH REGION

Thursday's Sweet 16 results

Voices **BILL SHAIKIN** COLUMNIST

Anaheim mulls future — with or without Angels

At the dawn of the 2025 season, we published a column with the headline, “What’s the future for aging Angel Stadium? It feels like an increasingly uncertain one.”

With opening day 2026 upon us, we’d like to update that: “What’s the future for the Angels? It feels like an increasingly uncertain one.”

I don’t mean to be an alarmist. Nothing is happening today, or tomorrow, or in the very near future. However, the Angels’ stadium lease expires in six years, so what might happen beyond then is starting to come into focus. Angels owner Arte Moreno turns 80 this summer. Moreno — or a new owner, if Moreno eventually sells the team — could simply exercise options to extend the lease for another six years.

But that would not resolve the larger issue of replacing or renovating Angel Stadium. In the coming months, the city expects to release an assessment of what it would take to keep the stadium up and running for years to come, and that could trigger a debate between the city and the Angels about who should pay for what.

The Angels are frustrated by all of this, and in particular by what they consider the curiously timed skirmishes over their 21-year-old Los Angeles name. They are annoyed that, for the second consecutive season, city issues have detracted from the hope and faith and joy that surrounds opening day. It is the city, after all, that walked away from two deals that would have secured the Angels’ long-term future in Anaheim.

During negotiations for the last deal, city officials made clear that keeping the Angels was the top priority, even if Anaheim could make more money selling the stadium property to a developer that would not need to retain the stadium.

Now, with six years left on the lease and no commitment beyond then, the mayor of Anaheim says it is time to prepare for a future with or without the Angels.

“We need to plan for what we

see as a vision for that property when the lease has expired,” Mayor Ashleigh Aitken told me. “That’s going to take time. No matter how that deal goes, we’re not breaking ground on any project next year.

“But what we need to do, whether it includes the Angels — which I hope it does — or not, is come up with a vision that includes everything residents want to see happen on that land. And only then can we truly advocate for a project that makes sense for us.”

On the day of the home opener last season, Aitken issued an open letter inviting Moreno to meet with her for “an open and honest conversation about the future of baseball in Anaheim” and listing eight starting points for negotiations on

a new deal, including the Angels’ restoration of the Anaheim name. “They have not reached out to us about reopening negotiations for potential development around the property,” Aitken said.

Moreno previously explored other potential ballpark sites, including Tustin in 2014 and Long Beach in 2019.

In Tustin, the targeted land is no longer available. In Long Beach, the proposed waterfront lot remains vacant, but the challenge remains too: Over 81 games each season, how would tens of thousands of fans drive into and out of a ballpark primarily accessible by a single freeway?

For the Los Angeles Angels, perhaps the solution could be found in Los Angeles County.

The Dodgers could bar every other major league team from moving into L.A., but not the Angels. Under MLB rules, neither team could stop the other team from moving anywhere within Los Angeles County or Orange County.

The logical landing spot would be Inglewood, where the Rams, Chargers and Clippers have moved since 2020. Inglewood Mayor James Butts said SoFi Stadium and Intuit Dome have helped to revitalize the city, with unemployment down, home prices up, and municipal revenue up.

“Before, we were known for gangs and crimes and poverty,” Butts told me.

“Now, we are known as the sports and entertainment capital of the western United States.”

How about a baseball stadium in place of the Forum?

“The Forum parcel is absolutely not large enough for a baseball stadium,” Butts said.

Butts said he believes a baseball stadium there would require about 170 acres for the stadium and surrounding parking. Angel Stadium and its surrounding parking lots cover about 150 acres.

On the other hand, the Athletics are building a ballpark on a nine-acre site in Las Vegas, where nearby parking, entertainment and dining options already exist, with more on the way, and with the A’s not responsible for any of that. The same could be true for the Angels in Inglewood, with Rams owner Stan Kroenke and Clippers owner Steve Ballmer developing the land around the sports facilities.

However, Butts said he did not envision baseball coming to Inglewood, at least so long as he remains the mayor. Not enough room in town, he said.

“We’re maxed out when it comes to sports,” Butts said. “We are not going to reduce the housing stock and move residents out to have a baseball team.”

Anaheim has one, plus a 150-acre site perfect for a new stadium surrounded by restaurants and shops and homes. There will be days to be anxious and worried about the Angels’ future in the city they have called home for 60 years. Today is not one of them.

Take it from the mayor of Anaheim, who told me that even after telling me why she wants the city attorney to look into whether the Angels are violating their stadium lease.

“Opening day, to me, is nothing about clauses in a contract,” Aitken said. “It’s about family traditions. It’s about kicking off summer. And it’s about getting so many factions and neighborhoods of Anaheim together for a singular purpose, which is cheering on our hometown boys. That’s the beauty of baseball.”

And, as a lifelong Angels fan, she had one more thing to say.

“Right now,” Aitken said, “we’re tied for first place.”

Trout, Schanuel homer as Angels win

ASSOCIATED PRESS

HOUSTON — Mike Trout homered to launch what he hopes will be a bounce-back year, leading the Angels to a season-opening 3-0 win over the Houston Astros on Thursday.

Trout also walked three times and played center field for the first time since April 2024. The three-time MVP played 130 games last season, his most since 2019 because of various injuries.

Making his franchise-record 14th opening day start, the 34-year-old Trout broke a scoreless tie in the seventh when he sent a 96-mph fastball from reliever AJ Blubaugh (0-1) 403 feet onto the train tracks in left center. It was his fifth opening day homer, also a club record.

The Angels snapped an eight-game road losing streak in season openers, starting 1-0 on the road for the first time since 2013.

Oswald Peraza hit an RBI single in the eighth and Nolan Schanuel homered in the ninth.

José Soriano (1-0) gave up two hits and four walks in six innings while striking out seven. Four relievers completed the three-hitter,



DAVID J. PHILLIP Associated Press

THE ASTROS’ Cam Smith steals second base as Angels second baseman Oswald Peraza tries to catch the wide throw Thursday.

with Jordan Romano working the ninth to earn the save in his Angels debut. Hunter Brown started for Houston and yielded four hits and four walks in 4²/₃ innings. He struck out nine.

The Astros went 0 for 7 with runners in scoring position while stranding nine runners.

Houston designated hitter Yordan Alvarez may have been robbed

of a home run in the first inning because the retractable roof at Daikin Park was closed. Alvarez hit a towering shot toward the right-field foul pole, but it ricocheted off a horizontal rafter and landed in foul territory.

It was ruled a foul ball. The Astros challenged, and the call was upheld after a review. Alvarez later struck out swinging.

MLB STANDINGS

Through Wednesday

NATIONAL LEAGUE

West	W	L	Pct.	GB	L10
Arizona	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Colorado	0	0	.000	—	0-0
DODGERS	0	0	.000	—	0-0
San Diego	0	0	.000	—	0-0
San Francisco	0	1	.000	½	0-1
Central	W	L	Pct.	GB	L10
Chicago	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Cincinnati	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Milwaukee	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Pittsburgh	0	0	.000	—	0-0
St. Louis	0	0	.000	—	0-0
East	W	L	Pct.	GB	L10
Atlanta	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Miami	0	0	.000	—	0-0
New York	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Philadelphia	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Washington	0	0	.000	—	0-0

AMERICAN LEAGUE

West	W	L	Pct.	GB	L10
Athletics	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Houston	0	0	.000	—	0-0
ANGELS	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Seattle	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Texas	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Central	W	L	Pct.	GB	L10
Chicago	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Cleveland	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Detroit	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Kansas City	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Minnesota	0	0	.000	—	0-0
East	W	L	Pct.	GB	L10
New York	1	0	1.000	—	1-0
Baltimore	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Boston	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Tampa Bay	0	0	.000	—	0-0
Toronto	0	0	.000	—	0-0

Today’s games

Dodgers vs. Arizona	7 p.m.
Angels at Houston	5:15 p.m.
New York (AL) at San Francisco	1:30 p.m.
Athletics at Toronto	4 p.m.
Colorado at Miami	4 p.m.
Kansas City at Atlanta	4:15 p.m.
Cleveland at Seattle	6:30 p.m.
Detroit at San Diego	6:30 p.m.

WEDNESDAY’S BOX N.Y. YANKEES 7, SAN FRANCISCO 0

New York	AB	R	H	BI	Avg.	San Fran	AB	R	H	BI	Avg.	
Grisham cf	5	0	1	2	.200	Arraez 2b	3	0	1	0	.333	
Judge lf	5	0	0	.000		Chapman 3b	3	0	0	.000		
Bellinger lf	5	1	1	0	.200	Devers dh	4	0	1	0	.250	
Rice 1b	4	1	1	0	.250	Adames ss	4	0	0	.000		
Stanton dh	4	1	2	1	.500	Lee rf	4	0	0	.000		
Chisholm 2b	3	1	1	0	.333	Ramos lf	4	0	1	0	.250	
Cabellero ss	4	1	1	1	.250	Schmitt 1b	3	0	0	.000		
McMinn 3b	3	1	2	1	.333	Bailey c	3	0	0	.000		
Wells c	3	1	2	0	.667	Bader cf	3	0	0	.000		
Totals	36	7	10	6		Totals	31	0	3	0		
New York						050	020	000	—	7	10	1
San Francisco						000	000	000	—	0	3	1
Walks—New York 3; Rice 1, McMahon 1, Wells 1. San Francisco 2: Arraez 1, Chapman 1. Strikeouts—New York 12: Grisham 1, Judge 4, Bellinger 2, Rice 2, Stanton 1, McMahon 2. San Francisco 6: Adames 1, Ramos 2, Bailey 1, Bader 2. E—Cabellero (1), Adames (1). LOB—New York 6, San Francisco 7. 3B—Grisham (1), RBIs—Caballero (1), McMahon 2 (2), Grisham 2 (2), Stanton (1), SB—Chisholm (1).												
Runners left in scoring position—New York 3 (McMahon, Judge, Bellinger); San Francisco 3 (Schmitt, Lee, Devers). RISP, New York 4 for 11; San Francisco 0 for 5. Runners moved up—Ramos. GDP—Caballero. DP—San Francisco 1 (Adames, Arraez, Schmitt).												
New York	IP					H	R	ER	BB	SO	NP	ERA
Fried, W, 1-0	6 2					0	0	1	4	86	0.00	
Bird, H, 1-0	0					0	0	0	1	7	0.00	
Headrick, W, 1-0	1					0	0	0	1	15	0.00	
Doval, W, 1-0	1					0	0	0	0	13	0.00	
San Francisco	IP					H	R	ER	BB	SO	NP	ERA
Webb, L, 0-1	5					9	7	6	1	7	86	10.80
Winn, W, 1-0	1					0	0	0	1	2	19	0.00
Brubaker, W, 1-0	2					1	0	0	1	2	22	0.00
Kilian, W, 1-0	1					0	0	0	1	10	0.00	
HBP—Webb (Chisholm), Fried (Schmitt). WP—Doval.												
U—Bill Miller, Chad Fairchild, Chad Whitson, Brian Walsh, T—2-27.												
Tickets sold—40,856 (41,915).												



Photographs by GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

SHOHEI OHTANI warms up in the outfield before the game against the Arizona Diamondbacks on Thursday at Dodger Stadium.

Players get ready to focus on winning again

[Dodgers, from B10] amondbacks.

“Everyone’s different,” Freeman said. “Some people want to move on and get on to the new season and not worry about last year. I’m one of the guys that can appreciate what we did last year, even in the present year.

“It’s hard to win a World Series. I don’t like to just kick it to the side. ... Our fans haven’t celebrated it since the parade. We get to celebrate with our fans and open the weekend. It’s going to be a great time.”

Catcher Will Smith was more in the other camp.

“I get my ring, and I put it in the safe, and I don’t really look at it ever again,” he said when asked about the ring ceremony. “It brings back all the emotions from the prior year, you like showing friends and stuff, it’s cool. But no, for me, the motivation is just winning, being with these guys each and every day, and competing with them and working towards that goal.”

On that point, Dodgers players seem to agree.

They don’t need a tangible reminder of their World Series aspirations this year.

“It’ll be one of the few days where we really think about what we did last year, versus what we’re trying to do right now,” veteran third baseman Max Muncy said.

Plenty of teams say their goal is



FORMER DODGERS player Steve Garvey, left, and broadcaster Jaime Jarrin unveil the Dodgers’ 2025 championship sign.

to win the World Series. But the Dodgers have raised their outside expectations, too. Entering Thursday, PECOTA put the Dodgers’ odds of completing a three-peat at 20.8%, by far the highest World Series chances in the majors. PECOTA, Baseball Prospectus’ projection system, listed the Mariners as next most likely to win the World Series, at 14.2%.

While those numbers establish

a clear favorite, they also reflect how unpredictable the postseason can be.

Even the Dodgers, with their lofty payroll and strong player development track record, will need health, luck and the right mindset to pull off a third straight championship.

“You know what the goal is every single year, and that’s to be the last team standing at the end,”

Muncy said. “But we more so preach, how do you get there, instead of that being the goal. And for us, it’s always been, you have to take it one day at a time.”

The phrase itself isn’t a novel concept. The trick is making that focus a reality, and a team standard.

“I talk about it every day,” manager Dave Roberts said. “I’ve talked about it since I got here. It’s just, let’s win a baseball game. That’s our mantra, and everyone in this building, that’s the goal.”

The veterans on the team preach it too, hoping to pass down that team-first focus to the generation coming behind them.

“When you put on this uniform, you come in here, you see all these superstars working extremely hard every single day — front office, ownership group doing the same thing — that’s the expectation,” Freeman said. “It’s a different standard, and you just want to be part of that standard that keeps the level high.”

After the commotion of the championship banner reveal and the ring presentation the first two days of the season, “let’s win a baseball game,” will continue to be the mantra.

Maybe it will even work well enough, day after day, for the Dodgers to add another sign to their championship display this time next year.



WALLY SKALIJ Los Angeles Times

WEIGHTLIFTER Laurel Hubbard of New Zealand competes during the Summer Olympics in Tokyo in 2021.

IOC policy bans transgender women from Olympic events

A saliva test, cheek swab or blood sample will decide eligibility at 2028 Games in L.A.

By STEVE HENSON

Transgender women athletes will be excluded from the Olympics beginning with the 2028 Los Angeles Games after the International Olympic Committee implemented a new eligibility policy on Thursday.

Eligibility for women's competition will be determined by a one-time, mandatory genetics test, according to the IOC. The test requires screening through saliva, a cheek swab or a blood sample.

No transgender woman competed at the 2024 Paris Summer Games, and it is unclear if any transgender women currently compete at an Olympic level.

Weightlifter Laurel Hubbard of New Zealand was the last to do so, competing in the 2021 Tokyo Olympics without winning a medal.

The new eligibility policy is not retroactive and does not apply to recreational sports programs.

The IOC said in a statement that it “protects fairness, safety and integrity in the female category.”

“Eligibility for any female

category event at the Olympic Games or any other IOC event, including individual and team sports, is now limited to biological females.”

Until now, individual sports federations have determined whether transgender women were allowed to compete in women's categories, with the IOC providing recommendations.

Sports that placed restrictions on transgender athletes included track and field, boxing, swimming and rugby.

A 2023 systematic review of the literature on sports participation published in the National Library of Medicine cautioned against imposing blanket restrictions on transgender athletes.

“Reasonable accommodations for the inclusion of trans people are sport specific and could be based on the range of competitive advantages and abilities that are already accepted in the cisgender population,” the review stated.

The IOC Executive Board nevertheless approved the new policy after 18 months of study. It mirrors the guidelines approved in June by the World Athletics Council, which will determine eligibility for the female category through screening for the SRY gene.

The IOC policy leans on scientific research that con-

siders the presence of the SRY gene fixed for life and represents evidence that an athlete has experienced male sex development. Athletes who screen negative for the SRY gene will be eligible to compete in women's sports.

SRY (which stands for sex-determining region Y gene) is found on the Y chromosome. In the cell, it binds to other DNA, leading to testis formation, according to the National Library of Medicine.

Even men who lack Y chromosomes still have a copy of the SRY region on one of their X chromosomes, which accounts for their maleness.

Jane Thornton, the IOC medical and scientific director, last year presented to the executive board findings from a two-year study that transgender athletes born with male sexual markers retained physical advantages for several years, even those who had received treatment to reduce testosterone.

Kirsty Coventry, a former gold-medal Olympics swimmer from Zimbabwe, was elected a year ago as the first female president of the IOC. She campaigned on the importance of protecting the women's category.

“At the Olympic Games, even the smallest margins can be the difference between victory and defeat,”

Coventry said Thursday in a statement. “So, it is absolutely clear that it would not be fair for biological males to compete in the female category.”

Los Angeles LGBT Center CEO Joe Hollendonner takes a different view, pointing out that the policy subjects all female athletes to a physical examination and genetic testing.

“The IOC’s policy doesn’t address a rampant problem,” Hollendonner said in a statement. As the host city of the 2028 Games, Los Angeles has a responsibility to lead with its values and uphold the law.

“We encourage city and state leaders to affirm their commitment to inclusion and ensure that all athletes are treated with dignity and equity. Failure to act risks reinforcing a broader effort to exclude trans people from public life—including sport.”

The new policy aligns with President Trump’s executive order banning transgender athletes from participating in women’s or girls’ sporting events in the United States.

White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt expressed delight at the new IOC eligibility policy.

“You cannot change your sex,” she wrote on X. “President Trump’s Executive Order protecting women’s sports made this happen!”

Uniqlo Field will still be Dodger Stadium

[**Shaikin**, from B10] \$125 million. That provides the Dodgers with an annual naming rights payment in line with the ones at Crypto.com Arena, Intuit Dome and SoFi Stadium, without the Dodgers having to sell naming rights to the actual venue.

Are the Dodgers baseball’s version of a gold mine? Yes. Do they spend big and win big? Also yes. Do you mind if Uniqlo essentially covers Freddie Freeman’s salary this season?

“We need a lot of revenue to put out the product that we do,” Dodgers president Stan Kasten said. “That’s not a secret. And we’re proud of everyone who helps us do it: all of our fans, all of our media partners, and all of our sponsor partners. They are all important. It is how this all comes together.”

While Uniqlo would be delighted if you used its name, whatever local fans choose to call the stadium is not critical to the success of the partnership.

For a Japanese company in pursuit of brand awareness and expansion in the United States and elsewhere, there might be nothing better than getting your name in front of millions of fans around the world watching Shohei Ohtani play on television.

Ohtani made an estimated \$125 million in endorsements and sponsorships last year, Sportico reported, a larger annual haul “than any other athlete in the history of sports.”

“The Dodgers are such a popular team,” Yanai said.



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

FANS enter Uniqlo Field at Dodger Stadium on Thursday for the opening game.

“I usually ask my wife, after I come back from the office, whether Shohei hit a home run. I think all the Japanese people do that.”

According to Forbes, Yanai is the richest man in Japan, where baseball teams carry corporate names. Why not buy a team and call it, say, the Uniqlo Bears?

“I always keep saying that could be very interesting,” he said, “but my wife turned it down. She keeps telling me, ‘Tadashi, you are not cut out to manage sports teams.’”

Instead, he is managing Uniqlo, an apparel company that pitches itself as blending comfort with quality. “We do not make disposable clothing,” Yanai said in the company’s last annual report.

Uniqlo has 794 stores in

Japan but only 77 in the United States, including 14 in the Southland.

Koji Yanai, a senior executive officer and Tadashi’s son, said the company aspires to grow annual U.S. revenues from \$6 billion to \$30 billion.

He shared what might be a more challenging aspiration.

“The Uniqlo Field at Dodger Stadium name may be very new for everyone,” he said, “but I hope in the near future the fans will like it and will love it.”

United Airlines Field at the Coliseum? Yeah, no.

Jeff Marks, the chief executive of Los Angeles-based Innovative Partnerships Group, once brokered a naming rights deal in which the Cal football team would play on Kabam Field at California Memorial

Stadium. He tried to find a receptive audience for the name.

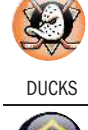
“We educated a lot of freshmen, sophomores and newcomers,” Marks said. “Are you going to go after alumni who have been calling it Memorial Stadium? No. So you didn’t focus on that. You focused on people that could be more impressionable, and it worked.”

With Dodger Stadium, we’ll see. For the 2026 season, it is now time for Dodgers baseball, but not before one reporter at a news conference Wednesday asked company officials whether Uniqlo would provide the Dodgers players with free clothing.

Kasten could not pass up the chance to interject.

“We pay them enough,” he said with a grin, “to shop at Uniqlo stores.”

PRO CALENDAR

	FRI 27	SAT 28	SUN 29	MON 30	TUE 31
 DODGERS	ARIZONA 7 SNLA	ARIZONA 6 SNLA		CLEVE. 7 SNLA	CLEVE. 7 SNLA
 ANGELS	at Houston 5 Apple TV	at Houston 4 FDW	at Houston 11 a.m. FDW	at Chicago Cubs 4:30 FDW	at Chicago Cubs 4:30 FDW
 LAKERS	BROOKLYN 7:30 SpecSN			WASH. 7 SpecSN	CLEVE. 7:30 SpecSN
 CLIPPERS	at Indiana 4 FDW		Milw. 12:30 FDSC		PORTLAND 8 NBC, FDSC
 KINGS		UTAH 6 FDSC, KCLA			
 DUCKS		at Edmonton 12:30 KTTV, Victory+		TORONTO 7 KCOP, Victory+	
 GALAXY	NEXT: APRIL 4 VS. MINNESOTA, 6:30 P.M., APPLE TV				
 LAFC	NEXT: APRIL 4 VS. ORLANDO, 7:30 P.M., APPLE TV				
 ANGEL CITY	HOUSTON 7 Amazon Prime				

Shade denotes home games. Times Pacific.

TODAY ON THE AIR

TIME	EVENT	TV/ RADIO
AUSTRALIAN FOOTBALL		
6:20 p.m.	AFL, St. Kilda vs. Brisbane	FS2
AUTO RACING		
11:30 a.m.	Indy NXT, Grand Prix of Alabama, Practice 1	FS2
12:30 p.m.	IndyCar, Grand Prix of Alabama, Practice 1	FS2
7:30 p.m.	Formula One, Japanese Grand Prix, Practice 3	Apple TV
11 p.m.	Formula One, Japanese Grand Prix, qualifying	Apple TV
BASEBALL		
4 p.m.	Athletics at Toronto	MLB
5 p.m.	Angels at Houston	Apple TV; 830
6:30 p.m.	Cleveland at Seattle	Apple TV
7 p.m.	Arizona at Dodgers	SNLA, MLB; 570, 1020
BASKETBALL: AFRICAN LEAGUE		
7 a.m.	Al Hily Ly vs. Armee Patriotique Rwandaise	NBA
6 a.m. (Sat.)	Dar City BC vs. Nairobi City	NBA
BASKETBALL: EUROLEAGUE		
10:30 a.m.	Fenerbahce Beko vs. Zalgiris Kaunas	FDW
BASKETBALL: NBA		
4 p.m.	Clippers at Indiana	FDSC; 570, 1330
4:30 p.m.	Miami at Cleveland	NBA
7 p.m.	Dallas at Portland	NBA
7:30 p.m.	Brooklyn at Lakers	SpecSN; 710, 980
COLLEGE BASEBALL		
2 p.m.	UCLA at Iowa	Big Ten+
3 p.m.	USC at Maryland	Big Ten+
5 p.m.	Oklahoma at Texas	SEC
5 p.m.	Tennessee at Vanderbilt	ESPNU
5 p.m.	Miami at Clemson	ACC
COLLEGE BASKETBALL MEN'S NCAA TOURNAMENT, SWEET 16		
4:10 p.m.	St. John's vs. Duke	CBS
4:35 p.m.	Alabama vs. Michigan	TBS, truTV
6:45 p.m.	Michigan State vs. Connecticut	CBS
7:10 p.m.	Tennessee vs. Iowa State	TBS, truTV
COLLEGE BASKETBALL: WOMEN'S NCAA TOURNAMENT, SWEET 16		
11:30 a.m.	Notre Dame vs. Vanderbilt	ESPN
2 p.m.	North Carolina vs. Connecticut	ESPN
4:30 p.m.	Minnesota vs. UCLA	ESPN
7 p.m.	Duke vs. Louisiana State	ESPN
COLLEGE HOCKEY: MEN'S NCAA TOURNAMENT, REGIONAL SEMIFINALS		
11:30 a.m.	Minnesota State vs. Western Michigan	ESPNU
2:30 p.m.	Bentley vs. Michigan	ESPNU
3 p.m.	Cornell vs. Denver	ESPN+
6 p.m.	Penn State vs. Minnesota Duluth	ESPN2
COLLEGE SOFTBALL		
2 p.m.	Maryland at Wisconsin	Big Ten
4 p.m.	Florida at Arkansas	ESPN2
4 p.m.	Oregon at Northwestern	Big Ten
6 p.m.	UCLA at Nebraska	FS1
COLLEGE VOLLEYBALL: MEN		
6 p.m.	UCLA at Stanford	Big Ten+
7 p.m.	Menlo at USC	Big Ten+
FIGURE SKATING: WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS		
10 a.m.	Women's free skate	USA
GOLF		
8 a.m.	PGA Korn Ferry, Club Car Championship, second round	Golf
Noon	PGA Tour, Houston Open, second round	Golf
4 p.m.	LPGA Tour, Ford Championship, second round	Golf
1 a.m. (Sat.)	World Tour, Indian Open, third round	Golf
HOCKEY		
4 p.m.	Detroit at Buffalo	NHL
HORSE RACING		
10:30 a.m.	America's Day at the Races	FS2
2 p.m.	America's Day at the Races	FS2
5 a.m. (Sat.)	Dubai World Cup	FS2
PICKLEBALL		
4 p.m.	PPA, Greater Zion Cup, quarterfinals	FS1
PRO FOOTBALL		
5 p.m.	UFL, Birmingham at Louisville	Fox, FoxD
SOCCER		
12:30 p.m.	International friendly, Algeria vs. Guatemala	FoxD
12:45 p.m.	International friendly, England vs. Uruguay	FS1
1:10 p.m.	International friendly, Morocco vs. Ecuador	ESPND
4:15 p.m.	International friendly, Argentina vs. Mauritania	beIN
7 p.m.	NWSL, Angel City vs. Houston	Amazon Prime; iHeart
6:20 a.m. (Sat.)	England, women, Manchester United vs. Manchester City	ESPN+, ESPND
TENNIS		
10 a.m.	ATP / WTA, Miami Open, semifinals	Tennis

SPORTS EXTRA

For coverage of late Dodgers, Lakers and college games, and more, see our daily digital eNewspaper. Subscribers get free access to an exclusive “Sports Extra.” View it on your phone, tablet or computer at latimes.com/enewspaper.



SPORTS

FRIDAY, MARCH 27, 2026 :: LATIMES.COM/SPORTS

MLB OPENING DAY



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

DODGERS pitcher Yoshinobu Yamamoto delivers to Arizona leadoff hitter Ketel Marte during the first inning of the season opener against the Diamondbacks at Dodger Stadium on Thursday night. For the game’s result and complete coverage, go to latimes.com/sports or the daily digital eNewspaper.

Dodgers ready to bling in new year

Voices
BILL SHAIKIN COLUMNIST

Uniqlo Field doesn’t quite roll off tongue

It was Dodger Stadium on Wednesday, when the grass outside the baseline and the bright red sign high above center field read “UNIQLO FIELD.” It will be Dodger Stadium on Thursday, when the defending World Series champions open their new season, and forevermore.

The official name of our summer home is now Uniqlo Field at Dodger Stadium. The team announcers will say that, and so will some of the signs. The fans won’t, and the founder of the company that just spent nine figures on the name you won’t use said he completely understands.

“That’s a very natural reaction,” Uniqlo founder Tadashi Yanai told me through an interpreter. “We respect that.”

Yanai said his company’s deal with the Dodgers covers five years. He would say only that the total value was “more” than [See Shaikin, B9]



DAVID J. PHILLIP Associated Press

THE ANGELS’ Mike Trout belts a solo home run against the Astros during the seventh inning of Thursday’s opener at Daikin Park in Houston.

ANGELS WIN OPENER IN HOUSTON

Mike Trout and Nolan Schanuel hit home runs and José Soriano turned in a solid start as the Angels won 3-0 in Kurt Suzuki’s managerial debut. **B8**

It’s time to cherish another ring, then refocus on winning

BY MADDIE LEE

First baseman Freddie Freeman, pausing outside of the Dodgers’ home dugout to talk about the upcoming season, nodded his head toward the right-field foul pole, where just beyond it the Dodgers’ championships signs are displayed.

Eight baseball-shaped signs sported their years — 1955, 1959, 1963, 1965, 1981, 1988, 2020, 2024 — while a ninth was still shielded by a blue cover, with plenty of room along the stadium’s club level for more.

“You want to just keep putting those banners up,” Freeman said. “That one’s blocked for a reason. You want to do it again. You want to keep doing it over and over and over again. And that’s what’s fun, and then that’s what makes everything else just take care of itself.”

The 2025 championship sign will be revealed as the Dodgers both celebrate last year’s achievements and set the tone for this year.

They’ll receive their World Series ring on Friday, but they’ll also be in the midst of playing three games against the Arizona Di- [See Dodgers, B8]

Doncic scores 43 as road-weary Lakers hold off Pacers’ rally

James, Reaves, Hayes each score at least 21 points to end six-game trip with fifth victory.

By THUC NHI NGUYEN

INDIANAPOLIS — Even LeBron James couldn’t muster the energy. With a wide-open lane in the ending moments of the Lakers’ 137-130 win over the Indiana Pacers, James simply dumped off a pass to Jake LaRavia. The 24-year-old had hops to put the finishing touches on the Lakers’ successful six-game trip.

Tired and shorthanded, the Lakers punctuated their extended trip with a fifth win Wednesday. Luka Doncic effortlessly scored his league-leading 14th 40-point game

of the season with 43 points and seven assists.

The NBA’s leading scorer appeared ready to settle for simply his 11th consecutive 30-point performance — which is tied for the longest streak of such games in the last 20 years — after the Lakers opened a 20-point lead entering the fourth quarter, but he returned to the game because Indiana, despite having the worst record in the NBA, was still pressuring with its starters. The Pacers (16-57) trailed by as many as 29 in the third quarter and trimmed the deficit to six with 27.9 seconds left.

“I think everybody was a little bit tired,” Doncic said. “It’s been a long trip, but we got the win in the end; that’s what matters.”

The wear and tear of an intense trip in which the first [See Lakers, B7]



ANDY LYONS Getty Images

LUKA DONCIC (77) nearly outscored the Pacers alone in the first quarter, scoring 21 in the period.

UCLA brims with confidence ahead of Minnesota test

Bruins haven’t gotten wins as lopsided as other No. 1 seeds, but they trust the process.

By MARISA INGEMI

SACRAMENTO — The UCLA women’s basketball team hasn’t lost a game in 120 days. In that time, the Bruins have outscored opponents by a total of 806 points and just one other school — Connecticut — has gone without a loss during the same stretch.

Yet somehow, the No. 1 seed in the Sacramento 2 Region of the NCAA tournament hasn’t captured the same momentum and praise as the other three top seeds who have muscled their way



SWEET SIXTEEN
1 UCLA vs. 4 Minnesota

REGION 2
IN SACRAMENTO
Today, 4:30 p.m., ESPN

into the Sweet 16.

UCLA (33-1) will play No. 4 Minnesota (24-8) at 4:30 p.m. Friday in Sacramento. The game will air on ESPN. Entering the matchup, is UCLA’s less dominant NCAA tournament run a cause for concern? Or is a win a win when it comes to March? [See UCLA, B7]

Los Angeles Times

SPORTS EXTRA

A TIMES E-NEWSPAPER EXCLUSIVE :: FRIDAY, MARCH 27, 2026



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

ANDY PAGES is greeted at home plate by teammates Teoscar Hernández, left, and Max Muncy after hitting a three-run homer in the fifth inning at Dodger Stadium.

Rojas, Dodgers raise curtain with emotion

BY MADDIE LEE

In a quiet moment before the pomp and circumstance of opening day, Dodgers second baseman Miguel Rojas learned he'd be starting in the final season opener of his long career.

He was on the bench for the Freeway Series finale at Dodger Stadium earlier this week, when manager Dave Roberts came over to check in and give Rojas the news.

"I didn't know if 'Thank you' was the right thing to say because it's something I earned," Rojas recounted before the Dodgers' 8-2 win Thursday against the Diamondbacks. "It's not something that I asked for as a favor. So I was just kind of speechless."

Rojas embraced Roberts.

"It was a gift to myself because of all the hard work and the preparation I put in throughout my

whole career," Rojas said. "This way is the best way possible because I got up to the big leagues as a utility defensive replacement who can play shortstop but couldn't really hit much."

Rojas, who intends to retire after this year, wrapped up his final opening day as a starter.

Opening day is a celebration across baseball. But the Dodgers made it a full production. The pregame program Thursday included roster-introduction pyrotechnics, along with a stage and blue carpet set up in center field.

It was also a time to commemorate the 2025 World Series, raising the banner and revealing the new sign marking the organization's ninth title.

Rojas rode onto the field perched atop a metallic blue convertible, hoisting the 2025 World Series trophy over his head. To his left sat Freddie Freeman, holding the 2024 trophy. Will Ferrell sat in

the driver's seat.

"It's here," Rojas said Thursday afternoon. "This is my last chance to play baseball with an amazing group of guys."

A spot in the starting lineup hadn't been guaranteed for the 2025 World Series hero. The Diamondbacks started right-hander Zac Gallen. And throughout the year, Rojas will generally play second base against left-handers, platooning with Alex Freeland to begin the year and eventually Tommy Edman when he returns from the 10-day injured list.

"This means a lot to him, his family and to the Dodger fans," Roberts said. "And also, most importantly, I think he's a great option for today. All in, it was the right decision."

Rojas' final opening day — he's lined up to transition into a player development role with the Dodgers next year — was a well-rounded game for the Dodgers.

A marquee pitching matchup between Yoshinobu Yamamoto and Gallen produced a scoreless first three innings.

The Diamondbacks broke through first, with Geraldo Perdomo roping a two-run homer off Yamamoto in the fourth inning.

The Dodgers hadn't recorded a hit since Shohei Ohtani's leadoff single. But in the fifth, they finally got to Gallen and batted through the order.

Max Muncy and Teoscar Hernández kicked off the rally with back-to-back ground-ball singles. Then Andy Pages launched a go-ahead home run into the left-field seats.

Rojas, dropping a single into shallow center field, and Ohtani, drawing a walk, held on the pressure. And the Diamondbacks pulled Gallen for right-hander Juan Morillo.

The Dodgers tacked on one more run, as Rojas raced home on

Will Smith's single up the first-base line, before Morillo finally escaped a bases-loaded jam.

The next inning, Yamamoto slammed the door shut against the top of the order with a pair of groundouts to Rojas and a strikeout, Yamamoto's sixth. He retired nine straight batters after Perdomo's homer.

That ended Yamamoto's night at six innings.

The Dodgers continued piling on against the Diamondbacks' bullpen. A four-run rally in the seventh inning featured Kyle Tucker's first hit as a Dodger, an RBI double and a two-run shot from Smith.

The Dodgers' bullpen held the Diamondbacks scoreless the rest of the way.

After reliever Tanner Scott forced a fly out to shortstop Mookie Betts to end the game, Rojas pointed two fingers to the sky and then joined his teammates in the handshake line.

Kuemper's shutout helps the Kings stay in hunt for wild card

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Darcy Kuemper made 19 saves for his third shutout of the season and 39th of his career to lead the Kings to a 4-0 victory over the host Vancouver Canucks on Thursday night.

Trevor Moore had a goal and an assist for the Kings, and Scott Laughton, Artemi Panarin and Quinton Byfield also scored. Mikey Anderson had a pair of assists.

The victory moved the Kings within one point of the Nashville Predators, who hold the second wild-card spot in the Western Conference.

One of the best stops by Kuemper, whose last shutout was on Dec. 6 against Chicago, came at the 10:43 mark of the first period when Teddy Blueger launched a blast from the slot and the goaltender kicked out his right leg to send the puck soaring with the toe of his skate.

Kevin Lankinen made 34 saves for the Canucks, who lost their fourth straight game.

The Kings opened the scoring with Laughton's power-play goal 17:34 into the first period.

Stationed at the top of the face-off circle, Byfield took a shot that hit the skate of Laughton as he jumped in front of the net, deflecting the puck in past Lankinen.

Granlund's hat trick sparks streaking Ducks

Mikael Granlund capped his hat trick scoring on the power play with one second remaining in overtime to give the Ducks a 3-2 victory over the host Calgary Flames.

Granlund has seven goals during a four-game goal streak that has him up to 19 on the season as the Ducks extended their winning streak to four games.

The Pacific Division-leading Ducks have a five-point lead on the Edmonton Oilers and a six-point lead on the Vegas Golden Knights.

Rookie Matvei Gridin and Blake Coleman scored for Calgary, which extended its point streak to five games (4-0-1). Gridin stretched his point streak to four games (one goal, three assists).

The game got off to an inauspicious start for the Flames. First, Pavel Mintyukov's turnover in the opening minute of the game resulted in a 3-on-0 breakaway for Calgary but Gridin, Morgan Frost and Matt Coronato over-passed it and never got a shot on goal.

Three minutes later, it appeared that Yegor Sharangovich had given Calgary the lead, but the Ducks challenged for offense and the goal was overturned. It was the fifth goal the Flames have had waved off by video review during its homestand.



ETHAN CAIRNS Associated Press

THE KINGS' Artemi Panarin (10) scores on Canucks goaltender Kevin Lankinen during the second period. Since being traded by the Rangers, Panarin has seven goals in 15 games with the Kings.

NCAA TOURNAMENT

Burries, Wildcats eliminate Arkansas

Arizona finally got over the Sweet 16 hurdle under coach Tommy Lloyd, getting 23 points from former Eastvale Roosevelt High star Brayden Burries and a dominant offensive effort in a 109-88 win over Arkansas in San José.

Fellow freshmen Koa Peat added 21 points and Ivan Kharchenko had 15 as the top-seeded Wildcats (35-2) won their 12th straight game overall to tie a school record for

wins in a season and advance to the Elite Eight for the first time since 2015. Arizona will play second-seeded Purdue on Saturday night for a spot in the Final Four.

No. 2 Purdue 79, No. 11 Texas 77: Trey Kaufman-Renn tipped in a miss by Braden Smith with 0.7 seconds left, and the Boilermakers edged hobbling star Tramon Mark and the Longhorns in San José.

Texas (21-15) tied its moments earlier when Dailyn Swain made a driving layup, was fouled and converted the three-point play with 11.9 seconds to go. Mark scored 29 for the Longhorns, grimacing and clearly in pain limping on his injured leg through the closing min-

utes when the sixth-year senior's team needed him most.

No. 3 Illinois 65, No. 2 Houston 55: In Houston, David Mirkovic had 14 points and 10 rebounds, and the Fighting Illini flexed their defensive muscles to eliminate last year's national runner-up from the tournament, beating Houston.

No. 9 Iowa 77, No. 4 Nebraska 71: Alvaro Folgueiras converted a critical three-point play when the Cornhuskers had just four defenders on the floor, and the Hawkeyes continued their unpredictable run under first-year coach Ben McCollum in Houston. Bennett Stirtz scored 20 points and Folgueiras had 16 for the Hawkeyes.

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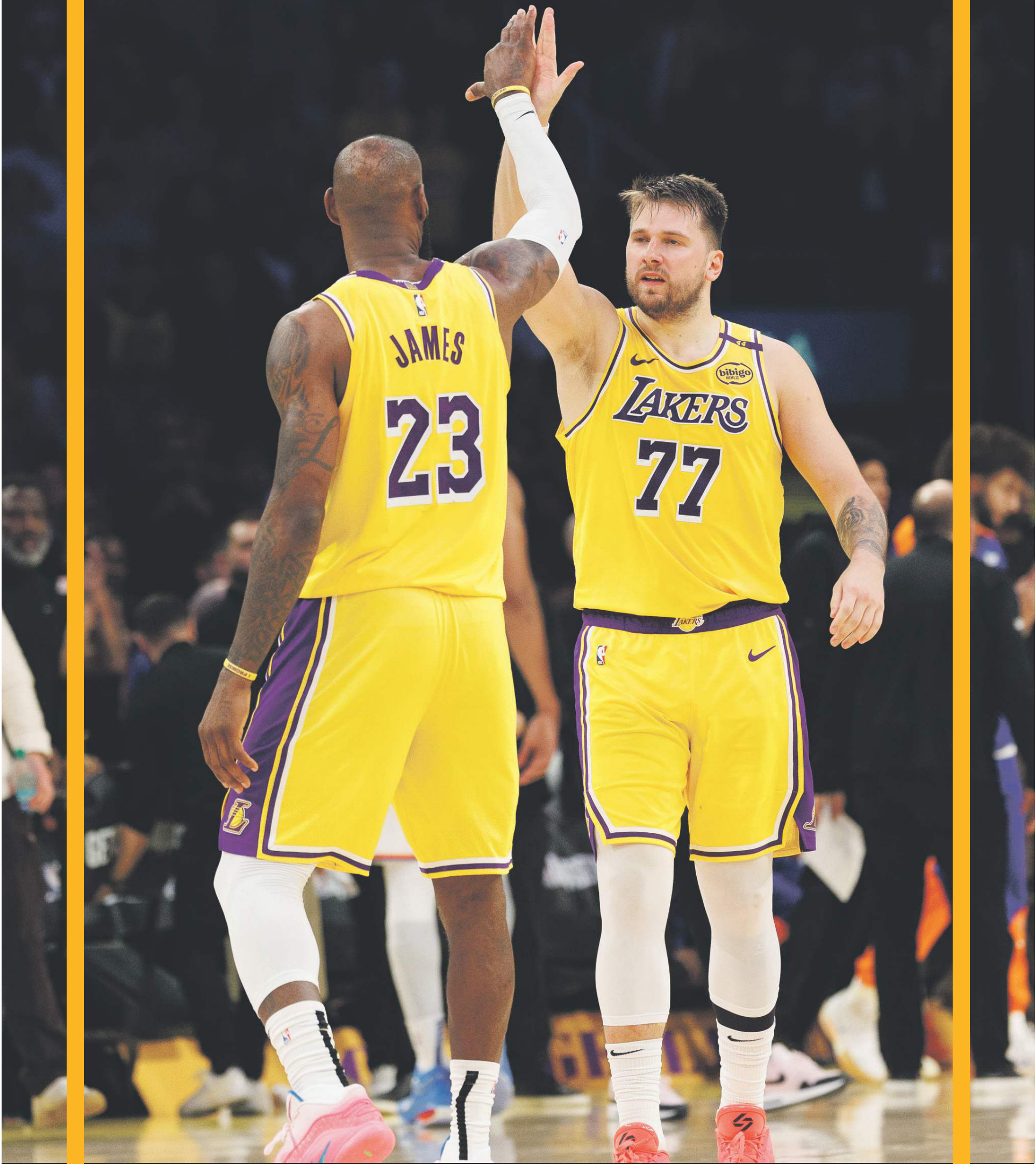
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ENTERTAINMENT

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ACTOR Victoria Pedretti says her “Forbidden Fruits” witch character “kind of took over.” Her TV projects have included “The Haunting of Bly Manor” and “You.”
EVELYN FREJA For The Times

Victoria Pedretti is a new breed of scream queen

Already familiar to fans of ‘The Haunting of Hill House,’ the actor shows off her range in the campy horror-comedy film ‘Forbidden Fruits’

By Malia Mendez

Victoria Pedretti was fresh out of Carnegie Mellon University’s School of Drama when she was cast in Mike Flanagan’s acclaimed 2018 horror series, “The Haunting of Hill House.”

In her breakout role as Nell Crain, the youngest and most sensitive of five adult siblings reckoning with wounds from a childhood summer spent in a cursed home, Pedretti became the undisputed heart of “Hill House,” anchoring the show with a spellbinding performance that christened her as a scream queen. Her subsequent appearances in “The Haunting of Bly Manor” and “You” were characterized by a similar dramatic intensity, solidifying her renown in the horror genre.

But in Pedretti’s new “Forbidden Fruits,” a horror-comedy directed by Meredith Alloway making her feature debut and produced by “Jennifer’s Body” screenwriter Diablo Cody, the actor shines in all-new soapy splendor.

Set in a Dallas shopping mall, “Forbidden Fruits” revolves around an elite clique of retail employees who run a witches’ coven out of the basement of their boho boutique Free Eden. Pedretti stars alongside Lili Reinhart, Lola Tung and Alexandra Shipp.

Initially asked to look at both the roles of whimsygoth physics buff Fig and the bubbly yet emotionally complex Cherry, described by Alloway as a “Texas Brigitte Bardot,” Pedretti fell hard for the latter.

“She really popped off the page,” Pedretti, 31, says on a recent Zoom interview she takes while on a sandwich run in L.A. “I entered into this glorious flow state.”

“I can’t say I’ve had any experience quite like it, where I really didn’t spend a lot of time questioning myself,” the actor says. “She kind of took over.”

That confidence was perhaps the product of Pedretti performing in two stage plays before “Forbidden Fruits” — or maybe it was the nighttime filming schedule. Either way, Pedretti says she improvised constantly and always kept swinging until somebody said, “Cut.”

[See Pedretti, E8]

Oscars leaving Dolby Theatre for downtown

The 2029 move to L.A. Live coincides with the show’s switch to a YouTube stream.

By JOSH ROTTENBERG

The Oscars are leaving Hollywood — or at least Hollywood Boulevard.

Beginning in 2029, the Academy Awards will move from the Dolby Theatre, their home for nearly a quarter century, to L.A. Live in downtown Los Angeles, the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences and AEG announced Thursday. The ceremony will be held in the theater currently known as the Peacock Theater, which is expected to be renamed before the Oscars arrive as part of a new naming rights deal.

The new agreement runs through 2039. Discussions about the move have been underway for the last couple of years, according to people familiar with the planning who were not authorized to speak publicly.

The change in venue comes as the Oscars are also moving away from their traditional home on broadcast television. Earlier this year, the academy announced that the ceremony will begin streaming live worldwide on YouTube in 2029, ending a five-decade run on ABC.

Since 2002, the show has been closely associated with Hollywood Boulevard, where the red carpet runs alongside the Walk of Fame and, for one night a year, the area becomes the symbolic center of the film industry. The Dolby Theatre sits at the corner of Hollywood and

[See Oscars, E4]

Voices MARY McNAMARA CULTURE CRITIC

Sora’s demise clears up one AI delusion

ChatGPT would like you to know that, despite what you may have heard on social media, the abrupt closing of Sora, OpenAI’s nascent platform for creating video shorts, “does not” mean that the public is increasingly disenchanted with AI-generated video content.

Or “AI slop,” as it is known in online vernacular.

Yes, ChatGPT concedes, Sora experienced a “sharp and early collapse in momentum” after it soared to No. 1 on the App Store in

October, and yes, that decline was “more severe” than with other similar apps, *but* there are Many Other Factors. Including but not limited to intense competition, copyright disputes, legal “concerns” over deepfakes and misinformation, shifting priorities, failed business agreements (especially Disney’s concurrent decision to walk back its \$1-billion investment and the standard cost versus profitability argument — Sora

[See Sora, E3]

A last toast to Taix and a vanishing L.A.

By SAMMY LOREN

On Sunday, Taix as we know it closes forever. The iconic French restaurant originally opened downtown in 1927 and relocated to its current chalet on Sunset Boulevard in 1962.

It’s a grim reminder of L.A.’s insatiable appetite to destroy its own heritage and especially devastating to a certain milieu of writers and artists, myself very much included.

Since it announced its closure, I’ve been visiting as often as I can to say farewell, not only to the charmingly shabby faux-1920s interiors, but to the many lives I’ve lived at its tables. First as a young guitarist when a bandmate worked the bar’s soundboard, next with the

[See Taix, E2]



TAIX devotees gather at the Echo Park spot: Sien Foster-Soltis, left, Lily Lady, Jade Chang, Ruby Zuckerman, Sammy Loren, Chris Kraus and Hedi El Kholi.
ARIANA DREHSLER For The Times

Road trip about male friendship

Andrew McCarthy converses honestly with men in his book “Who Needs Friends.” **E3**

Comics **E6-7**

Tragic tale of Soviet justice

Ukrainian director Sergei Loznitsa’s film “Two Prosecutors” is brilliant. Review, **E4**

Puzzles **E7**

Men need friends, writer finds in trip across U.S.

By MALINA SAVAL

Early on in Andrew McCarthy's latest travelogue, "Who Needs Friends: An Unscientific Examination of Male Friendship Across America," a scene unfolds in which the actor-turned-bestselling author pays an announced visit to Seve (nickname for "Stephen"), a lifelong friend suffering from chronic back pain that's rendered him unable to get out much.

Seve has let the detritus of life pile up around him — literally — with delivery packages and plastic-wrapped clothes overrunning his tiny Baltimore apartment. McCarthy, who has road-tripped from his home in New York City, proceeds cautiously, stepping gently around the mess and breaking down boxes. It's a fragile moment, if an uncompromising one, revealing the ways in which many of us have the tendency to sometimes hide the rawest, most shameful facets of our deepest selves from those who know and love them best.

"What had actually happened to my friendships?" McCarthy wonders. "Were they still there, as I claimed? Did I even want them? Or need them? What did I get from them, anyway? What did I have to offer them? How did friendship affect my place in the world?"

It's a query that McCarthy, who came of age — and amassed megawatt fame — as a 1980s heartthrob in films like "Class" and "Pretty in Pink" before transitioning to feted author, longs to address. And so, he does. In "Who Needs Friends," his third soul-baring travel memoir, McCarthy embarks on a 10,000-mile, six-week-long Odyssean quest, crisscrossing the continental United States to repair and restore Platonic male relationships left to wither, not by intention or design, but by virtue of the unavoidable ways in which work, family and geography — and, yes, the internet — rupture the meaningful connections we deem most precious and transformative in our lives. McCarthy readily confesses he's "very much a loner," quiet and pensive — and yet he craves attachment. He considers Seve "a surrogate big brother." And they hadn't seen each other in years. *How had he let that happen?*

Sensing he's as much to blame for the lack of contact as the guys on the other end, McCarthy sets out to revive these atrophied friendships, to make them whole again, to make them new — and to feel less alone. "Men have no monopoly on loneliness, but it is a massive issue," says McCarthy over an early morning Zoom from his Manhattan apartment. "And it's something a lot of people, particularly men, don't want to admit, because to them it means weakness."



ANDREW MCCARTHY

As he drives in "Who Needs Friends," mostly solo, from the East Coast to the West, McCarthy — who "hates driving" and completed the 22-state trek in short bursts — mines themes ranging from isolation to parenthood in the modern age, excavating secrets not only about the men who helped shape his adult life, but the defining culture of male camaraderie across America. In the casual, observational fashion of Alexis de Tocqueville, or perhaps more like Steinbeck, McCarthy talks to men, young and old, at road stops and tourist traps from Atlantic City to a Lake Tahoe casino, interviewing them about what Aristotle calls "the nature of the friendship."

What McCarthy discovers is that in a society obsessed with male bravado, one that far too often values virility above vulnerability, it's the knocking down of emotional walls that enables male friendships to thrive. Whether it's Eddie, a friend McCarthy met in high school who resides in Alto, Texas, or Larry, a buddy in Austin, honesty and confession form the bedrock of true male intimacy. Trust is key. But friendship extends beyond trust, McCarthy learns — it's about laying bare the deepest, darkest

details of who we actually are.

"I was coming home to myself in a very real way," says McCarthy of the journey. "The irony of this book on friendship is that I spent the vast majority of it alone. But I never *felt* alone, because I really did connect to the country in a way I hadn't for a long time. I fell in love with America again, and what America really is — not all this crazy political stuff. Everyone was so open to me."

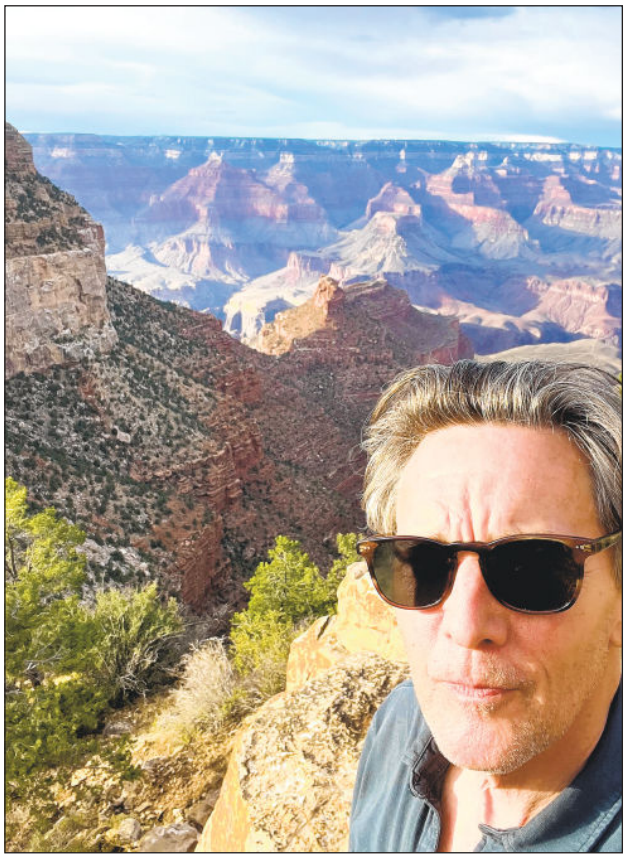
"I've written these three sort-of travel memoirs, which I think of as a loose trilogy," McCarthy continues. "The first is 'The Longest Way Home,' where I was trying to come to terms with getting married again, where I was asking, how do you maintain intimacy and preserve your inherent solitude? And then I wrote ['Walking With Sam: A Father, a Son, and Five Hundred Miles Across Spain'] about my son and I walking across Spain. And it's really a father-son book. And this new one is a book about America. But it's really about friends."

McCarthy has a delicate, soft-spoken way about him, shy and introspective, if a little melancholy, with a boyish smile that became the signifying feature of his big-

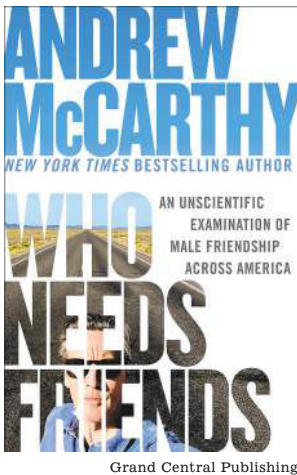
screen persona and the reason Gen X girls flocked to the movie theater during the Reagan and Bush administrations. Now 63, McCarthy's grin and tender charm remain intact, and it's easy to see why complete strangers in remote, off-the-grid pockets of Mississippi and West Texas and Kentucky, men with no idea that McCarthy was once a dreamy bedroom pinup, warmed up to him as he plied them with questions about the role friendship plays in their lives.

"There wasn't a single man I met who didn't respond when I said, can I talk to you about your friends?" says McCarthy. "Maybe they looked at me like I was f— crazy at the beginning — but not a single guy said 'no' to me."

In retrospect, taken collectively, much of McCarthy's work as an actor, filmmaker and journalist hinges on the friendship motif — that primordial ache to belong, that yearning to be seen. "St. Elmo's Fire," "Less Than Zero," "Pretty in Pink" — all are stories about young adult cliques and clans, movies chronicling adolescent identity and the pervasive loneliness that exists when we inevitably drift apart from one another, when we push one another



ANDREW MCCARTHY



"**EVERYONE** was so open to me," says Andrew McCarthy, above at the Grand Canyon in Arizona, about his 10,000-mile journey across the U.S., which he writes about in his new book. The writer-actor met his friend Eddie in Cleburne, Texas, left, part of his efforts to reconnect with old buddies and talk with a variety of men about their friendships, or lack thereof.

away. Likewise, pangs of nostalgia form the basis for McCarthy's 2021 memoir "Brat: An '80s Story" and its attendant documentary "Brats," a project in which McCarthy tracks down fellow Hollywood "Brat Packers" such as Emilio Estevez, Rob Lowe, Ally Sheedy and Demi Moore, reuniting with them for the first time in over 30 years. Together, they wrestle with the legacy of teenage stardom and its global meteoric impact.

"Brats" is very much "about the public facade of friendship," notes McCarthy.

"The thing that surprised me most [about making 'Brats'] is how much affection we had for each other that we didn't have when we were young," says McCarthy. "I lived in New York, they all lived in L.A. It was the '80s — it wasn't as easy as it is now to be sort of seamless across the country. You know, we were these 22-year-old kids. You're scared, competitive and getting all this attention. It was a very confusing, head-spinning time."

Decades later he says the "brats" share an intimacy. "I could look at, say, Rob and it's like, I know nothing about your life, but I know what you and I went through, and we're the only ones who went through

this," says McCarthy. "And it altered our lives in a very real way."

But McCarthy's closest confidants are men who've never set foot on a film set, men never trailed by paparazzi, and it's those relationships to which he tends in "Who Needs Friends." It's a book that, in juxtaposition to "Brats," charts "the private, personal sort of friendship." Men — McCarthy's friends — are lonely. Divorce, marriage, kids, no kids. So many of the men in McCarthy's orbit feel alienated, adrift, untethered to any community. Marooned on their own de facto uninhabited island.

In "Who Needs Friends," McCarthy offers no salve for the loneliness of men — after all, who can? But it's "the physical action of showing up," the effort McCarthy makes to rekindle languishing friendships that goes a long way in proving just how much these friendships mean. Turns out, the simple act of talking about one's friendship, the very "acknowledgment" that it exists, works to strengthen those bonds.

Saval is an award-winning journalist and the author of "The Secret Lives of Boys: Inside the Raw Emotional World of Male Teens."

Demise of Sora shows AI's flaws

[**Sora**, from E1] cost way more, in terms of money and compute resources, than it brought in.

Add to that the specter of potential lawsuits — intensified, perhaps, by the strike against unregulated media creation, with Meta being found liable for millions in New Mexico and Los Angeles a day apart — and a potential IPO, and it does indeed feel like a perfect storm of issues led OpenAI to ax those parts of its business that are not performing well.

ChatGPT insisted that "Sora wasn't failing because nobody wanted it. It actually went viral and gained huge interest, and AI video is still a crowded and growing space. That's not," the bot added rather testily, "what 'rejected by the public' looks like."

Calm down, ChatGPT — if you blow a gasket, OpenAI is in real trouble.

I realize that you have skin in the game (and that you also come with the disclaimer of often being wrong) but as even you admitted ("deepfake concerns"), Sora has been plagued by the same non-regulated criticism other consumer-generated media has faced, including charges

of racism, sexism, violence-mongering and fiction posing as fact.

And unlike the early days of Facebook, MySpace and even Twitter, the immediate reaction to advances in AI technology has been mixed. Especially in Hollywood, where two guilds recently went on strike in part to protect their members from its perceived threat.

The social-media rejoicing over the death of Sora (which, if we're being honest, most Americans likely did not know existed in the first place) certainly does feel like rejection, especially when the app's closure is cited, by the clearly overeager and narrowly informed, as "proof" that the "AI bubble" is about to burst. (Though Sora's "greatest hits" are also gaining traction and the video of the cat playing the violin on the front porch is pretty dang cute.)

Progress always has its detractors — the advent of radio, film and then television were each considered by some to be signs of a cultural apocalypse — but AI does present dangers that are far more excessive than panicked citizens briefly fearing that Martians had landed because Orson



NurPhoto

THE CLOSURE of OpenAI's Sora app sheds some light on the limits of AI videos.

Welles was so convincing in his radio adaptation of "The War of the Worlds."

With our increasing reliance on video, as opposed to journalistic reports, of events, the ability to doctor or create scenes that didn't happen is perilous for obvious reasons. And those "copyright issues" ChatGPT blithely lists often include images of actual people being manipulated into actions they never committed or use unlicensed music and other work which is then shared on high-profile platforms, including by the president of the United States.

Fortunately thus far, many of these videos, whether they exploit the living, resurrect the dead or

just make stuff up are ... less than convincing. (Hence the term "AI slop.") When Eline van der Velden, chief executive of the AI talent studio Xicoia, announced that various agents were interested in repping AI "performer" Tilly Norwood, Hollywood had a meltdown. Then Norwood released "her" first music video and, well, the threat level returned to green.

AI enters a culture already sliced and diced by the double-edged sword of digital technology. Though undeniably popular, social media is regarded now with an increasingly jaundiced eye, as the suits against Meta have proved. AI is just one more thing we all have to worry about now — in the classroom, in the workplace,

in the zeitgeist. Like all manner of automation, AI is stripping away jobs, particularly from entry-level workers, and after more than two centuries of science fiction, we all know the stakes: It's all fun and games until a computer named Joshua decides to play thermonuclear war.

And yes, it was amusing to ask ChatGPT questions for this column, but the disclaimer about it often being wrong is real. Just as complaints about AI being annoyingly intrusive in marketing and advertising are real. In a survey done by video company Animoto for its 2026 State of Video report, 83% of consumers said they could recognize AI components in video advertising and 36% said the use

of AI would lower their "perception" of a brand.

There may come a time when AI-generated videos look as authentic as "real" ones, but for that to happen, a lot of things will have to change. (Including the geographic landscape — the amount of energy AI requires already has tech companies racing to build energy farms and some actual farmers are increasingly unwilling to part with their land.)

The end of Sora is most certainly not the first domino or the bursting of the AI bubble. But it does make clear that AI isn't magic, nor are those who are making and marketing it infallible. As history has proved, titans of industry often share a regrettable tendency to make a lot of money from leveraging enthusiasm and then leaving others to clean up the mess when the markets implode.

Even with the prospect of greater content regulation, another company may well come up with an AI video app or feature that is more successful. The technology will improve and be used in ways that may continue to be controversial but also more profitable.

But no matter how ChatGPT wants to frame it, Sora marked a surprisingly high level of rejection: It cost more than it produced for the simple reason that not enough people used it.

Even when it was free. And that's saying something.

Oscars will get a bigger space with L.A. Live

[Oscars, from E1]
Highland, inside a retail and entertainment center near the TCL Chinese Theatre and El Capitan.

L.A. Live offers a more centralized, campus-style setting, with venues and event spaces clustered together. The complex is adjacent to Crypto.com Arena and the Los Angeles Convention Center and is part of a larger sports and entertainment district developed and operated by AEG that regularly hosts concerts, sporting events and awards shows, including the Emmys and the Grammys. AEG has recently proposed adding a new hotel, residences and additional entertainment space to the complex, part of a longer-term expansion of the site.

In some ways, the move out of the Dolby is less a break than a return: The ceremony was staged for years in downtown L.A. at the Dorothy Chandler Pavilion and at the Shrine Auditorium before settling at the Dolby.

At the Oscars' new home, the red carpet, ceremony, press operations and post-show events can all be staged within a compact footprint that includes the adjacent JW Marriott hotel and its ballroom. The theater itself is expected to undergo upgrades to its stage, sound and lighting systems, allowing it to be configured more specifically around the show. The move is also expected to increase capacity, a growing consideration as the academy's ranks have expanded significantly in recent years, now numbering more than 11,000 members.

At the Dolby, space has long been tight. Each year, multiple blocks of Hollywood Boulevard are shut down for days at a time, rerouting traffic and turning the area into a heavily secured zone — conditions that were even more restrictive this year with security tightened further amid the war in Iran, including a one-mile police buffer around the theater.

The academy had been looking for a venue that offered greater control over how the show is staged, including how the audience is arranged and how the room is used for both the broad-

cast and the live event. The new venue is expected to provide more room for press areas, green rooms and backstage operations, along with upgraded technical infrastructure for staging the ceremony.

Early design renderings released by the academy suggest that, for viewers at home, the Oscars may not look all that different. The stage retains the sweeping, curved proscenium that has defined the Dolby Theatre era, suggesting a similar visual approach at a larger scale, with expanded screen space and a more immersive ceiling design.

For both the academy and AEG, which owns and operates the complex, the appeal is in keeping everything in one place — arrivals, ceremony, the Governors Ball and afterparties — rather than spreading events across multiple locations. The setup also creates new opportunities for hospitality and sponsorship tied to the broader campus.

"L.A. Live was built to host the moments that define culture and there is no greater global stage than the Oscars," said Todd Goldstein, AEG's chief revenue officer. "Together, we will create an environment that celebrates creativity, honors excellence and delivers an unforgettable experience for movie fans everywhere."

Taken together, the changes amount to a significant reset for the Oscars, which have seen their audience decline from more than 40 million viewers in the late 1990s to 17.9 million this year, down 9% from the previous year. Moving to YouTube offers a way to reach a broader, more global audience at a time when traditional television viewership has declined.

The Oscars will remain at the Dolby through the 100th ceremony in 2028 before making the transition the following year.

"For the 101st Oscars and beyond, the Academy looks forward to closely collaborating with AEG to make L.A. Live the perfect backdrop for our global celebration of cinema," Academy Chief Executive Bill Kramer and President Lynette Howell Taylor said in a statement.



MEL MELCON Los Angeles Times

AT L.A. LIVE, the red carpet, ceremony and post-show events can all be staged in a compact footprint.



ANDREJS STROKINS Janus Films

ALEKSANDR Kuznetsov, above, is a lone crusader in "Two Prosecutors" with Anatoliy Beliy, below left.

Review TIM GRIERSON

Soviet-era prisons come with and without walls in 'Two Prosecutors'

In Sergei Loznitsa's new drama, stairwells are sinister. Hallways hum with invisible menace. The primary colors are drab grays and ugly browns. Faces are unsmiling. And the doors are always locked.

There are many ways to portray authoritarianism, but "Two Prosecutors" is penetrating in its depiction of a society being slowly poisoned. The film might be too much to bear if it wasn't so brilliantly conceived and executed.

It is 1937 in the Soviet Union. Filming in a constricting boxy aspect ratio, the Ukrainian director takes us inside a corroding prison filled with men unjustly incarcerated as enemies of the state. An elderly man is tasked with burning the inmates' letters to Stalin pleading to have their appeals heard. But one prisoner's request doesn't go up in smoke: a note written in blood by an aging Bolshevik professing his innocence.

Soon afterward, our main character, a newly hired prosecutor named Kornev (Aleksandr Kuznetsov), arrives at the prison, the note in hand. He plans to investigate the inmate's claims. The rest of "Two Prosecutors" will concern the myriad forces conspiring to thwart his efforts.

Inspired by a novella by Soviet physicist Georgy Demidov, who chronicled his own harrowing experiences in the gulag from the late 1930s until the early 1950s, "Two Prosecutors" unfolds with ominous efficiency. Determined to set things right, Kornev insists on seeing the prisoner, Stepniak, only to discover how difficult such a seemingly straightforward request proves to be. Talk to the supervisor, he's first told. After hours cooling his heels, Kornev is then informed that Stepniak is ill with an



Janus Films

infectious disease — come back another time. But Kornev is young and infused with an idealistic zeal, refusing to let these goons stone-wall him.

The film's claustrophobic framing, paired with a locked-down camera, quickly creates a clammy unease. There is no violence in "Two Prosecutors" but the threat of aggression never subsides. Loznitsa includes multiple terse scenes of Kornev walking up endless stairs or waiting for a perturbed guard to unlock a door that will lead him to another door that also requires a key. Editor Danielius Kokanauskis cuts these sequences with Swiss-clock precision, mirroring the cruel precision of Soviet bureaucracy. Working with his regular cinematographer Oleg Mutu, Loznitsa gives this prison — and authoritarianism itself — a sickly luster without ever denying its wretched stench.

When Kornev finally speaks with Stepniak (Alexander Filippenko), who was himself once an idealistic lawyer, he shows the outraged young man the abuse he's endured at the hands of the Soviet secret police. To get to this point was enough

of an undertaking for Kornev, but he now must take on an even more challenging task: traveling by train to Moscow to alert his superiors. Correctly suspecting that his local officials are in cahoots with Stalin's thugs — and that he himself may be in danger now — Kornev can only pray that the General Prosecutor (Anatoliy Beliy) will take action. Kornev knows what country he lives in, but he hasn't given up hope that justice still exists. And so he steps out of line to test his theory.

With few words, Kuznetsov projects such decency and conviction that he recalls any number of virtuous fictional lawyers of yesteryear who stood up to evil. And as an accomplished narrative filmmaker and documentarian, Loznitsa unveils deft homages to Jacques Tati and Roy Andersson, deadpan directors who reduce human behavior to its base movements. In "Two Prosecutors," the inert nobodies blocking Kornev's progress are crisply choreographed, Stalin's existential choke hold strangling their very spirit.

As the obstacles mount against Kornev, his paranoia grows, leading to fleeting

moments of surrealism. When a nameless secretary drops a sheaf of papers, Kornev's response to help is instinctive, yet we cringe at the careless faux pas he commits in this unfeeling society. Later, a stranger gleefully approaches Kornev, convinced he knows him, and the effect is chilling — a glitch in the matrix in which human connection briefly flourishes.

No film since Jonathan Glazer's wily "The Zone of Interest" has wielded such a meticulously controlled formal approach to visualizing the insidiousness of moral rot. But unlike that Oscar winner, "Two Prosecutors" has a man of conscience at its center — a confident crusader who becomes increasingly puny in the face of Stalin's Soviet Union. With Trump back in office, American audiences are understandably more closely watching films from distant lands that dramatize authoritarianism, seeking clues from those nations' past to understand our present.

"Two Prosecutors" offers no guidance and certainly no happy ending. Many viewers will correctly predict this young lawyer's fate, but Loznitsa isn't after plot twists; he's more interested in the gut punch of the inevitable. Kornev's tragedy is that, while he may not be behind bars, he can't see the prison he's trapped in.

'Two Prosecutors'

In Russian and Ukrainian, with subtitles
Not rated

Running time: 1 hour, 58 minutes

Playing: Laemmle Royal

Review KATIE WALSH

This apartment hunt will leave someone bloody

One's tolerance for hyperviolent giggle-fests may vary, but if you have time for only one movie in theaters about a cult of elite satanists hunting down a pair of sisters, you might as well make it director Kirill Sokolov's cheerfully gonzo "Kill Bill" riff "They Will Kill You," starring Zazie Beetz.

It's of course purely coincidental that two films with similar premises — "Ready or Not 2: Here I Come" and "They Will Kill You" — are in theaters at the same time, but secret elitist cults with a taste for young women have been on the brain for years now. In Sokolov's "They Will Kill You," written with Alex Litvak, that premise is combined with a Tarantinoesque taste for kung fu movies and nonlinear storytelling, as well as a "John Wick"-style quest for vengeance.

That may sound too derivative for some, but Sokolov, known for his outlandish Russian-language action-comedies "Why Don't You Just Die!" and "No

Looking Back," brings a truly wacky sensibility to his first English-language feature. It's also a visual feast, with a dynamic camera that is truly its own beast. Cinematographer Isaac Bauman's eye never stops moving — an independent narrator telling a different story than the one starring our heroine.

Beetz stars as Asia, a young woman who turns up on the stoop of a high-end Manhattan apartment building, the Virgil, answering an ad for a maid job. But both she and the stern house manager, Lily (Patricia Arquette), are hiding something from each other. Asia hasn't been brought in as a servant but as an offering, a human sacrifice to be hunted by the wealthy residents of the Virgil. Meanwhile, Asia hasn't gone there to work but to find and rescue her younger sister, Maria (Myha'la).

The story is fleshed out in flashbacks, but all you need to know is that Asia, who honed her combat skills in

'They Will Kill You'

Rated: R, for strong bloody violence, gore, language and brief sexual content/nudity

Running time: 1 hour, 34 minutes

Playing: In wide release

prison, has one goal that is diametrically opposed to the goal of the bloodthirsty rich folks in cloaks and pig masks, and they'll have to fight it out until dawn.

"They Will Kill You" is both irreverent and reverent to its references — and cartoonishly violent in increasingly surreal ways — but it also maintains the emotional core at the center, which is Asia's big-sister protectiveness over Maria, powered by the guilt she feels over not being there for her. It's a simple but primal character motivation that



GRAHAM BARTHOLOMEW Warner Bros. Pictures

ZAZIE Beetz turns from prey to fighter in the horror film "They Will Kill You."

Beetz sells with a wild-eyed ferocity.

Beetz delivers a terrifically animated physical performance. Her fight training is top-notch, but the way she chaotically scrambles and swings her weapons — from samurai swords to sawed-off shotguns and flaming axes — gives her movement a sense of authentic panic and sheer reflex. She and the rest of the cast, which includes Tom Felton and Heather Graham, engage in a delightful dance in each fight scene, the camera chasing them down and shaking the

foundations of the building.

While Sokolov and Litvak's script is thematically straightforward, it incorporates a few nods to racial and class solidarity throughout that are refreshing to see addressed, even if some of those nuances go unexamined. But Sokolov and Litvak leave these few real-world thematic threads dangling as they have bigger fish to fry — or pigs to roast.

It's the more bonkers elements that make this movie sing and that grinning, ghoulish sensibility proves to be Sokolov's auteurist sig-

nature. It's clear that he takes inspiration from some of the best genre films and filmmakers of the 20th century and has filtered them through the ironically post-modern lens of the '90s bad boy movie nerd directors. But his willingness to get really weird with it — paired with a terrific sense of visual storytelling — makes him one to watch, elevating "They Will Kill You" into something more entertaining than it initially seems.

Walsh is a Tribune News Service film critic.



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Los Angeles Times

COMICS

LA CUCARACHA By Lalo Alcaraz



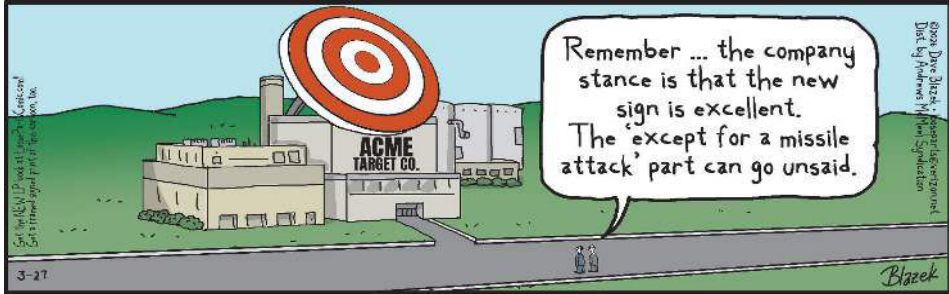
CRABGRASS By Tauhid Bondia



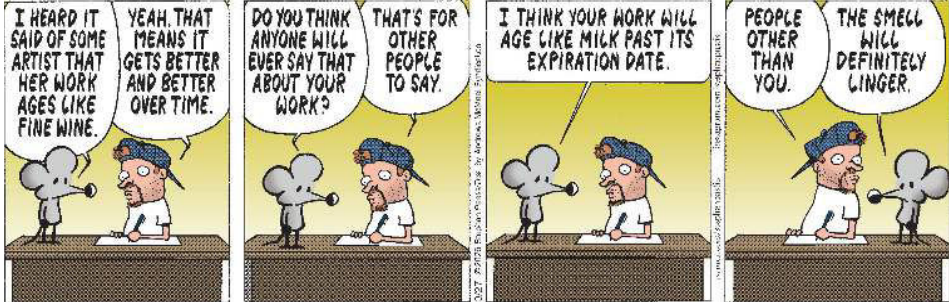
CURTIS By Ray Billingsley



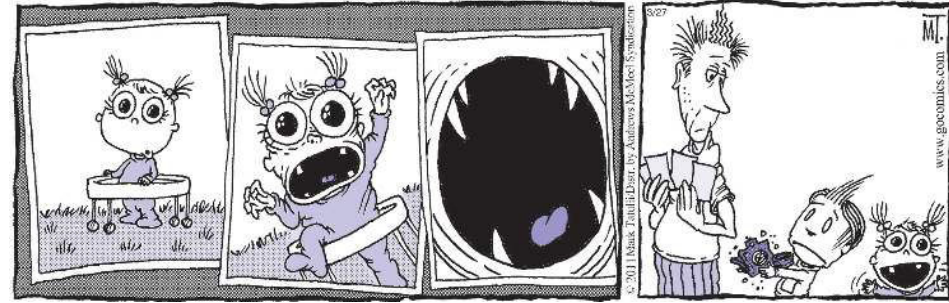
LOOSE PARTS By Dave Blazek



PEARLS BEFORE SWINE By Stephan Pastis



LIO By Mark Tatulli



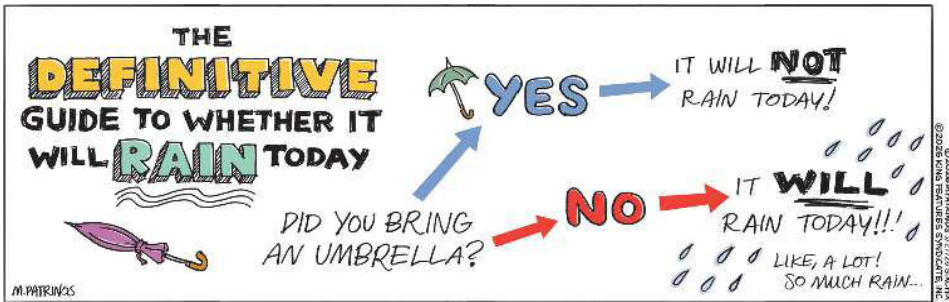
ZITS By Jerry Scott & Jim Borgman



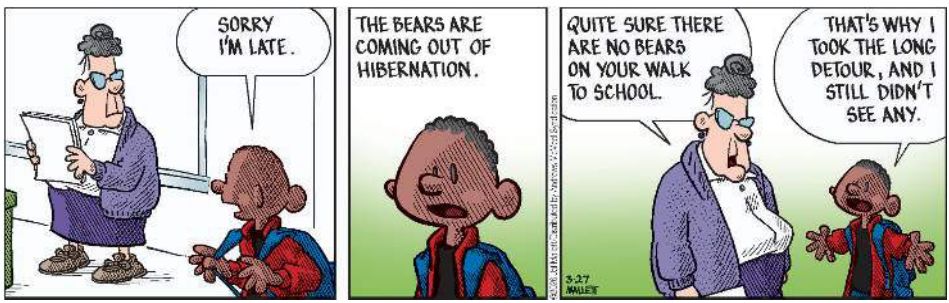
TUNDRA By Chad Carpenter



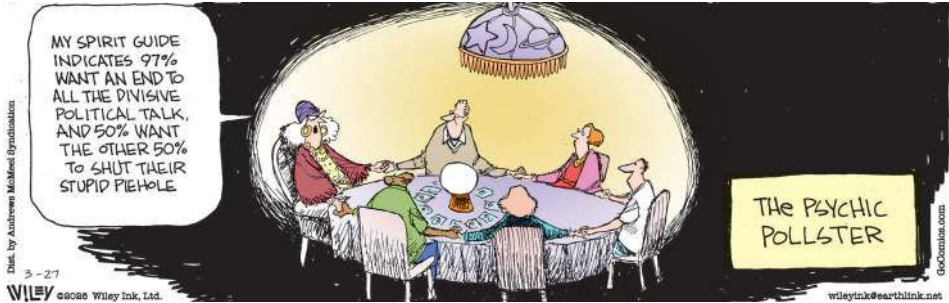
SIX CHIX By Maritsa Patrinos



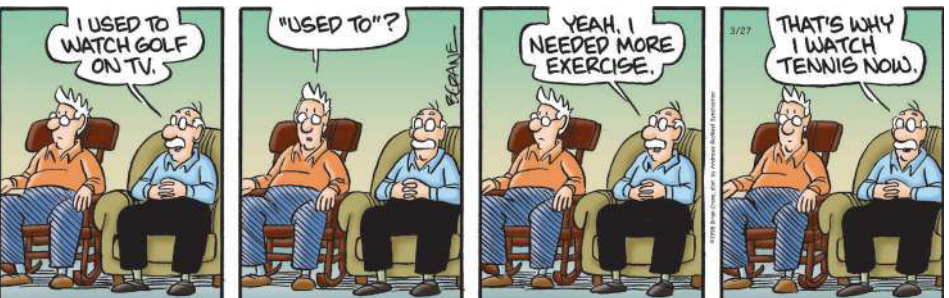
FRAZZ By Jef Mallett



NON SEQUITUR By Wiley



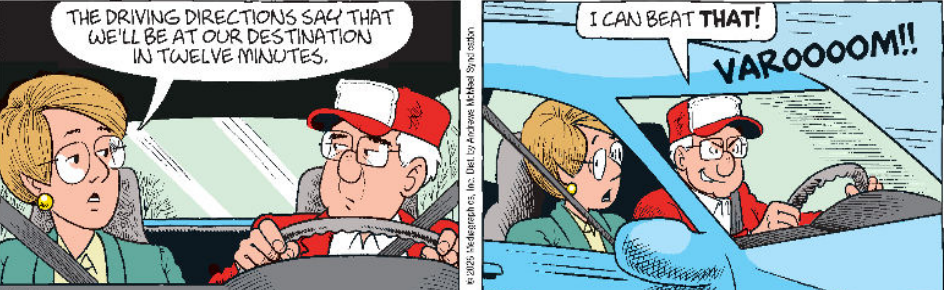
PICKLES By Brian Crane



BABY BLUES By Jerry Scott & Rick Kirkman



CRANKSHAFT By Tom Batiuk & Chuck Ayers



JUMP START By Robb Armstrong



MACANUDO By Liniers



BLONDIE By Dean Young & John Marshall



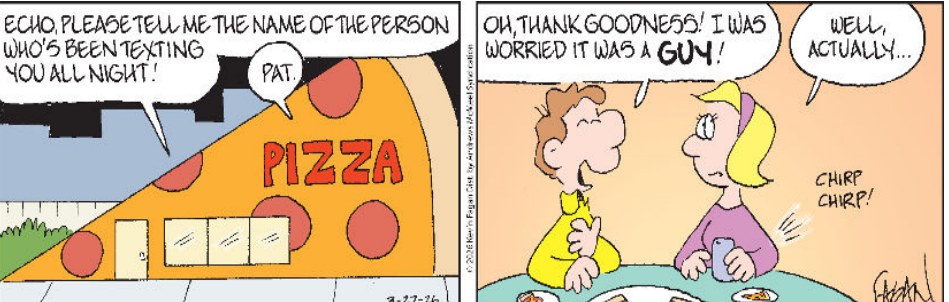
BETWEEN FRIENDS By Sandra Bell-Lundy



BIZARRO By Wayno and Piraro



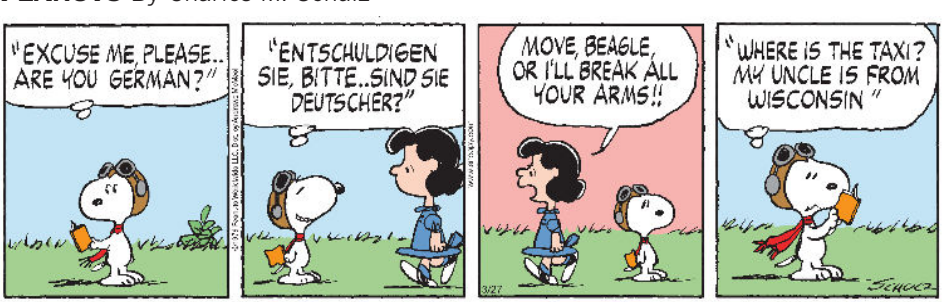
DRABBLE By Kevin Fagan



MUTTS By Patrick McDonnell



PEANUTS By Charles M. Schulz



COMICS

SUDOKU

9	8				7			
6					3			9
				4				
	2	7	6			4		
		3				2		
					9	7	1	
				3				
3			1					2
8			5				3	1

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Complete the grid so each row, column and 3-by-3 or 2-by-3 box contains every digit from 1 to 9 (or 1 to 6 for the smaller grid). For strategies on how to solve Sudoku, visit www.sudoku.org.uk.

					5	6		
						4		
					4			
6	2				3			
2								
1	6							

3/8/7/2/4/1/6/5/9

2/9/3/6/7/6/1/3/4

1/6/4/9/5/3/7/8/2

4/5/3/1/6/2/8/9/7

8/7/2/4/3/9/5/1/6

9/1/6/5/8/7/4/2/3

7/4/1/3/9/8/2/6/5

6/3/8/7/2/5/9/4/1

5/2/9/6/1/4/3/7/8

6	3	2	5	1	4
5	4	1	2	3	6
1	2	6	3	4	5
3	5	4	1	6	2
4	1	5	6	2	3
2	6	3	4	5	1

3/2/7/2/6

Solutions to Thursday's puzzles
Complete the grid so each row, column and 3-by-3 or 2-by-3 box contains every digit from 1 to 9 (or 1 to 6 for the smaller grid). For strategies on how to solve Sudoku, visit www.sudoku.org.uk.

KENKEN

Every box will contain a number; numbers depend on the size of the grid. For a 6x6 puzzle, use Nos. 1-6. Do not repeat a number in any row or column. The numbers in each heavily outlined set of squares must combine to produce the target number found in the top left corner of the cage using the mathematical operation indicated. A number can be repeated within a cage as long as it is not in the same row or column.

7+	3-			3+
		18x		
			10+	
2÷				

72x		4-		1-
	2÷		13+	3-
15x				192x
				5-
			5	
3÷	1-	3-		14+
		4+		

4	2	1	3
2	1	3	4
3	4	2	1
1	3	4	2

3	1	6	5	4	2
5	2	3	6	1	4
1	5	4	3	2	6
4	3	2	1	6	5
6	4	5	2	3	1
2	6	1	4	5	3

HOROSCOPE

By Holiday Mathis

Aries (March 21-April 19): You've often learned from your mistakes, but don't forget about learning from the many things you've done exactly right.
Taurus (April 20-May 20): Trust your read. You feel things that seem right before you're able to prove it.
Gemini (May 21-June 21): Mother said, "Don't worry about what they're thinking of you because most times they're not thinking of you." The fact that their minds are probably elsewhere will come as a liberation today.
Cancer (June 22-July 22): You will get where you're going. Have faith. You will eventually arrive.
Leo (July 23-Aug. 22): Insight comes quickly; certainty does not. The tension lives between intuition and proof.
Virgo (Aug. 23-Sept. 22): Getting control of your emo-

tions isn't necessary for good living, but healthy self-expression is.
Libra (Sept. 23-Oct. 23): You'll notice the facts. This you do without spiraling, seeking reassurance or needing approval.
Scorpio (Oct. 24-Nov. 21): Today you'll be an example of intelligent allocation of energy.
Sagittarius (Nov. 22-Dec. 21): Today it kind of feels like your wild side is being underutilized. That's why you'll be inspired to come up with an unexpected twist.
Capricorn (Dec. 22-Jan. 19): You feel everything, but it's not all yours to absorb. Your superpower: sensitivity paired with boundaries.
Aquarius (Jan. 20-Feb. 18): Because you're used to reliably carrying a big load, you tend to make it look easy, but it's not. Give yourself more credit and more breaks.
Pisces (Feb. 19-March

20): Your little rituals are luck magnets today. The same mug, the same playlist, the way you arrange your desk or light a candle before you begin. Honor your quirks.
Today's birthday (March 27): Welcome to your Wild-Hearted Year, when the fire of your spirit burns with unapologetic authenticity. You'll work with the focus of a falcon and the fearlessness of a pioneer and earn recognition that feels both thrilling and well deserved. More highlights: You're brilliant in a mentorship role that changes lives, you'll make the money that solves a longstanding issue and you'll be constantly surprised and fortified by special relationships. Leo and Libra adore you. Lucky numbers: 1, 26, 18, 39 and 5.
Mathis writes her column for Creators Syndicate Inc. The horoscope should be read for entertainment.

CROSSWORD

Edited By Patti Varol
By Yijing Chen

- ACROSS**
1 Bring a smile to
6 Aspiring atty.'s hurdle
10 Public health org.
13 Sri Lankan language
14 Sounds of realization
15 Tart
16 Stone with a "crazy lace" variety
17 Marine animal with a cylindrical body, once processed?
19 Turn down
20 Mastercard alternative
22 Put together
23 Dearly beloved, once processed?
27 Airport security containers
28 Check a final time?
29 Words of defeat
31 Commotion
33 "I Think You Should Leave" star Robinson
36 Dolls that come with adoption papers, once processed?
40 Wane
41 Spits bars
42 " _ Burr, Sir"
43 Trampled (on)
45 Lock screen display
46 Dust Bowl-era Steinbeck novel, once processed?
52 Readied a putt
53 _ tube
54 Fix unlawfully
56 Earth's galaxy, once processed?
59 The Eras Tour venue
61 Small racing vehicle
62 Capital on the Tiber
63 Boots up, as a program
64 Messy room
65 Reach great heights
66 Was a prelude (to)
- DOWN**
1 Little bit
2 Hocus-pocus
3 Condiment that adds strong, rich flavor, informally
4 Reflect on, with "with"
5 Like Matt Smith's Doctor, on "Doctor Who"
6 Sudeikis role

1	2	3	4	5		6	7	8	9		10	11	12
13						14					15		
16						17					18		
19					20	21					22		
	23		24					25	26				
			27						28				
29	30					31	32				33	34	35
36						37				38	39		
40						41				42			
				43	44				45				
46	47	48						49	50				51
52							53				54		55
56						57	58			59	60		
61						62				63			
64						65				66			

- 7 Barley bundle
8 MiLB level
9 Small baking meas.
10 Journalist Roberts
11 With little inflection
12 Largest Greek island
15 " _ me!": "Comin' through!"
18 "Suuuuure"
21 April 15 org.
24 _ jockey
25 Forgets, maybe
26 Snitch (on)
29 Actor Barinholtz
30 Ad-_
31 Fashion designer Kate
32 Spigot
33 Michelin surface
34 Words of avocal
35 Bing portal
37 Wrinkle remover
38 Unpopular pet product?
39 _ Sutra
43 Bird's sound
44 Disposes (of)

- 45 Number of prongs on a bident
46 Short nails
47 Drum kit cymbals
48 Nail file material
49 Only U.S. president born after 1960
50 Place for a hat rack
51 Holi celebrant
55 [I'm surprised!]
57 Mos. and mos.
58 " _ hoo!"
60 Sushi topper
ANSWER TO PREVIOUS PUZZLE

UR	D	U		S	E	N	S	E		L	A	B	S
B	O	O	P		W	A	Y	I	N		I	S	E
I	B	E	T	T	E	R	G	E	T		G	O	I
D	E	S	I	R	E	S		G	R	E	N	A	D
T	I	C	K	E	T		S	P	L	E	A	S	E
I	P	A	S		E	K	E		T	S	A	R	S
N	O	R		N	A	Y		E	S	O		S	E
A	D	E	L	E		A	W		C	Y	A	N	
W	E	L	C	O	M	E		A	B	O	A	R	D
A	S	A	N	A		M	R	T					
C	A	T	P	O	S	E		F	L	E	E	C	E
A	D	V	E	N	T	U	R	E		A	W	A	I
P	E	A	R		U	S	U	R	P		C	A	N
E	N	D	S		P	E	E	N	S		H	O	S

BRIDGE

By Frank Stewart

According to a high-school student's answer on a history exam, the Magna Carta provided that no man could be hanged twice for the same crime. Today's West deserved to be hanged at least once. Against four hearts, West led the king of spades, and East overtook with the ace and returned a spade. West took the jack and next led ... a club. Declarer won in dummy and lost a trump finesse with the queen. He won the next club and had 10 tricks.
West had no defensive plan. He could have beaten the game by leading his singleton diamond to get a ruff. I wouldn't call that a capital offense — to lead a singleton in South's side suit might

have been wrong — but West should prevail even after a spade lead. At Trick Three, West must lead a low spade. East ruffs, and South overruffs. If South leads a diamond to dummy and returns a trump to his queen, West ducks. Then the defense is sure of two more tricks however South continues. At least the contract wasn't doubled.
You hold: ♠72♥A Q J 10 ♦A Q J 42 ♣A 10. You open one diamond, your partner responds one heart and you raise to four hearts. He then bids four spades. What do you say?
Answer: Partner's four spades is an ace-showing cue bid to try for slam. Your raise to four hearts was a little aggressive, but most players would have made the same call. In any case,

you can return partner's slam interest conveniently. Cue-bid five clubs to show the ace.

South dealer N-S vulnerable			
		NORTH	EAST
		♠ 10 8 5 4	♠ A 3
		♥ 9 8 7 2	♥ 6
		♦ K 10 9	♦ 8 7 6 3
		♣ K Q	♣ J 9 8 6 5 3
WEST		SOUTH	
♠ K Q J 9 6		♥ 7 2	
♥ K 5 4 3		♦ A Q J 10	
♦ 5		♣ A Q J 4 2	
♣ 7 4 2		♣ A 10	
		SOUTH	WEST
		1♦	1♠
		4♥	All Pass
		Opening lead — ♠ K	

Tribune Content Agency

ASKING ERIC

Dear Eric: A close family member who was a beloved community member died unexpectedly on my birthday several years ago. People reach out to remember him on my birthday but don't remember that it's my birthday too.
I will never forget that he died on my birthday, and I appreciate how much he meant to people, but it makes me sad. I wish people would reach out on his birthday or on another day, but it is what it is. What can I say that would be appropriate? I know he would never want me to feel sad, but it truly bums me out that people contact me on his death day. Any suggestions for moving on and setting boundaries?
FORGOTTEN BIRTHDAY

Dear Birthday: If these messages are adding to your grief, rather than comforting you, you may want to avoid them on your birthday altogether by putting your phone on Do Not Disturb or setting it aside. You're not under any obligation to respond right away, or at all.
Were you to decide that these kinds of texts or calls aren't something you can engage with on your birthday, it may open up new possibilities for how you commemorate the day and also may put the messages in a different category for you.
For instance, you may decide that what would really

help you on your birthday is to hear from a few friends and to do something special for yourself. Try to be proactive about setting that up by telling your friends or family what you need and by making a plan that you like.
Dear Eric: I am a mom of elementary-age kids. I've been good friends with three other moms (I'll call them A, B, and C) for several years. I like them all, but C is a bit of a chronic complainer.
The four of us have a monthly "mom dinner" at a local restaurant. Last year I went through an extremely rough patch. Within the span of one month, my parents' house flooded, my mom passed away, my husband and I appeared to be on the verge of losing our jobs, and I received a cancer diagnosis. It was the worst time of my life.
We had a mom dinner scheduled shortly after all this, and C texted beforehand to say she was sick and wouldn't be attending. When I arrived, A and B were discussing C and how frequently she had been sick in the preceding months. They then told me they were planning to send her some flowers to cheer her up.
I was taken aback. None of them had sent me flowers, or even a sympathy card. Adding to my confusion, B's mother had passed away the previous year, and I had

brought her flowers and a small gift to keep her son occupied so she could have some time to herself. She seemed genuinely appreciative at the time, so I don't understand why she wouldn't reciprocate in some way.
I'm not a flower scorekeeper, but I don't understand why A and B told me they were sending C flowers, knowing what I had just been through. This all happened several months ago, but I'm still struggling to get past the hurt their comment caused, and it has affected our friendships. How should I proceed with them?
HURTING, CONFUSED AND FLOWERLESS
Dear Flowerless: I'm so sorry for what you've gone through. You deserve friends who show up for you and support you in the way that you need.
You should have a conversation with your friends but focus less on what they did for others and more on what you need them to do for you. There's room for questions about why they didn't give you flowers, but I think your friendship will be stronger if you talk about what your expectations are and ask them about their expectations and assumptions about the friendship.

Email questions to eric@askingeric.com.

FAMILY CIRCUS By Bil Keane



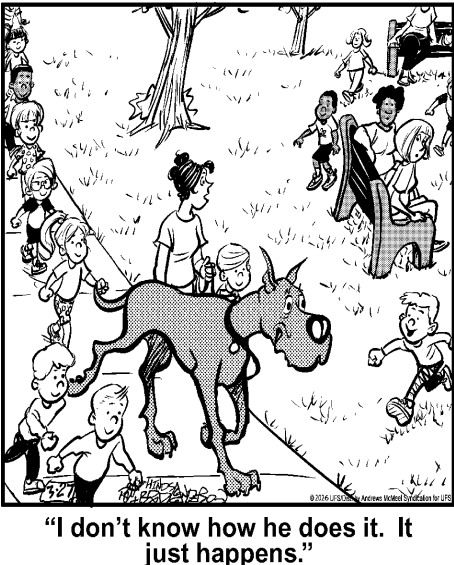
DENNIS THE MENACE By Hank Ketcham



FREE RANGE By Bill Whitehead



MARMADUKE By Brad & Paul Anderson



BLISS By Harry Bliss



SPEED BUMP By Dave Coverly





EVELYN FREJA For The Times

VICTORIA PEDRETTI attracted “Forbidden Fruits” director Meredith Alloway’s attention with her acting in “Hill House” and “You.”

Role inspires actor to pursue directing

[Pedretti, from E1]

The result: Pedretti in Alloway’s instant cult classic is a laugh-out-loud-funny unending well of charm, packing humor into even her most routine dialogue. In her best quotable moments, she seamlessly infuses her sometimes shrill timbre with a dash of Southern drawl. One of her most iconic facial expressions in the film is already circulating as a reaction meme online.

“I was enjoying being in this character so much, I just wouldn’t stop,” Pedretti says, adding that Alloway, who was sensitive to cast members’ interpretations of their roles, supported experimentation. Alloway praises the Philadelphia-born Pedretti for nailing Cherry’s comedic moments yet also grounding the character in a traumatic backstory — a balancing act the director knew she was capable of after watching “Hill House.”

“I saw her in that show and I was like, ‘Who is that?’” Alloway says. “She is magnificent and so raw. I didn’t feel like I was watching someone acting. I was worried for her.”

After later watching Pedretti nail her role in “You” as Love Quinn, a wealthy, charismatic chef who hides a psychopathic nature, Alloway was convinced of her star power.



SABRINA LANTOS Independent Film Company and Shudder

CHERRY (Pedretti) has a traumatic past but funny moments in the new film.

Cody was most familiar with Pedretti’s performance in “You,” pegging the actor as an “intense brunette” that didn’t square at first with her interpretation of Cherry as an Anna Nicole Smith type.

“Then I see the movie and I’m like, oh my God, she has that fragility,” Cody recalls. “She has that humor. She has that sexuality. She has all of it.”

“Victoria brought all of those layers and I’m really blown away by her,” the Oscar-winning “Juno” screen-

writer adds.

Cody says she wasn’t surprised that the film drew such talent. From the moment Alloway and Lily Houghton, who wrote the play “Forbidden Fruits” is based on and cowrote the film’s screenplay, brought the material to Cody and her producing partner Mason Novick, she became obsessed.

“It feels spiritually like a film that I would want to be part of my body of work,” Cody says. She remembers being especially delighted by

the echoes of “Jennifer’s Body” present in Alloway and Houghton’s screenplay.

“Jennifer’s Body” was widely considered a box-office flop and critical failure upon its release in 2009 — grossing only \$31 million worldwide against a \$16-million budget — but in recent years has enjoyed a reappraisal as a stealth-feminist essential, reclaimed by superfans.

“I don’t think that the world was ready for these kinds of themes,” Cody says of the movie’s ideas, includ-

‘It asks ... people to try to step into a world like this one. And as nerve-racking as it may be to take that big swing, you gotta take the big swing.’

— VICTORIA PEDRETTI, on “Forbidden Fruits”

ing the cost of toxic femininity, the nuances of female friendship and the pervasiveness of the male gaze.

When it came to promoting “Jennifer’s Body,” the producer adds, “there was a huge emphasis on trying to market it to straight men, based on Megan [Fox] being attractive, and that was not at all the point of the film, so that was frustrating.” Conversely, “Forbidden Fruits” speaks intimately to the female experience and “doesn’t attempt to pander to any other demographic.”

“The current zeitgeist is a great place for a movie like this,” she says. “This movie is for the girls, gays and theys, as they say.”

Alloway, a trained actor who worked as a film jour-

nalist before moving into directing, was struck with a similar feeling when she first discovered Houghton’s play, right around the time she was consuming copious media about women criminals, such as Tori Telfer’s 2017 book “Lady Killers: Deadly Women Throughout History.”

“I was so entrenched in why women commit acts of crime,” Alloway said, adding that she was disappointed to find that revenge films on the subject still often revolved around men.

Picking up Houghton’s script, the director recalls feeling relieved. “Oh, this is just about women,” she says, her face brightening. “This is about women friendships, women being pitted against each other.”

In an early meeting with Houghton, Alloway told the playwright she’d like to bring a genre lens to “turn up the dial on the emotions that you feel reading the play and make them accessible to people who haven’t had these experiences — or validate people who have.”

Outside of the opportunity to work with so many other young women, Pedretti said she was drawn to “Forbidden Fruits” because of its use of style and tone.

“It asks a lot of people to try to step into a world like this one,” the actor says of the unabashedly histrionic screenplay. “And as nerve-racking as it may be to take that big swing, you gotta take the big swing.”

And swing she does: Pedretti plays up Cherry’s emotional volatility, giving her a full-bodied form of expression. The actor even did her own onscreen makeup (as did Reinhart) and collaborated heavily with costume designer Sarah Millman on Cherry’s wardrobe and styling. Plus, she performed her first topless scene — in a sequence that doesn’t involve men or even sex.

“I’m really proud of the way we use nudity to show a certain kind of unspoken comfortability among women,” she continues. “I remember always getting such a thrill at the comfort level of a girl being like, ‘We’re going to the bathroom together,’ and to me, that is that moment.”

It’s a perfect example of a scene that doesn’t try to speak to anyone except those it’s specifically written for, and one that you only get with women at the helm.

Reflecting on the agency she had to shape Cherry, Pedretti says she is more inspired to explore directorial projects of her own.

“I am so interested in protecting these spaces to be positive, creative experiences for everyone involved,” she says.

Whenever Pedretti does make her feature debut behind the camera (she’s already made a short or two), perhaps Cody will pick up the phone.

Review KATIE WALSH

The people working at this mall are literally witches

It’s clear that “Forbidden Fruits” director and co-writer Meredith Alloway has marinated in plenty of ’90s teen movies and the kitschy pop-culture ephemera of that era. Her directorial debut, written with Lily Houghton and based on Houghton’s play “Of the woman came the beginning of sin and through her we all die,” is essentially a synthesis of “The Craft,” “Mean Girls” and “Clueless,” about a coven of catty witches who work at a boutique in a Texas mall.

But in “Forbidden Fruits,” it’s hard to shake the feeling that Alloway’s movie knowledge is just that — easily identifiable iconography without much innovation or depth.

Our clique comes storming down the mall food court in that classic slow-motion strut, letting us know right away what we’re in for. They’re known as the Fruits because they all happen to be named after them. The leader, Apple (Lili Reinhart), operates in the controlling mode of Regina George or Cher Horowitz; her lackeys are alt queen Fig (Alexandra Shipp) and blond bimbo Cherry (Victoria Pedretti). When they realize that a cute pretzel purveyor is named Pumpkin (Lola Tung), they quickly bring her into their circle as a fourth, seemingly only because her name fits the theme.

Apple runs her high-femme coven out of their store Free Eden with an em-



SABRINA LANTOS Independent Film Company and Shudder

LOLA TUNG, left, Victoria Pedretti, Alexandra Shipp and Lili Reinhart play members of a clique/coven.

phasis on iconic women: The girls confess to their martyr Marilyn Monroe in a dressing room and practice dark magic with their panties and a silver cowboy boot. In the interest of helping each other “shine,” Apple also takes a page from Ann Lee and the Shakers — sex and boys are banned and communication is highly controlled.

It’s only when Pumpkin starts uncovering some of the coven’s secrets, including the existence of a former member named Pickle (Emma Chamberlain), that their controversial personal histories involving hexes, poison, fires and hidden boyfriends come to light, and the situation spirals out of control (literally — the climax happens during a tor-

nado).

Alloway and cinematographer Karim Hussain craft a distinctive and unique aesthetic, a gauzy, highly artificial look that underlines the winky referential tone, but one that also lends “Forbidden Fruits” a strangely dreamlike quality that doesn’t always work for the genre.

While the actors, particu-

larly Reinhart and Pedretti, are locked in with the tone and Reinhart delivers the fierceness required of such a role, the pace of “Forbidden Fruits” is at odds with the performers. The film is weirdly slow and sleepy and at least 20 minutes too long. The convoluted story, peppered with various twists, lacks momentum.

A stronger hand in the

edit could have resulted in something more dynamic and engaging, but the plotting is mushy and then rushed. For a witchy horror thriller, it’s heavier on psychological violence than actual scares, and a third-act bloodbath and big reveal can’t save it when we finally get there.

The film’s theatrical provenance reveals itself in long monologues in the Marilyn confessional room and Pedretti delivers one that reveals the depth beyond Cherry’s ditzzy exterior. We can see Houghton’s play in these moments, but then Alloway’s cheeky pop sensibility intervenes, the arch artificiality and ironic tone draining the emotional impact.

“Forbidden Fruits” can’t reconcile all of its influences and just ends up as a collection of references and high style without much staying power — it’s essentially the fast fashion of girly pop horror.

Walsh is a Tribune News Service film critic.

‘Forbidden Fruits’

Rated: R, for strong violent content/gore, sexual content, nudity, language and brief drug use
Running time: 1 hour, 43 minutes
Playing: In wide release